We Drink the Fatal Drop

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34703932.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Vampires, Alternate Universe - Supernatural Elements, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Spooky October Vibes, Temporary Character Death, Or Undeath I should say, Werecats, Injury Recovery

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Summary

When Adora was eighteen, she killed her best friend. It is kind of hard to repair your relationship from there, but when she hits Catra with her car seven years later, she discovers her best friend very much *not undead* and no happier about having been turned into a vampire against her will despite having *'fixed the problem.'*
(Vampire Adora/Werecat Catra Modern AU)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Catra is a werecat in this AU. That means she has a "human" form that she has to use in human society, but she prefers to be half-shifted (which is just her appearance from the show). I've made my own vampire lore, but it's based off a lot of common stuff that you'll find in other vampire media.
> CW: Suicide/suicidal thoughts mention. This AU is a bit angstier than my usual fics, but no darker than "a strange disease like me" or "Lifepoint" were, I'm just putting the warning out there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fucking full moon. Catra growls to herself as she slides through the undergrowth. She kind of wants to just barrel straight through it, but the last thing that she should do is leave a trail that can be followed. Not that anyone is following her tonight, but old habits die hard. She has spent enough time evading supernatural hunters – and human cops – that the habit is engrained in her. She isn't willing to let her guard down just because it has been a few months since anyone caught onto her scent.

After suddenly fleeing work when the full moon pulled the beast out of her, she just might end up on someone's radar again. She picked this area specifically because it is under the protection of a coven and doesn't have any unsanctioned hunters roaming around it, but the coven itself might put a price on her head if they think she risks exposing them to the humans in the area. They would have to fucking catch her first, but she would prefer to not have to move *again*.

She hasn't even had time to look for an apartment yet. Well, the time or the confidence that this area will be safe enough for her to stay for even a six-month lease. She picked the drive-in theatre where she

works specifically because it backs onto some woods where she could make a den. The sound of the movies playing doesnt bother any other businesses or neighborhoods in its somewhat remote location, but more importantly, Catra can just run home after a late shift, but she usually gets out of *sight* first.

She was born a werecat. She had perfect control of her shifting for eighteen years. Then she fucking died. Now she feels the pull of the moon like never before, made weaker by raising from death. She managed to hold it together as long as she was inside the ticket booth, but once she stepped out, she had to bolt and yell some shitty excuse about realizing she was late for something"as she fled straight to the edge of the woods with her fingernails elongating into claws.

She thinks she managed to get out of sight before she dropped to all fours and her entire body was taken by the transformation, but she will only find out when she goes to work again in two days and sweeps the area for the scent of wolfsbane or silver hiding in a hunter's possessions. Hopefully her boss just thinks she needed to shit or something and ran off for privacy, but Catra hasnt gotten many lucky breaks in life.

Okay, that isnt fair . The heartbeat in her chest proves that she has had *some* luck. She managed the near-impossible and regained life from twisted undeath, after all. Life owed that to her after torturing her for eighteen years and then murdering her, though. The only kindness it has ever truly handed her is the fact that she isnt currently sprinting across a highway to an empty den. She wont be alone in her otherwise very lonely home. She has-

She has half a second to process the car horn before the world tilts sideways and goes black.

--

"Fuck. Fuck, fuck, fuck. Fuck!" Adora is basically breathing curses as she beats back her airbag. She doesn't give a shit about the airbag, she's undead and doesn't need it. The werewolf or whatever she just hit is more important. She saw rippling muscles beneath a hulking pelt before the airbag filled her vision. There aren't any natural predators that size in this area. The closest thing they have are bobcats, and this beast could have bit one in half easily, so werewolf seems most likely, especially with the full moon out tonight. She manages to fumble with her seatbelt, throwing open her car door and hurrying forward to inspect the-

Catra. Adora stares, her mouth falling open as her nostrils flare, drawing in the scent of Catra's blood. She may be shifted into her fully feline form, but Adora recognizes her. That's her best friend. There is no one's blood that she knows better in the world, and Catra's is spilling on the *road*. Adora shudders, fighting off both memories and her body's instincts. She has fed recently and she is grateful for it. She thirsts for spilled blood whenever she is low on blood. Even having fed just a few days ago, her body instinctively craves Catra's taste. It was her only meal for eighteen years.

The last time that taste was in her mouth, she was bleeding Catra dry in a bloodlust frenzy. She craves the familiar scent, but the memories of their last encounter make her feel sick. The nausea is grounding, reminding Adora that she had to turn Catra so she would survive the draining. She shouldn't be *able* to bleed now that she is a vampire. A werecat could survive being hit by a car easily, as can a vampire werecat, but something is very wrong with Catra if her blood is flowing.

Adora may be shocked by Catra's sudden appearance, but she needs to make sure that she is okay. She can push her instincts aside if it's to help Catra. She couldn't on the day that she turned her, but there were weeks of extenuating circumstances leading up to her bloodlust frenzy that day. She hurries forward, running her hand down along Catra's side and assessing the damage. Catra is

breathing heavily, but her eyes are closed. When Adora tries to lift one eyelid, it becomes clear that she is unconscious. That- that shouldn't be possible either.

Vampires shouldn't bleed, shouldn't break, and shouldn't sleep – not even by being knocked out. The only way that should be possible is through hibernation, and you can't instantly fall into it like that. This amount of blood loss would warrant hibernating if vampires *could* lose blood like this, but they can't. Their hearts can't pump and make them bleed out even when they receive wounds. Adora can't panic like a human does, her body lacking adrenaline responses – you don't need them when you're the apex predator – but she is still *freaking out* internally as she places a hand on Catra's barrel chest and feels her heartbeat.

She could hear it in her ears and smell her blood circulating, but despite the fact that Adora has some of the best senses of any mammal, she didn't believe what they were telling her until she felt the steady pounding of Catra's heart for herself. It shouldn't be possible, and yet she can't deny – she doesn't sense Catra through the sire bond at all, and she hasn't in over a year. Catra is – or *was* – her fledgling and Adora should have been able to feel her no matter where she was, as long as she was alive.

Adora has never heard of a vampire managing to actually restart their heart, but Catra is unmistakably bleeding, even if Adora can already see her werecat healing factor scabbing over the wounds so they can heal. Adora doesn't know what the fuck is happening with Catra or what state she is in when she *hasn't* just been rammed by an SUV, but right now she has to help her. Werecats naturally have an amazing healing ability, but the impact has crushed Catra's bones.

Adora has to make sure the car still works and then get Catra in it and take her home. Once she has her somewhere stable and can make sure her body is really healing like it should, she can call Glimmer. And then scream. Screaming is all that she wants to do, but it has to wait. She somehow just found Catra in the middle of the

woods. She isn't going to lose her *tiger*, and she sure as hell isn't going to be responsible for her dying *twice*.

Maybe she can combine driving home with screaming actually.

--

Every part of Catra's body hurts. Every time she becomes aware enough to register a new part of her body, the only signals she gets back from it are pain. She draws in a deep, aching breath, and rattles a purr out. It hurts, but there is an edge to it that is almost the good kind of hurt. It's soothing, at least. It lets her body's pain signals calm down so she can actually take stock of her situation. She is lying on her left side, the relatively uninjured one. It is still damaged from hitting the asphalt after the car rammed into her, but the pain from it is nothing compared to her right side.

The broken bones feel like they run the entire length of her body, pain throbbing deep into her tissue. Even with her healing factor, it will take days to get back on her feet. Fuck. If she is lucky, the driver left her on the side of the road to die. She looks like a wild animal, after all, and they don't seem like a responsible person. They were driving with their headlights off at night. If they had been *on*, Catra would have detected their approach despite being absorbed in her thoughts and sprinting through the woods at high speed.

Dammit. Now that her senses are waking up enough to extend beyond her own pain signals, she knows that she is in a building – a scentless one, so this place is kept *clean*. That means they took her somewhere. Hopefully it isn't a proper wildlife rehab center, or at least not one equipped to handle a big cat the size of a puma. Breaking out isn't going to be easy, but she can't stay here. The longer she stays, the greater the risk of her shifting back and exposing the whole community once the full moon passes.

She can drift off for now, though. She doesnt have the strength to move, which means she definitely doesnt have the strength to shift back, and she can still feel the pull of the moon on her. She isnt in danger of discovery yet. Just before her mind fizzes out into darkness again, she registers the impression of another being. Their presence both relieves her and sets her on edge, but she is too far gone to fight back to consciousness, much less register why.

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Adora doesnt scream on the drive back, mostly because she doesnt want to do anything that could upset Catra, even while she is unconscious, but she does hyperventilate. She assesses Catra again once she arrives and determines that she isnt bleeding anymore, though there is blood soaked into the backseat from before her wounds closed. A part of Adora's body still wants it, but mostly she is terrified. She carries Catra to the bedroom as carefully as she can given Catra's size while fully shifted into her puma-like form. Catra never wakes, not even as Adora lies her down in her seldom-used bed.

Adora tries calling Glimmer, but she doesnt get a response. Unlike her – at least now – Glimmer is a dhampir and still needs sleep. It's past midnight. She is probably curled up with her husband and blissfully unaware of Adora having a meltdown on the other end of the farm. As much as Adora loathes asking anything of Angella – she has already done more than enough for her – Adora is staring down at a broken Catra and she needs answers. Angella is a full vampire and doesnt need sleep.

A year ago, Adora felt a massive wash of pain from Catra. It brought Adora to her knees, clutching her chest as she felt more pain through the bond between sire and fledgling than she had ever been in for herself. As suddenly as it started, it ended. It took her ten

minutes of gasping on her living room floor to realize that she couldn't feel Catra at all anymore. The bond was merely a vague pull on her soul until that point, Adora having no desire to try to exert control over Catra through it, but from that moment on it was silent.

When she realized that the bond was broken, she burst into fresh tears, from grief rather than pain this time. Catra never wanted to be a vampire. She hated Adora for turning her. There were only two options: Catra fell into hibernation after something happened that hurt her badly, or she was now dead, likely by her own hand, unable to put up with the torment that Adora cursed her to. Adora broke down with the realization. Eventually, her friends helped to pick her back up, but she swore she would never love again. Catra was to be her one and only for eternity.

Now she is here and *alive*. Adora has to do everything that she can to help her – both with her car-induced injuries and with whatever the hell she did to undo the turning process and break the bond. Adora tries calling Angella, but she doesn't answer her phone either. Adora never thought that she would curse Micah out, but she blames his mortal need for sleep for why Angella doesn't pick up. Either she has her phone on silent to not disturb him or she is lying in bed with him to bond despite how she doesn't need sleep.

Adora could march up to the main house and go knocking on doors, but that means *leaving* Catra. She has one more phone number she can try. Anxiously, she dials the landline that she rarely bothers the owner of. Adora hopes that she will answer, but she doesn't know what time of day it is over there. All she knows is that the house is nestled up in the mountains and that phone service only reached the area shortly after Angella put them in touch via letter. Usually she just gives letters to Angella and after a few weeks Angella gives her back a heavy brown envelope with her response.

"Hello, Adora?" Mara greets, sounding confused. Adora breathes out a desperate sigh of relief. Both Mara and her wife are vampires, but Adora was afraid they would be farming or some shit and not answer the phone. Adora doesn't know where they are, but she knows that

they have livestock that they live off the blood of and that they pass themselves off as regular –if reclusive –farmers. Mara prefers communicating via letters just because she is old and values her privacy deeply, but phone calls can also arrive at inconvenient times.

"I found Catra. And she' s alive," Adora rushes out, bending to place a hand as lightly on Catra's head as she can. She doesn't think her head was struck by the car, but it definitely hit the ground and is likely injured. Her healing factor should at least negate any damage from a concussion quickly . On the other end of the line, Mara draws in a sharp breath.

"Adora, that' s great-" she starts to congratulate, but Adora cuts her off with a growl of frustration, shaking her head despite how Mara can't see it.

"No, I mean she' s *alive* . I hit her with my car and now she's fucking unconscious. She has a *heartbeat*. There's no trace of vampirism in her," Adora corrects her . Everything is silent for a moment, the only sound Catra's heartbeat filling Adora's senses. Adora has never heard of this happening, but if anyone knows about it, it will be Mara. She is two hundred years older than Adora, but importantly, Angella put them in touch so Adora could learn from her because Mara is the only other living higher vampire that Angella knew of.

They are more powerful than regular vampires, but paradoxically , more likely to die. They require more blood to survive and fall into bloodlust easily if they don't get enough to eat. Vampire hunters often put them down for the safety of others. Many covens won't even allow them in their territory because of the potential threat that they pose. Mara and her wife have had to do a lot of research together to dig up what little has been learned about the higher vampires that have lived –and died –previously . If anyone has heard of something like this happening, it will be them.

"It could be possible, but most people don't know that. Any method that you find in a book is either going to kill you completely or transform you into a monster. It takes *a lot* to do it and not lose

yourself. The only successful method that I know of is a dark process," Mara tells her . Adora is certain that if her heart could beat, it would be pounding now as she stares down at Catra with fear clawing at her throat. If Catra found a method that could potentially turn her back into a mortal werecat, she would have taken it despite the potential consequence.

"She looks normal," Adora whispers. *Please tell me that means she succeeded without losing herself* . Adora doesn't feel like she can speak, but she doesn't care what Catra did as long as she is okay now. The room is filled with nothing but Catra's heavy breathing. After several seconds, Adora hears quiet movement on the other end of the line.

"Dearest. We have a situation," Mara says, her voice distant from the receiver. Adora swallows. Mara calling in Light Hope doesn't assure her at all. Light Hope is the oldest living vampire, at least that's known to still be alive. She has long since washed her hands of dealing with community affairs, but she had a vast amount of knowledge even before she met Mara and began researching to help her understand what she is. When there is no answer, people turn to Angella to ask Light Hope for help. Adora listens anxiously as Mara talks with Light Hope, the sound of voices muffled now and indistinguishable. Mara probably put the receiver down to talk with Light Hope, but Adora wishes that she could understand the conversation.

She needs Catra to be okay. Lightly, afraid of aggravating her injuries, she runs a hand down along her coat. Catra's werecat form has always most closely resembled a cougar in size and shape, though werecats don't directly correspond with any cat species. Catra's tabby markings and large, pointed ears are evidence enough of that even with her eyes closed and hiding their mismatched colors. Adora can sense the injuries beneath the surface of Catra's skin, but she can also sense her magic rushing to heal them. It's just needed so many *places* that it will take awhile for her to recover.

"If she looks and senses like a normal werecat, then there's a chance that she did it right, but it isn't a guarantee," Mara's voice cuts into her thoughts, her voice gentle and regretful. It isn't the news that she wants to give Adora. Adora swallows, looking down at the expression on Catra's face, pained even in her sleep. She doesn't look peaceful, but she does look like *her*, sleeping quietly in Adora's bed, right where she belongs. She doesn't look like her mind has fried, though that would explain her sprinting along a dark road in the woods as a cat.

Fuck. Fuck. Adora can't have lost her. She just *found* her. She hasn't seen her since Catra fled upon waking up and finding herself a vampire.

"Mara, I need her to be okay," Adora breathes, her voice broken and laced with tears. She doesn't know what else to say. She doesn't know what to *do*. Mara makes a soft, pained sound.

"Have Micah assess her. He will be able to tell you more about her condition before she wakes. I hope she's okay, but Adora, you need to prepare yourself for the possibility that she won't be all there when she wakes up. She may even attack you. Promise me that you'll defend yourself," Mara asks, her voice coaxing with an undercurrent of worry to it. Adora gives a full body flinch, looking down at Catra's chest slowly rising and falling with her heavy breathing.

"No," Adora responds. She doesn't know that she would and she can't lie to Mara.

"Adora, please-" Mara starts to beg, but Adora lets out a shaky breath, laced with tears, and she cuts off.

"Mara, if she really isn't in there, I don't want to spend eternity with the knowledge that I drove her to turn herself into a monster just to escape what I did to her. Could you fight Light Hope if you had to?" Adora asks her, a bit more venom in her voice than she intended, but all her anger is truthfully directed at herself. On the other of the line,

Mara is silent for a moment. Adora is just about to gloat when Mara speaks up.

"Yes. Because she would want me to live if she didn't," Mara finally says, her voice quiet. Adora swallows.

Well, that's where Light Hope and Catra differ.

--

Catra wakes up growling. There's a *man* here now. She is too out of it to register much, but she can sense two forms, one human and one decidedly not. Catra's eyes fly open as she curls her lip back and roars. The internal pain is intense, but she has to defend herself. The man quickly pulls back and bumps into the wall. The space is tight and he can't flee far. Oddly, it looks like a bedroom-

"Catra, it's okay," Adora assures. Catra feels her body shut down as it registers her voice. Or maybe just from pain. After several moments of blankness, she comes back to herself. She passed out or something, but now she blinks her eyes open and finds the man cautiously running a hand along her body again. She is still shifted and *fuck* does it still hurt, but it isn't the kind of overwhelming pain that shuts down all her senses like she experienced the last time that she partially awoke. If she had been in any less pain, she would have registered the specific kind of traceless existence in the space that vampires leave.

She is intimately familiar with it, but she especially would have registered the traces of Adora in the air. Seven years can do nothing to unwrite how well she knows the only woman that she has ever loved. Catra slits an eye open warily so she can watch the bearded man. The man, catching the movement of her blue eye opening, stills. He doesn't freeze like a prey animal, instead looking to her with

caution and respect, like he is waiting to see what she does. Adora is in the room too somewhere behind her, but Catra is focused on the potential threat right now.

Adora could be a threat too, but not at the moment. Catra senses no bloodlust from her and Shadow Weaver isn't here. She is too weak to compel Adora into doing anything over a distance even with the sire bond between them. Adora herself couldn't figure out how to do that to Catra over the six years that she had the power to and she was stronger than Shadow Weaver even back when she was just a dhampir. Once she became a higher vampire, it should have been easy, but Catra never felt magically pulled back to Adora and thus their captor.

"I'm checking your injuries. I won't hurt you," the man says. His voice is low and assuring. Catra instantly doesn't trust him. He radiates a friendly aura. No one just *looks* nice like that. He has to be up to something. Catra growls despite the way it makes her injuries throb. Behind her, she hears movement, and then the bed dips as Adora seemingly climbs onto it with her. A gentle, *familiar* hand runs over Catra's ears. They are probably the only part of her that is uninjured.

"He's going to help, Catra. It's okay. You're safe. After he assesses you, he'll leave and then it will just be you and me. I promise," Adora assures her, rhythmically stroking her ear from the base to the tip. Catra grumbles a little, but she lets her growl drop. She is too tired and injured to question what is going on or how Adora found her. The bond should be broken. If Catra went through all that and Adora can still hunt her through it-

She can't think about that now. It makes the mangled heart in her chest beat too quickly. She focuses on the hand providing the only comforting sensation she has at the moment instead. She doesn't dare take her eyes off the man still, but after a moment of her lying there silently, he returns to his inspection. Every time he touches her it hurts, but everything hurts anyway. Her bones knitting back together isn't a *pleasant* sensation. She wants to ask if a fucking eighteen-wheeler hit her, but she isn't in any shape to shift and ask

questions. Her first one would be *where the fuck did you come from* anyway.

"She is obviously injured, but her body is responding exactly as it should. A few days of bed rest and she will be back on her feet. She appears to be a healthy werecat aside from her injuries. I cant accurately assess her mental state unless she shifts back, but her responsiveness is a good sign," the man says, looking up and talking to Adora instead of Catra. Catra curls her lip. She's *right here*. Clearly he knows how werecreatures work. She is cognizant enough to insult the grey in his beard. She growls to show her displeasure.

"Shh, you're okay. A few days in bed wont kill you. Ill take care of you," Adora promises her, gently petting her cheek. Her touch is featherlight. This side of her face didnt actually get hit, so it just feels nice. The pain and exhaustion get to her and her eyes drift closed again, just like they did when she first heard Adora's voice. Despite everything, a part of her just trusts that if anyone can keep her safe, it's Adora.

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Micah talks with her in hushed tones on the doorstep after he finishes checking Catra over. He says that everything he saw was a good sign, but that she should still prepare herself for Catra being *different* once she is healed up enough to shift back. Adora doesnt care. Catra recognizes her. She even quieted when Adora spoke to her. She still knows her. Adora waves Micah off, not wanting to leave Catra alone for even a moment.

She normally tries not to abuse her powers, but she transformed into a bat and flew as fast as she could to go knock on the back door of the main house when she went to fetch Micah. She was in turmoil at the idea of Catra being lost to her right when she had been lifted by

the hope that she had found her again. Adora needed someone to look at her and tell her that she would be okay. Apparently she looks exactly like a normal werecat, which is a good sign that whatever she did was successful.

Adora busies herself with fetching Catra water, but she is still unconscious when she returns to the bedroom. Adora leaves the glass on the bedside table and sits down at her computer to research grocery stores in her area. She doesn't have food. There's an untouched jar of peanut butter that she doesn't know the source of, but that's it. She doesn't even know where people shop for food. She sees food in superstores when she goes there for other things, but she knows grocery stores exist, she just doesn't know the names of any.

She doesn't know anything about the food that mortals need. She may have been born a dhampir and thus capable of eating, but she didn't *need* it, so Shadow Weaver wasn't going to waste resources on it while she was slowly inoculating Adora with her venom. The transformation from dhampir to higher vampire took years, but once it was done, Adora would have become sick trying to eat food just like any other vampire, so even after escaping from Shadow Weaver's clutches, she hasn't learned much.

She did grow up with Catra, though, and Shadow Weaver made sure to keep her well-fed. She had to if Catra's healing factor was going to keep up with two hungry vampires. Adora vaguely remembers a few of the dishes that Catra used to make for herself. She googles them and puts together a list of ingredients that she'll need. She doesn't actually know how to cook and she can't tell if these dishes are complicated or if she's just completely out of her element. She is in the middle of googling easy recipes for a first-time chef when Catra groans softly. Instantly, Adora sets her computer aside and scrambles to her bedroom, appearing at Catra's bedside only a moment later.

She watches Catra's muscles tense and twitch as she snarls a little and then her eyes blink open. Her gaze is unfocused at first but

eventually her eyes wander up to meet Adora's. Adora smiles hopefully at her, reaching down and gently petting her ears. Catra watches her hand approach, but she doesnt seem wary . Her eyes fall half-lidded as Adora pets her. Okay, so she likes that still. Adora looks up, out the window. The moon is falling low in the sky now. Dawn will break soon. The windows are treated and Adora is in no danger inside, but that limits her options when it comes to going to get food for Catra.

The farm estate has covered walkways between all the houses so Angella and Adora can still get around during the day, but any grocery store that Adora finds likely wont have a covered parking lot. She cant even abuse her ability as a higher vampire to transform into a bat because, while it may allow her to brave the daylight, she would cause a panic at the store. Shell have to go grocery shopping this evening when the sun is low in the sky and she can just use her parasol. The stores should still be open then.

Catra begins purring, immediately drawing Adora out of her thoughts as her attention snaps back to her. Catra's eyes are open, seeming bright and aware as she watches Adora pet her. She is probably only purring to self-soothe, but Adora can pretend that it has something to do with her presence. Catra cant talk right now to tell her otherwise or yell at her again for biting her.

"I have water for you. No food yet, but Ill get some. Can you sit up to drink, or do you want me to help you?" Adora asks. She isnt sure how well Catra can respond, or if she can even understand her, but she hopes so. Catra's eyes narrow at her. Alright, so she understood that and she didnt like it. She probably doesnt feel up to moving, but she needs fluids. Her healing factor and the moon have definitely helped, but werecats still need food.

"You lost blood, Catra. You need to drink. Ill help you," Adora tells her, settling on the side of the bed and carefully reaching down to cradle her head. It may be the only part of her relatively undamaged. It is scraped up and connected to her broken shoulder, but if Adora can crane it up enough for Catra to lap up some water, it wont be

too bad. Catra growls as Adora carefully tries to tilt her head up, but she doesnt move. Adora doesnt think that she is in danger of being bitten. She just hopes it doesnt hurt Catra too much.

Despite her protests, Catra drinks when Adora manages to get the glass in position. Catra forces several long laps with her pink tongue, having to navigate around the glass that Adora brought her, before she closes her mouth and growls at Adora again. Adora would really like her to drink more, but she compromises and sets the glass aside, gently lowering Catra's head back down to the pillow. Catra's eyes immediately begin to slip closed. Adora sighs, a bit relieved.

Every sign points to Catra still being herself. Adora will just have to wait until she can shift back to confirm it. For now, she gently pets Catra's ears as she drifts off.

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Catra drifts in and out a bit, always registering Adora somewhere nearby before she slips away again. It isnt until after dawn has broken that she wakes for real. Adora is in the next room, so Catra has a few moments to breathe heavily as she forces her body to shift through the pain. Shifting doesnt normally hurt, but she doesnt normally do it this *injured* either. With the moon gone, though, she needs to shift back so her broken bones will fall back in place and heal properly.

Probably. Catra's medical knowledge when it comes to werecats is kind of shit. She knows a lot about vampires and a bit about humans, but she has been making everything else up as she goes for her entire life. Shadow Weaver didnt care if Catra was healthy or broken as long as she was alive to be Adora's good little blood bag. Catra's knowledge is either geared towards vampires or has been freshly acqired in the last few years since Adora turned her .

The pain from shifting when she is this hurt is immense. She grits her teeth and bears it – she is *experienced* with that – but she must not be completely quiet because when she is done, lying naked in the bed and panting, she registers a sheet being pulled over her. Adora came running. Catra wishes she could still growl, but she wasn't in great control as she shifted and she went all the way to human form. She lacks the vocal chords for true growling, but that fucking *hurt* and she isn't eager to do it again soon just to get back to her preferred halfway form. Human will have to do for now.

"Catra, fuck, lie still. You shouldn't have done that. Are you okay? Can you breathe?" Adora asks, her words coming out in a rush as she leans over her, hands hovering awkwardly above her as she just barely manages to hold herself back from touching Catra. Catra squeezes her eyes shut and curls her lip. She only has human vocal chords, but she still manages to grind out an approximation of a growl.

"Don't fucking lecture me about what I *'should'* do," she grits out, opening her eyes to fix Adora with a firm glare. Adora freezes, blinking down at her before she drops her hands back down to her sides, straightening a little. Adora looks paler than usual. Catra likes to think that she has cowed her, but in all likelihood she just isn't getting enough blood.

That makes Catra feel a bit smug. She likes the idea of Adora struggling to feed herself without Catra. Well, no, she doesn't, not when she thinks about the reality of it like that. She actually fucking hates it. She just wants Adora to miss her and realize how badly she needed Catra. She wants Adora to realize what a fucking mistake she made turning her. She wants-

She wants Adora to explain how the fuck she found her.

"Where are we?" Catra grits out, darting her gaze around all of the room that she can see. She is lying on her back now. She vaguely remembers rolling during the painful transformation. She wasn't in control of her movement then – she would have stayed put if she

was – but the change in angle is kind of nice. It gives her a better view of the tiny bedroom they are in. It's definitely Adora's – there's a fucking oil painting of a horse on the wall – but it doesn't resemble anywhere that Shadow Weaver kept them.

The walls are white, seeming old but well-cared for. There is a large window despite the room barely having the space for an end table to be squeezed between the queen size bed and the wall. The door is open, but all Catra can see out of it is another white wall. Shifted into her human form, her senses are diminished – there is a *reason* that she prefers to live in her halfway form – but she never detected anything in the air other than Adora before she shifted back.

"The Lunet estate. I live here. It's safe. The owner is a vampire, but her husband is a human and her daughter is a dhampir married to another human. They're good people," Adora tells her, cautiously stepping closer to sit on the very edge of the bed and reach for something on the end table. Catra scoffs at her words, roaming her eyes over the room again. That explains how old this place looks. The furniture is definitely antique. She can see a window in her periphery, but aside from greenery and tree branches swaying gently in the breeze, she can't make anything out without turning her head.

"Where's Shadow Weaver?" Catra croaks out as Adora's hand reappears in her line of sight, freezing halfway through extending the glass towards her. Adora's eyes are wide as she stares down at her. Catra can't believe she is surprised. The first thing that Adora should have said to her was Shadow Weaver's precise location. She should have given her fucking coordinates without prompting just to assure Catra that she wasn't close enough to bleed her dry.

"I *fixed my problem*, but she can still compel you. You aren't safe if she's nearby. Where is she?" Catra snaps back, suddenly having enough energy to get mad. Maybe it is best that she is in her human form. Her tail would definitely be lashing if she had one right now and it would probably hurt. Adora swallows, quickly shaking her head and reaching out. Catra growls – more like groans, but whatever – as

Adora reaches out and cups her cheek, her expression pinched and serious as she makes eye contact with Catra.

"She's dead. Staked by hunters, but I killed her, really," Adora says, her voice growing weak and small by the end. She sounds *ashamed*. Catra feels her jaw drop open as she gapes up at Adora. Catra might not feel as jubilant at that news as she always thought she would, but fuck, she isn't *mad* at Adora for it. Actually, maybe she is. Catra ran immediately after Adora turned her, but it took her five fucking years to get a real lead on how to reverse the turning process so Shadow Weaver couldn't compel her through Adora.

If Shadow Weaver has been dead the entire time, then all that work was for *nothing*. Catra was never afraid of Adora choosing to use her sire compulsion abilities on her. Shadow Weaver was Adora's sire, though, and Catra couldn't take Shadow Weaver having control over her through her bond with Adora. She didn't try to escape before Adora turned her because she didn't want to leave Adora, but she was terrified of what Shadow Weaver could do to her through the chain of compulsion.

"When?" she asks. Adora winces, looking away. Her fingertips are quivering slightly on Catra's cheek.

"I tried to go after you when you ran. She used the sire bond to compel me back. She wanted to let you go since you weren't… *useful* as a blood bag anymore. When hunters came to the area a few months later, I made sure she couldn't compel me and we fought. I won. I ran afterwards, but I felt when the hunters found her and finished her. I couldn't do it myself, but I made it an easy job for them," Adora explains, her voice low and throaty. Catra swallows. She can imagine what that fight must have been like.

Shadow Weaver was a fucking pathetic vampire on her own, but she still held power over Adora. She needed either eye contact or her voice to exert it, but either one should have been enough to stop Adora. Catra can't imagine what Adora did to stop Shadow Weaver from compelling her, but maybe she doesn't want to know. Catra's

head hurts too much to think about this and her eyes are stinging weirdly.

"W ater," she croaks out. Adora turns back to her so fast that she almost spills the cup still in her hand, but she manages not to pour it on Catra as she reaches behind her and gently lifts her up so she can drink. Her body is still made from broken bones, but the pain is definitely better since shifting. The water helps too. When Adora lowers her back down, she is feeling marginally better. Something is pulling at her-

Oh.

"B ack door ," Catra rasps out, her eyes already falling closed. She only needs to stay awake for a few moments more and then she can be comfortable. No matter how she feels about all that she did to get a heartbeat back – and especially the lonely years that she went through in the process – Shadow W eaver can't get her anymore and Adora isn't a threat to her on her own. There's another vampire on the property who could be a risk, but Adora would probably protect her. If not, she has backup now that she knows without a doubt will defend her to the death.

Maybe all those years were worth it just for that, actually.

"What?" Adora asks, her confusion clear . Catra's order was cryptic, but she isn't up to talking much right now . J ust thinking about Shadow Weaver has drained her.

"Open the backdoor ," Catra repeats, annoyance tinging her voice. She doesn't have a lot of energy and she doesn't want to waste it on repeating herself. Adora hesitates for a moment more, but she can likely detect Catra's fading light, because after a moment she stands and leaves the room. Catra doesn't see Adora approach the backdoor with her own eyes, but she still sees Adora blinking down at the shape unfamiliar to her on the other side.

After a few long moments of staring, Adora opens the door. Catra settles back into her own head as Melog darts past Adora, making a beeline for the bedroom. They are shrunk down to be inconspicuous, but even the light shift in the mattress from them hopping up on it is soothing. Safe. Now she can finally rest.

"You *stole a witch's familiar*?" Adora demands, her voice incredulous, as she walks back into the room. Catra scowls at the ceiling, opening her golden eye to glare at Adora, standing at the foot of the bed and gaping at the cat now tucked against Catra's mostly-undamaged ankle. Melog hisses for her, causing Adora to shy back a little, though not as far as is warranted. Not that Melog will attack her – Catra doesn't want them to – but a hissing cat shouldn't be fucked with.

"I didn't *steal* them, she made them for me out of mud," Catra shoots back. Melog is far more than mud now, but they started as a homunculus before they imprinted on Catra. She needed them in order to have a chance of surviving the process that let her regain her life, but she has grown to value them for very different reasons, even if she is grateful right now that she will heal faster with them at her side.

"I needed a fucking companion after my last one bled me dry," she snipes, closing her eyes again. Adora draws in a sharp breath despite how she doesn't need to fucking breathe. Yeah, Catra hasn't let that go. She knows that she would have done the same damn thing and turned Adora if she drained her too much, but it's hard to get over someone being responsible for your murder. She just tries to remind herself that Shadow Weaver was the one ultimately responsible for starving Adora to point where the bloodlust took her over when she finally let her feed again.

"I'm so fucking sorry, Catra," Adora whispers. Catra swallows, squeezing her eyes shut just a little tighter. Sure she is. Of course she is. She didn't mean to do it. Catra's head is a tangled mess right now.

"I'm still processing that Shadow W eaver is dead, Adora. I don't have room for this right now," Catra tells her . She really doesn't. She still doesn't even know how she got here, but she is fucking ex hausted. Melog is growling again, their tail lashing as they try to look threatening from their position at Catra's feet. They just want Adora to leave her alone so she can heal. It's what she needs. Come tonight she can worry about every other problem in her life.

With her senses dulled, she doesn't hear Adora silently pad away . She is startled when she speaks up again and her voice comes from the doorway.

"Okay . I'll be in the nex t room. The house is small. I'll hear it even if you just turn over. Say my name and I'll come running," Adora tells her, her voice soft. Catra's heart is thudding loudly in her ears, but she just sniffs in response. She really hates her human form. It gives vampires the drop on her while her senses are limited. Melog is here, though. They'll guard her .

Melog purrs to her as the bedroom door closes and Adora – presumably – walks away . Catra lets herself sigh and focus on Melog's presence. She isn't going to fall asleep again, at least not q uickly , but she really needs to just rest and *proces* . She has been through fucking enough today. She just wants to sleep until her head – and heart – stop hurting.

She's not a vampire anymore, though. She can't nap for the few centuries that it would take. The afternoon will have to be enough.

Chapter End Notes

> Note on rating: I'm not yet sure how ex plicit this fic will be, so I currently have it rated M, though I think it will end up with one smut scene. I'll change the rating if I need to and put a warning on the chapter that includes the smut if it does happen.
> I also don't know how many chapters this will be, but I'm betting 4-5, so I put the lower estimate on it and will adjust it as needed.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> This fic is dedicated to every single piece of vampire media I've ever consumed in my life. They all inspired the lore for it lol. Especially whichever one my old boss used to put on and watch on slow days. I'm not actually sure if it was Vampire Diaries or True Blood because I didn't watch it myself, but I found how the powers seemed to work for it interesting. There's also a vampire book I read in high school that got a movie later that was probably More influential, but I don't even remember its name now.
> Adjusted the chapter count to where I Think it will end up. It could still change though.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer and Bow have their own property on the farm estate and weren't woken up by Adora flying to the main house at two in the morning, but once they do wake up, they must hear the news from Micah because they start blowing up Adora's relatively-unused phone. Adora scrambles to silence it so it won't bother Catra and texts back what little information that she has: Catra has fixed her problem', somehow made a deal with a witch for a familiar , and is still very much pissed at Adora for killing her.

After Adora explains that she has no idea how Catra is alive, Bow helpfully reminds her that Catra, unlike her, has things she needs to do to *stay* that way. Adora points out that she can't go out to get her food with the sun high in the sky, but Bow is an actual fucking angel on Earth and offers to cook a large breakfast and bring some over for Catra. Maybe he just doesn't want Adora to burn the property down trying to cook, but Adora is grateful nonetheless. Catra is awake when Bow and Glimmer make their way over . Adora can

sense her, drifting in and out but starkly aware when a light knock rings out on Adora's front door.

"How is she?" Glimmer asks when Adora opens the door, eyeing the wall into Adora's bedroom warily. Adora shrugs, knowing her expression must be a bit pained as she opens the door to the fridge so Glimmer and Bow can drop off their plastic containers with meals inside.

"I hit her with a fucking SUV, Glimmer. She's broken everywhere a werecat can be and live. I would be pissy too," Adora responds. Pissy is kind of Catra's default to be honest, but she has definitely cranked it up a few notches today. Adora can't blame her for that or anything else that she is mad about. There is a reason Adora never tried to go hunt her down even after she dealt with Shadow Weaver. Well, that and the fact that she needed to find a source of blood quickly. Once she found the coven and had blood secured, it was hard to leave to go chasing after the pull on her soul Catra had. She was terrified of getting strung out again and entering bloodlust while she was hunting her down.

She certainly wasn't going to compel Catra to come to *her*. She doesn't even know how she would go about doing that, but she does know that it would have been the worst thing that she could do. The moment that she broke the spell, Catra would run again, and she would hate Adora even more for that than she does for killing her. Adora at least didn't *mean* to hurt her. She didn't mean for any of it to happen. The only thing that she chose was fighting Shadow Weaver months later when hunters were drawn to the area.

They had been forced to start attacking random humans for blood, but they never lasted more than a few weeks after Shadow Weaver kidnapped them, and the string of disappearances drew attention. Adora couldn't keep hurting and *killing* people. If Shadow Weaver was right and normal vampires would put Adora down for being a higher vampire, then sobeit. She would take the risk of breaking free and finding a coven to latch herself onto. She didn't care what they

did to her – they wouldn't let her hurt anyone else, and that was all that mattered.

She really hopes that Catra doesn't ask what she did to make sure Shadow Weaver couldn't use her voice to compel her when Adora fought her. Admitting that she had chosen to hurt one last person was bad enough. She doesn't want to give the details of what she did. Sneaking up behind Shadow Weaver with a blindfold around her head and the knife in her hand, knowing she intended to slit her throat, made Adora feel sick. She tells herself that it saved others – from Shadow Weaver and from *her* – and she knows it is true, but the guilt still comes for her when she is lying alone in her bed at night.

Said bed is currently occupied by a deeply broken werecat, but Adora fears that she will be alone in it again as soon as Catra can walk. She wouldn't blame Catra for not trusting her , but seven years of loneliness did nothing to break the attachment to Catra that Adora formed in childhood. Adora always loved her. She can't imagine that Catra feels the same now. She thanks Glimmer and Bow as she bids them farewell, but the words sound hollow in the face of her inner turmoil.

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Catra spends the morning processing while she drifts in and out. She doesn't really sleep, but she is aware of little. With Melog back at her side, she feels like she can finally rest as well as *think*. She certainly has a lot to process.

Shadow Weaver is dead. Catra isn't sad about it – the woman was a fucking *monster* – but she isn't gloating with victory like she always thought she would be either. Stockholm syndrome or some bullshit makes her unable to cry tears of joy at her freedom. Their tormentor

was with them for their entire lives – Catra and Adora were both *days* old when Shadow Weaver snatched each of them for the purpose of feeding off of and siring respectively – and it feels weird to think that she is just gone.

Part of Catra has been so tormented by her for so long that she can't quite believe it. Her doubts whisper that Adora has been compelled by Shadow Weaver into lying to her so she will let down her guard and walk into a death trap, but Adora wouldn't be able to act so naturally if that were the case. She wouldn't even be walking normally. Her movements always became twitchy whenever Shadow Weaver compelled her, as if her body was moving without her commanding it to and she was trying to fight it.

As weird as it is to think that Shadow Weaver is gone, it is almost harder to process that Adora is here and Catra doesn't have to be afraid of her. Well, afraid of Shadow Weaver acting through her. Adora never wanted to hurt her before. She had *control* over Catra for five years through the sire bond and still didn't hurt her. Catra, for a few minutes, was mad about all she went through to regain a heartbeat once she learned that Shadow Weaver was long dead, but now she is relieved again. She trusts Adora not to choose to hurt her, but she doesn't like the idea of anyone having control over her.

Catra is fucking *free*. Bed-bound and broken – the whole Shadow Weaver thing actually distracted her from the hit-by-a-car thing for a minute – but otherwise free. She can stop fucking running. Well, stop running on the off chance that Adora or Shadow Weaver catches her. Now she just has to worry about hunters, but they shouldn't be much of an issue for a werecat. She might not be able to fight the pull of the full moon anymore, but she is still in control of herself when she shifts. She doesn't revert to a wild animal and she isn't going to attack anybody. As long as she stays out of sight, she shouldn't have issues.

She would like to – for fucking once – get to just be a *person*. She has a chance at that now. She didn't expect to feel free the next time that she saw Adora. After she managed to get her blood flowing

again, she daydreamed about them finding each other, but Shadow Weaver still had control over Adora. It wouldn't be safe for either of them. It seemed like they were doomed from the moment that the hag touched them for the first time. Now...they're not. Now they're here. In a tiny house, but *Adora's* house. And apparently, Adora was the one to hit her with a car.

That explains how Adora "found" her, but Catra was reeling so much between her injuries and waking up to Adora's voice, it hadn't really occurred to her. When she hears a knock on the door, she finally forces herself through shifting again so she can reach her preferred halfway form and have access to all her senses again. She listens to Adora greet the guests quietly at the door. Sniffing the air, Catra realizes it is a human and a dhampir. Probably that daughter and husband that Adora told her about. Listening in on their conversation, though brief, brings some clarity.

Catra has trouble focusing on what is being said, though. They brought food. Fuck, she is starving. Of course Adora doesn't have any food of her own, she doesn't need it, but Catra is suddenly ravenous knowing a meal is close. She eavesdrops as, at her feet, Melog stands and shakes, rippling out their coat and growing in size while Adora complains about Catra's bitchiness. Catra would laugh if it wasn't guaranteed to be painful. She has always been a bitch. Adora should be used to it, but maybe the seven years apart softened her.

By the time that Adora has received instructions for how to reheat the food from the pair and is wishing them goodbye, Melog has made their way to the head of the bed and is helping to nudge Catra up into a sitting position so she can eat. It hurts far more than shifting again did. Catra groans with pain. Predictably, Adora barely takes the time to close the front door before she comes running.

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Adora was distracted by Glimmer and Bow's departure, *clearly*, because when she runs to investigate the noise in the bedroom, she finds that Catra is sitting up and sporting the cat ears that Adora is used to her having. Adora freezes in the doorway as Catra glares at her, seeming to dare her to say anything about her sitting up, but Adora is breathless despite the fact that she doesn't actually need to *breathe.* She is seeing the woman she has always loved again for the first time in seven years and it feels heart stopping.

Catra was always most comfortable like this, so Adora loves her the most like this, and most of her memories are of this version of Catra. Catra's hair is inexplicably short now and she isn't exactly as Adora remembers her, but Adora's fluster isn't helped by the fact that the sheet fell down to pool around Catra's waist when she sat up and she doesn't seem to have covering herself back up high on her priority list. Adora is, not for the first time, very grateful that she can't blush as she forces herself to tear her eyes from Catra.

There's also the giant cat - not dissimilar in shape and size to Catra's fully shifted form, though that's where the similarities end - that her familiar has expanded to. They are seemingly helping Catra to sit up, turning to blink at Adora with interest when they finish. Adora has had questions about them ever since she saw the cat at her backdoor, but she wanted to give Catra the space she needed to think about what Adora told her. Shadow Weaver being gone is almost bigger news than Catra somehow managing to reverse the turning process, and Adora didn't know that was even possible.

"Do you want food?" Adora asks, because she does still have priorities. She can start quizzing Catra after she has eaten. Catra's ears twitch back – fuck, Adora *missed* her – and she makes a face that makes Adora smile just from the familiarity of it. Her nose wrinkles adorably and her lip curls a little. She wants food, but she is annoyed by the idea of admitting it. She hates admitting that she needs something. "I'll reheat it. I'll be right back," Adora promises her. Catra doesn't have to actually say anything. She will take care of

her happily. The corner of Catra's lip twitches, her aura satisfied. Adora smiles to herself as she turns and heads back to the kitchen.

She rarely uses her own microwave and every time she did, she had Glimmer or Bow within sight to correct her if she did it wrong, but it isn't *that* complicated. At least, Bow's instructions weren't. The biggest challenge is remembering where she stashed the silverware when she moved into what used to be a guesthouse. She rinses it off while she waits for the microwave to beep and then brings everything into the bedroom. Catra's eyes are bright and ravenous – it is unfortunately a look on her that Adora knows well – but she doesn't move when Adora brings her the food, just watching Adora bring it closer.

"Do you want help?" Adora asks as she places the container in Catra's lap. Catra growls lowly as she carefully lifts her left hand and reaches out just far enough to take the fork from Adora. Adora holds it out to her so she doesn't have to move much, but that's a clear *no*. Catra snatches it and then stabs her food pointedly with her fork. She doesn't seem to have any trouble taking a bite while glaring at Adora, though pain signals are still pouring off of her. Catra could always fight through anything to be stubborn, though. Adora raises her hands defensively.

"I already hurt you enough, I just want to minimize the pain that you're in now. I know you can eat for yourself," she placates. Catra twitches and looks back down at the meal in her lap, seeming determined to ignore Adora now as she sets to eating like she is starving. Adora hopes that she is just hungry from using up her energy stores to heal. This is her first meal today, but Adora is hoping that she ate enough yesterday. She has no idea what the last few years have been like for Catra, but they can't have been as bad as the years previous.

"Bow's a good cook, huh?" Adora tries as the meal disappears quickly beneath Catra's fork. She actually has no idea if he is. She knows Glimmer and Angella are terrible at it because they get ribbed during the family dinners that Angella and Adora sit in on just for the

company. Gunmmer has mentioned how much better Bow is at cooking than her, so he's probably decent at least. Catra pauses to snort and send Adora a narrow-eyed look before she takes another bite a touch *angrily*.

"Is he your new blood bag?" Catra sneers when she finishes chewing. Adora startles, recoiling just a little. Catra's ears pin back and she ducks her head ever so slightly as she refocus on her food. It's almost as if she is apologetic, but that was definitely called for.

"No. Angella, the owner of this place, is the leader of the local coven. She gets me blood bags from the coven's donors. It takes double the amount a regular vampire needs, so she fabricated a sister for me in the records to get me the extra without making my status public knowledge, but it's all freely given and I don't have to hurt anybody," Adora tells her. To her surprise, Catra's head snaps up and she stares at Adora. Adora blinks back down at her for a moment before she registers the edge of fear in Catra, her body tense and her scent conflicted. Then it clicks for her.

"Covens and hunters aren't like Shadow Weaver taught us, Catra. Angella and her coven can be trusted. They've been supplying me with blood for five years," Adora tells her. Catra actually scoffs, scraping her fork on the edge of the tupperware container to get the last bits of the meal while she scowls. Shadow Weaver wanted a sire because she wasn't a strong vampire on her own and thus needed to have another under her control to act as a guard dog, but the hunters that Adora was raised to fight weren't monsters.

They were police. Actually, they're better than that. Human police can be pretty shitty. Hunters keep everyone – vampire, werecreature, witch, and human alike – safe from anyone who is abusing their abilities. Adora herself helps with coven enforcement now. She is relieved to know that they will stop her if she ever falls into a bloodlust again. She shouldn't as long as no one forces starvation on her again, but it helps to ease her guilt. Part of her dedication to the job is because she is determined to make up for the people she has hurt by helping to save more now.

"I know that, idiot. I knew it *then*. You were the only one bought in," Catra grumbles. Adora winces, looking away. Catra was afraid too, but she did suspect that Shadow Weaver was lying about everything. She tried to convince Adora of it, but it was hard when she knew as much – and as little – as Adora and wasn't confident she was right. Adora hunches her shoulders.

"My point is, we're safe here. I'm good friends with Glimmer and Bow, and Angella provides me with a place to live in exchange for helping her enforce coven by-laws. I have plenty to eat and I'm not a threat anymore," Adora tells her, trailing off quietly. It's hard to say that to someone she fucking killed, but she won't ever let herself get to that state again. She has a choice now, and she will always choose not to hurt anyone again. Catra is silent, her ears pinning back as she looks away. Adora closes her eyes, desperately searching for something to cut off the spiral of bad thoughts threatening to take her over.

"Catra, how are you alive right now?" Adora tells her, opening her eyes to watch Catra scowl. She drops her fork into the container and pointedly pokes at its edge. Adora bends to take it from her, but then she stands there expectantly, peering down at her. Catra, predictably, doesn't want to answer the question. She turns her face away, but Adora isn't going to be deterred so easily. She pointedly shuffles around the bed to put herself back into Catra's line of sight. Catra immediately scowls.

"None of your fucking business. I managed to undo what you did to me. Melog helped and that's all you need to know," Catra tells her, flicking an ear towards the large cat beside her. The cat – Melog, apparently – mews loudly and leans to carefully lick Catra's cheek. Catra's face relaxes a little and she purrs in response. Clearly she likes the familiar, probably even more than she likes Adora at the moment. Adora swallows. She likes seeing Catra happy, but she's *worried*.

"Do you still need lifeforce from others? Are there long-term effects? Are you mortal again?" Adora asks. If she had a heartbeat, it would

be racing now as she runs through the possibilities. Despite Melog's nuzzling, Catra scowls again. Melog pulls back to narrow their eyes at Adora, their strange mane shifting hues to a threatening red as they fix Adora with a glare to rival their owner's.

"I'm *alive*. I eat food and do regular shit. I'm fucking fine, Adora. Aside from, you know, all the broken bones. Why the fuck were you driving without your headlights on?" Catra demands. She hisses through her teeth as a twitch of the blanket signals her tail just gave an irritated –and painful– lash. Adora winces. Yeah, hitting Catra with her car is quite possibly the worst way for them to reunite, but it was an *accident*.

So was killing her.

"Because I'm not human and I don't need them to see at night? They kind of fuck with my vision, and I didn't think there would be any cops to ticket me on a backroad. Why were you werecat running through the woods?" Adora asks. Catra huffs, looking away. After a moment, Melog turns their head to follow her line of sight. They mew loudly, drawing Adora's attention as they focus in on the glass of water on the end table. Apparently Catra is thirsty but doesn't want to say it.

Adora circles around the bed to fetch the glass, holding it out to Catra. Catra takes it for herself and lifts it to her own lips this time. Steadily, she drains it completely. Okay, Adora still wants answers, but that's good. She takes the empty glass back from Catra and sets it on the end table again along with the empty food container. She will get Catra more water soon, but for now she turns back to Catra and looks to her pointedly. To her surprise, Catra seems a bit embarrassed.

"I'm *fine*, but ever since reversing the turning process, I can't control my shifting on the full moon. I'm not actually mortal, I just managed to purge the vampire venom from my blood and get a heartbeat back. Melog helps sustain me. That's why the witch made them for me, to substitute what I lost when I purged you from my system," Catra tells her, reluctantly. Adora swallows. Okay, that introduces

more questions than answers, but still immortal is probably good, right? Catra looks more worn than she did before Adora turned her, but Adora is willing to bet most of that is because of the car wreck and not ageing.

Aside from her injuries and short hair, she looks much the same. Dhampirs age and die just like mortals. For their childhoods, they grew up appearing to be the same age, but they knew that at some point that Shadow Weaver would start poisoning Adora with small doses of her venom in an attempt to create a higher vampire without biting her, which would most likely just kill her as her own magic fought Shadow Weaver's. Whenever the process was done, Adora would either be dead or frozen in immortality, no longer aging while Catra continued to live—and die.

Both of them avoided thinking about it. If Catra has managed to stay stuck while cutting out her need for blood, then that might just be the best-case scenario, at least when it comes to them getting to stay together. Adora isn't sure that Catra wants that anymore, but she hopes so. She hopes Catra will at least want to be friends. She reaches towards Catra, but she freezes when Catra flinches in response. Catra's eyes quickly dart away to stare at the corner of the room, her ears plastered to her head.

Cautiously, Adora lowers her hand and places it on Melog's head instead. Melog blinks at her with wide eyes as Adora slowly begins to pet them. Glancing between Catra and Melog, she watches both of their eyes slowly blow out, their pupils rounding. A moment later, Catra begins to purr while Melog rumbles a gentle vibration. That's interesting, and Adora definitely wants to explore that more at a later date, but right now isn't the time.

"Thank you for helping her," Adora tells Melog. Catra scoffs, but Melog blinks at her and then mews, sounding *proud*. Adora isn't sure which one of their responses to believe, but she is leaning more towards Melog's. Catra might not be looking at her, but her eyes give her away. Adora keeps petting Melog as she considers what to do next. She wants to ask Catra more about what she did, but that

clearly agitated her. It seems like that conversation will have to wait until after Catra is healed up.

"I'm going to go shopping this evening to get you food. Is there anything you want to make sure I get for you?" she asks, changing gears. She watches Catra's shoulders relax, her defensiveness easing as she snorts. She finally looks back to Adora to send her a derisive look.

"TV dinners. They're in the frozen section. They're premade meals with instructions for how long to microwave them on the box. Even you can't fuck it up," Catra tells her. Despite the ribbing, Adora lights up just having Catra's gaze on her again. She nods eagerly. She can definitely do that. Catra is probably right that it's the only way to avoid anything melting or setting on fire in her rarely-used microwave.

Catra's tail thumps, the amused twist to her expression immediately transforming into a grimace as the involuntary movement sends a jolt of pain through her. Adora winces herself. The pain must be bad, because when Adora reaches out to guide Catra into lying back, she doesn't even scowl or protest the help. She just screws up her eyes and lets Adora manipulate her until she is laying flat on her back again. Adora carefully pulls the sheet back up to cover her as Catra just breathes deeply, waiting for the pain of movement to pass.

"Do you want me to-" Adora starts to ask, but Catra cuts her off.

"Yes. I can't rest with you here. Your guilt complex takes up the entire bed," Catra responds, her voice rough from the pain that she is processing. She hasn't been able to open her eyes yet. Adora doesn't know whether to laugh or cringe at that, so she just nods and quietly slips off the bed. As she gathers the empty container and Catra's drained glass from the bedside, she watches Melog take up her spot beside Catra, seeming determined to watch over her.

Silently, Adora thanks them. Catra is more hot and cold right now than usual and Adora is just grateful that she is allowing someone to

stay with her. As much as she wants to stretch out in the bed beside Catra, she leaves to quietly do the dishes. Catra asked her to go. Adora can go be consumed by her thoughts in front of the sink instead of camped out at the foot of the bed like she wants to be.

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Catra has a problem. Well, she has roughly seventeen problems and most of them are labeled *Adora* right now, but she has one problem that is more pressing than the others and it's that she needs to pee. There is no way she is making it to the bathroom on her own though and she told Adora to fuck off only like an hour ago. Every conversation takes a lot out of her with her body devoting so much of its resources to healing and she didn't want to talk about her last few years with Adora anyway.

Being around Adora is strange. When she reached for her, part of Catra shied away, warning her that it was Shadow Weaver finally taking the opportunity to act through Adora. Catra believes Adora if she says that Shadow Weaver is dead, but her body is so used to danger that it doesn't truly know how to let her guard down and just let someone in. If she can do it with anyone, it will be with Adora, but right now she is on edge enough from all the pain signals. At least they are dulling as her body stitches back together.

She thanks Melog, the moon, and her own healing factor for that. She still doesn't feel up to walking. Actually, all she feels up to is lying in bed in Adora's arms, but that would hurt like hell. The pain is making her needy, but she will have to settle for listening to Adora slowly turn the pages of a book in the next room. Fuck, she has missed her so much. At first, all she knew was pain, but the longer that she stays awake – and the more time she has to process that Adora can't be compelled anymore – the more she just wants to crawl right back into Adora's arms.

It is all that she ever wanted, but it was never safe. Shadow Weaver hated that they loved each other. Even if Catra wouldn't have been opening herself up to easy direct attack from Shadow Weaver acting through Adora, it was dangerous for them to ever do something outside of the few limited scenarios where intimacy was allowed and risk getting caught. They still did it, but the one time that they got caught kissing-

Well, Catra died.

She isn't actually mad at Adora for killing her. All this time she has been mad at her for *raising* her. Adora knew exactly what kind of nightmare she was raising Catra back into, especially being her sire and giving Shadow Weaver power over her. It's certainly a sticking point between them and Catra isn't going to let her forget it again anytime soon, but Adora was her first and only love. Catra doesn't know how she is supposed to move on with someone else when they couldn't possibly understand what she and Adora went through together.

No one else has a lived experience like that – at least she hopes not. Catra sighs, staring up at the ceiling. Melog can see the antique clock from where they are lying and they inform her that it has only been fifty-two minutes since Adora slipped into the room to drop off a refilled water and then vanished again, but it seems like Catra's quiet contemplation time is over. Her body has needs, and getting help going to the bathroom will also get her some time in Adora's arms, in a roundabout way.

Catra still doesn't want to call for her. Pointedly, she turns her head to the side and coughs. Immediately, she hears a slight shift of movement out in the living room as Adora's head snaps up, zeroing in on the source of the noise. For several seconds, neither of them moves. Fine, so one cough isn't enough. It hurts to do, but whatever, so would calling Adora's name. Catra coughs again. This time, Adora closes her book, though she doesn't stand. Catra scowls.

Adora said all she had to do was whisper her name and she would come. Then again, a cough is far from a summons. The loud mew that Melog lets out next *is* though. Catra gives a low hiss under her breath at them, chastising them for calling Adora so obviously, but Melog doesn't understand why Catra is playing this game, especially not when the call works and Adora quickly stands and heads for the bedroom door. Catra's ears twitch as the bedroom door opens.

"Do you need water?" Adora asks her , her voice soft. Melog mews an answer for her – a *no*, but Adora doesn't need to know that.

"Yes," Catra responds, her voice rough from the false coughs. She turns her head to watch Adora approach, her expression cautious but hopeful, though she grimaces at the same time that Catra does when the pain from sitting up makes her hiss even with Adora's help. Adora gets her upright quickly though – vampire superstrength is good for something, she guesses – and fetches her the glass of water. Catra doesn't want to have to sit up twice, so she drains it, though she makes sure to pace herself.

"Do you have a bathroom? Or toilet paper?" Catra asks as Adora takes the cup back from her. The corner of Adora's lips twitch, but she sets the cup back on the end table and nods.

"I have to, I have mortal visitors regularly . My two closest friends are a human and a dhampir. Can your pride take me carrying you there? I think trying to walk early would delay your healing and make you bedbound for longer," Adora asks, already leaning forward over the mattress and smiling at her. That hopeful expression is back, like she is hanging onto any chance that Catra may be offering to touch her. Catra can't really blame her , though. She is doing the same thing herself, at least internally.

Catra sniffs, turning her nose up a little at the goading, but she doesn't say *no*. Even after seven years, Adora still speaks her language. She grins at Catra as she carefully bends down and worms her arms beneath her on the mattress. It fucking hurts, as does Adora lifting her into the air, but Adora just holds her there for a

moment as Catra's head falls onto her shoulder and she breathes heavily. She tries to focus on the small comfort of being in Adora's arms and not the pain searing through her as Adora seems to have decided she has had time to adjust and carries her out of the bedroom.

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Adora gets Catra a robe while she is using the bathroom to give her some privacy. Catra seems grateful for it. She doesnt say anything, but her gaze softens despite the obvious pain that she is in. She lets Adora manipulate her body to carefully pull her arms through the sleeves while minimizing the amount of movement she has to do as much as possible. It kind of falls open as Adora carries Catra back to the bedroom, but she fixes it again after she lays her back down, and she lays the sheet over her for good measure.

Catra didnt seem that upset by her nakedness, but she also seems to appreciate the gesture. If nothing else, it will help Adora focus around her and protect Catra's privacy if someone walks by the window. She hesitates after getting Catra settled, not really eager to leave the room again so soon. Catra is still just breathing heavily as she works through the pain caused by moving, her teeth gritted, but she doesnt seem nearly as annoyed by Adora' s presence this time.

Adora wouldnt blame Catra for any anger she holds towards her , but she is starting to suspect her snippiness has more to do with the pain that she is in than her actual feelings towards Adora. Shell have to wait until after Catra is healed up to test that hypothesis, though. She watches Melog sniff at Catra as if concerned, their ears plastered back and tail held stiff, but after a few moments Catra's breathing eases and so does Melog's stance. They pull back, walking towards the end of the bed and shrinking with every step.

Adora blinks at them at they settle down next to Catra's feet, now miraculously shrunk down to the size of a house cat. She has never actually met a witch's familiar before. Maybe that's normal for them. The one witch she met that supposedly had one kept *talking* about her familiar like he was there, but the air was empty. Everything that Adora knows about them she has learned from the coven, but she knows that they amplify their owner's magic and reflect their emotions. Right now, Melog seems at ease, so that means that Catra has to be at least somewhat calm internally.

Adora looks back to Catra to find her expression more relaxed, apparently recovered from the pain now she has been still for a few moments. Her eyes are hooded, but her gaze is burning as she watches Adora stand awkwardly at her bedside. Adora swallows. That is a look that she knows well and it never fails to light her blood on fire. Catra has seemed mostly pissed at her – rightfully – and the last thing that Adora expected was for her to give her this look again. It means so many things. It means *I want you*. It means *hold me*. Ultimately, it always meant *come feed*.

They werent allowed to be intimate except when Adora was feeding. Vampire venom induces a state of bliss in those they feed on, at least when it is done consensually. It feels more like a tranquilizer to unwilling victims, forcing their bodies limp and minds numb. They certainly dont get turned on from it. Catra was always terrified of when Shadow Weaver would feed on her, but Shadow Weaver didnt like dealing with Catra's fur while feeding or how she would always instinctually fight her no matter the punishment later, so she usually drew blood from her and then drank it from a warmed glass.

It was kind of horrifying to watch, but it was better for Catra than having her venom and fangs in her. She would sit quietly for the blood withdrawals most of the time, anyway. Adora was another story. She struggled with bloodlust during the inoculation process, so she spent a few years feeding from drawn blood as well to avoid seriously hurting Catra while feeding, but once the transformation was complete, Adora had control of herself as long as she got blood

regularly enough. She returned to feeding directly like she did when they were kids. Aging had changed things, though.

Catra's body had a reaction just from being in such an intimate position with Adora and the venom left her in a blissful haze that neither of them could help. When Catra wanted her, she would encourage her to feed, not only because it felt good for her, but because it was a time when they were allowed to stretch out in Catra's bed together, Catra lying down in preparation for the weakness afterwards and Adora holding her as she ducked down into her neck. They could cuddle, they could *moan*, and they could be alone together without worrying about Shadow Weaver bothering or punishing them. It couldnt be helped. Feeding was just euphoric.

Adora's mouth feels dry. Catra's eyes are warm and enticing, but Adora is *not* feeding on her now. That seems like a bad idea in general after the last time, but it would also disrupt her healing. That is the last thing that Adora wants to do despite how those eyes entrance her. Maybe, for once, feeding doesnt have to be what the look means. It wasnt about the venom for Catra, really – it was the intimacy. They dont need an excuse to be close now , though Adora will have to be careful of Catra's injuries.

"Can I join you? I'll be careful," Adora breathes. She can acknowledge that she's thinking with her metaphorical dick right now, but fuck, it has been seven years and she has thought of no one but Catra in that time. She wasnt expecting this, and she isnt sure what Catra's reaction will be despite the bedroom eyes that she is giving her.

Catra purrs.

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Catra already wanted to be held before trying to move, but the pain makes her desperate to just feel safe in Adora's arms. She doesnt say anything, but she is glad that Adora noticed and stayed. Her eyes fall closed and her purr rumbles loudly as Adora carefully lays out in the bed beside her. She knows that Adora is trying to avoid hurting her, but there is a small gap between them that Catra cant stand. She has been alone for seven fucking years. She thought she could live with that up until the moment that she woke up to Adora's voice again and now all she can think about is the comfort she once found in Adora's companionship.

"Closer ,"she whispers. Her ears twitch, an edge of nerves entering her body, but she needs this. She thinks Adora will give it to her. She instantly reacted to the look that Catra gave her at least, even if it took awhile for her to go from horny to speaking. Adora pauses beside her, looking at her with wide, searching eyes before she shuffles closer. Their sides just barely brush. The points of contacts are scarce and as electrifying as they are painful, but it's what Catra needs.

The last time that she was hugged was nearly two years ago, when she bid goodbye to the strangely kind witch who helped her. Before that, it was Adora a few weeks before she turned Catra. Melog is extremely cuddly , but they can only do so much for Catra when she is this touch starved, especially for one touch in particular. Adora's. Now Adora is right beside her and the only thing that can hold them back is how much pain Catra is in.

Carefully, she shifts her head so it curls down the side of the pillow towards Adora. Adora is still too far away to make contact, but after a moment of scanning Catra's face, she shifts close enough for Catra to lift her head again and this time place it on her shoulder. A bit of wiggling on Adora's part and her shoulder is right there for Catra to comfortably pillow her head on while the rest of her is just barely touching Catra's side. As long as she doesnt move, it wont hurt.

Catra lets her eyes fall closed and breathes in deeply. Adora's subtle, almost invisible scent fills her nostrils. It feels incredible to be

curled up with Adora again despite the pain in her body and the awkward angle. As soon as she is healed up, she is going to climb into Adora's lap and refuse to leave it for a week. For now, she satisfies herself with just her shoulder. As a purr begins rumbling in her chest, she drifts off into a comfortable sleep. The pain may be making her temperamental, but this is right where she has always wanted to be for her entire life.

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Catra eats one more time before the sun starts setting and Adora has to leave for the grocery store. Adora could have laid in bed with her for forever, feeling breathless and buzzing with happiness as she listened to Catra's heartbeat. The steady rhythm of her breathing makes Adora feel calm in a way she didn't know something so passive and natural could. It never made her feel like that before – at least, not unless Catra was purring too – but it's a constant assurance that Catra is alive and well in her arms.

Catra fell asleep purring, though the purrs tapered off into gently rumbling breaths eventually. Adora is no more inclined to move after what must be two or three hours of lying together – looking at the clock would require turning her head and risk waking Catra, which she definitely isn't doing – but eventually Catra's stomach growls and she lets out an adorable *mrrp* as she wakes, her ears flicking as she tunes back into her surroundings.

Taking care of an injured sort-of-mortal is more work when they are mostly awake than Adora bargained for – until Catra mentioned it the first time, Adora didn't even think about the fact that she needs to use the bathroom – but Adora does it happily. She carries Catra to the bathroom again, although this time she runs ahead to open the door and raise the toilet lid first so Melog doesn't have to do it for

them when she has her arms full of Catra, and she fetches her food and water.

She does everything she can to get her as comfortable as possible as the sun starts going down in the sky. Adora has to leave now if she wants to make sure to get out to the store while it's still open and it's safe for her to leave, but she wants to get Catra as comfortable as possible first. As Adora fusses with pulling Catra's robe to cover her chest again after it fell open on the way back from the bathroom, Catra raises a brow at her. This morning she definitely hated Adora's hovering, but now she seems mostly amused by it.

"I'm sure Glimmer or Bow would gladly stay over here with you while I'm gone, but I figured-" Adora starts.

"I don't want that," Catra finishes for her, decisively. Yeah, that's what she thought. Adora nods. It would make her more comfortable to know that someone was with Catra, but at least Melog is here. They have a strong enough bond with her that they were able to find her within hours of being hit by a car. They will probably be able to keep up with her needs.

"I'll be back within an hour. If I get delayed, I'll text Glimmer to come let you know," Adora tells her, double checking that she has her phone in her pocket. She doesn't usually need it that much, but she typed up the shopping list that Catra rattled off while she was eating on the notes app, so she needs it for this trip. Catra also gave her the name of a local grocery store to go to – when Adora paused at that, Catra reluctantly admitted that she lives nearby, which made Adora light up – so Adora will need her phone for directions to get there too.

"Keep an eye on her, okay, buddy?" Adora asks Melog as she stops at the foot of the bed to pet their head. Catra rolls her eyes, but she is smiling. Her mood has improved again since waking up. She mentioned the pain was easing – at least before Adora picked her up – so that is probably why. She might be back on her feet tomorrow.

Melog mews what Adora is an affirmative to her as they butt up into her hand, apparently enjoying pets just as much as their owner does.

Adora wont be gone long, but she is still grateful that Catra wont be alone for it. She has been alone for long enough.

Chapter End Notes

> These two are Unusually fucked up and that's saying something for Catradora. They arent going to be healed for a couple decades, but they can start smooching and growing together at least.
> Also to the people talking about getting food delivery in the comments and stuff: Adora honestly thinks that's something just limited to big cities (she, like, knows it exists but that' s about it). Catra will teach her better eventually lol

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> *Through gritted teeth* It's a short AU, only 5 chapters. It's a short AU, only 5 chapters. It's a short AU-

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra has nothing to do but think while she is bedbound, but she has too much that she doesnt want to think about. The more time she has to let it sink in that Shadow Weaver is gone, the more grateful she is to have found Adora again, but it is also bringing up bad memories that Catra usually tries to avoid recalling. Melog helps entertain her, the two of them passing memories and scenes back and forth as they silently tell stories to one another of better times, but Catra is relieved when Adora returns from the store.

She is a welcome distraction. Spending more time thinking about the last time that Adora's fangs entered her neck or the day that she regained a heartbeat isnt going to give them back the seven years between them. It was lonely. It sucked. Catra was on the run, strung out and traumatized, always running on empty as she hunted animals in her cat form and then shifted back to drain their blood so she could sustain herself. It was never quite enough, but she wasnt going to be a bloodsucker and attack humans. She didnt want to be a murderer-

Well. She's here now. Adora cant judge her for anything she has had to do in those seven years. Catra knows that she has done the same or worse. Catra still isnt eager to talk about it or see the look on Adora's face as she realizes what she drove Catra to do. Catra knows she was trying to "save" her when she turned her, but Catra lost a lot when she died. She lost more getting her life back. She really doesnt want to talk about it. She wants to spend as long as

possible ribbing Adora for her shitty driving and inability to cook and not confront their past.

There's nothing but hurt in it. She would rather look forward. It is the only way that she has been able to keep going all these years. She lives out of spite, determined to succeed on her own. It turns out that dodging hunters is a lot easier than Shadow Weaver made it seem – at least when you have morals and don't feed on humans – but outrunning her past is all that Catra has been able to do since surviving the worst of it.

She would like to stop running. Adora has been living here for years and hasn't had issues with the coven. It should be safe. Regardless, Catra isn't eager to run from Adora now that Shadow Weaver isn't a risk. She's staying. Traumatized and petty, but staying. Adora definitely isn't letting things go – she doesn't know *how* to – but she seems willing to go easy on Catra while she is still injured. She doesn't ask her questions about anything other than how she is feeling and how TV dinners work when she gets back, at least.

She jokes with her, accepting all of Catra's condescending instructions on how to fix the TV dinner without melting the plastic. After Catra eats – it's shitty, but she has eaten far shittier, so she isn't complaining – Adora carries her to the bathroom despite how Catra could probably shuffle to it herself now. It would hurt more than being carried though, and Adora offers without being asked, so Catra lets herself be carried, resting her head on Adora's shoulder again.

She is starving for the contact. She nuzzles in when Adora carries her back to bed, rubbing her cheek against her shoulder and getting her scent on her. Adora's senses aren't tuned to pick it up really, but despite the nuance of Catra's different types of marks being lost on her, she will be able to detect that she has Catra's scent on her. She doesn't need to be able to smell it when she clearly notices Catra making the movement, though. Adora draws in a breath, well aware of what Catra is doing.

She is reluctant when she puts Catra back down in the bed, busying herself with fixing her robe again, though Catra suspects she is just looking for an excuse to touch her. She drinks it in gladly, purring as Adora pulls the sheet over her. When Adora straightens, she seems reluctant. Catra watches her, her eyes half-hooded. The looked worked last time. She doesn't have the same intent behind her gaze right now, but Adora looks to her hopefully again.

"It has to be boring staying in bed all day. How about I go get my book and read in here with you? Then I can get you anything you need without you having to call for me," Adora asks. She has that particular tone of voice that she uses when she knows that something was Catra's idea but she is saying it for her so she doesn't have to voice it. It makes the heartbeat in Catra's chest speed up. She heard Adora use that tone earlier today too, but after seven years without it, it is going to keep feeling monumental for some time.

"I'm probably going to sleep soon. You don't mind staying in bed overnight?" Catra has to ask. She has fallen asleep with Adora after feeding before, but Shadow Weaver would never allow them to just spend hours cuddling together for no reason, so she has never woken up with her still there. Not only would she like to, but if Adora moves while she is sleeping in her current state, the pain is going to jolt her awake. Adora smiles, shaking her head to assure Catra.

"No, I don't. I've been texting with the group chat for Glimmer's family. They know I'm going to be sticking to my house while you recover. They don't really know how much you- how close we were, but they're glad I found you again, even if last night was scary," Adora tells her. There's a lot to unpack in that statement, especially in what Adora was *going* to say before she changed her mind, but for the moment Catra just gives a single, small nod. It doesn't hurt nearly as bad as it did when she first woke.

It's a good thing too. She has tomorrow off, but she works the next morning. She is still going to be in some pain then, but she should be walking around. She needs this job regardless. It works for her and it

pays well enough. She hopes she'll be walking tomorrow morning, but for now she just wants to fall asleep in Adora's arms. Adora beams, turning to head out into her living room. Catra listens to her shuffle around for a minute before quickly returning with her book in hand.

Getting settled again hurts, but this time she gets to be halfway in Adora's arms, her face tucked into her neck and able to crack an eye open to read the book that Adora has propped up against her legs. Melog is settled at her feet again and Catra can scan the page along with Adora in the dark room until sleep starts to pull at the edges of her mind and her eyes drift shut. Her entire body aches, but it very well might be the most peaceful sleep that she has ever fallen into without Adora's venom to lull her into blissful peace.

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Adora reads happily until she finishes her book. She spends a lot of time reading when the sun is up, but usually at night she helps around on the farm, does some work for the coven, or goes around town. There are a couple twenty-four-hour places in the area that she frequents, but she also likes to just go and be out in the world. She never got the chance to in her childhood. Back then she was a dhampir and could have actually gone out in the sun to enjoy normal human society on a regular schedule, but she was as much of a prisoner as Catra was. Worse, actually, because once the inoculation started, she would have died from poisoning if she tried to leave before it was done.

Maybe she wishes for a mortal life sometimes – she *really* wants to know what the hell Catra did to get her heart going again – but she is glad to have found other vampires who live partially on her schedule. Angella is usually active around the farm at night and they spend a lot of time talking then, but Adora also gets to spend time with the

other inhabitants who sleep at night thanks to the farm being built with enough covered walkways to be vampire-accessible during the day.

Befriending normal mortals would still be hard for her, but she does have friends—maybe even something close to a family—and Catra's sudden mood change has her hopeful that she might have Catra back too. Maybe. She has some pretty major stuff to get over, and she can't exactly get help from your regular therapist. She has to process everything on her own time. Hopefully they have all the time in the world, but Adora has been missing Catra for so long, she really hopes that she is able to get comfortable with her again quickly.

She wouldn't blame her if it took her years, but her cuddliness last night seemed like a good sign. Catra stays on her chest, though Melog moves a few times in the night, getting up and shifting their position before falling right back asleep. It is pretty much the only thing that passes for entertainment after Adora finishes her book, but she is more than happy to spend a night at home if it's with Catra, even if she is doing nothing but lying silently and listening to her heartbeat. It's soothing, Catra's scent filling the room as her heart beats steadily in Adora's ears. Every beat is an assurance: Catra is here, Catra is alive, and most importantly, Catra is herself.

Adora is still worried about what she had to do, but she has no doubt that Catra's mind is the same as it was before. She even makes the same noise when she wakes up as she used to, her extremities twitching just a little as she prepares her body to spring into action at a moment's notice. Catra always woke up quickly. Today, she grimaces a little as she twitches, no doubt woken quicker by the pain. She yawns loudly, rubbing her cheek on Adora's shoulder before lifting her head and blinking at her. Lifting her head is a good sign. That was too painful for her to do without reason yesterday.

"Good morning," Adora breathes, stretching out her own limbs before she reaches up to gently pet Catra's short hair. Catra's eyes slip closed again as she purrs and leans into the attention. Yeah,

definitely a marked improvement. "How are you feeling?" Adora asks, carefully scratching at the base of Catra's ear. The scratches make Melog begin their weird, vibrating purr too from their current spot curled up near Adora's hip. For a moment, Catra just sinks into the attention. After a minute of enjoyment, she carefully stretches out her limbs and grimaces a little.

"Broken bones are all healed up, but there's still plenty of things to hurt. I'll minimize my walking today, but I think I'll be fine to hobble to work tomorrow," Catra tells her. Honestly, that is a better than Adora thought she would be doing, so it's a relief. The relief is tinged with a shameful fear though: once Catra can walk, will she stay? Adora doesn't know the answer. As much as she wants to believe that how Catra behaved last night was more indicative of her feelings than the way she sniped at her upon first awakening, the pain could have just been getting to her and causing her to seek out comfort.

She doesn't seem angry right now, though she did just wake up. Adora reminds herself that Catra lives close enough to use the local grocer. Even if she leaves after recovering, it doesn't have to be goodbye. Adora just has to hope that Catra likes her more than she hates vampires. She used to be confident of that, but killing someone changes things, as does having *freedom*. Catra loved her before, but she was the only kind face that Catra had ever known then. They definitely still have an emotional bond, but Adora's feelings run as deep as they always have and she fears that things have changed for Catra.

This line of thinking hurts. Adora tries to focus on Catra's words rather than her own worries.

"Where do you work?" Adora asks, still petting Catra and hoping that ear scratches are enough to placate her into talking. Catra doesn't seem bothered by discussing this, though, just blinking slowly at Adora as she leans into the touch. It's kind of weird to think of one of them – even Catra, who can live on a human schedule – having a job. Adora helps around the farm, but it is far from a normal job given that this farm is partially nocturnal in its schedule.

"Peekablue's Drive-In Theatre. I came to this area about a month ago because I ran into a werewolf that told me the coven is serious business and doesn't let hunters fuck around without cause," Catra tells her. Adora blinks. It's weird to think of Catra having been so close for weeks without her knowing. If they still had the bond, she is sure she would have picked it up, but it has been gone for a long time. She is relieved to know Catra works so close, at least. Adora goes to that movie theatre with Glimmer and Bow every Halloween for their midnight horror movie marathon.

"That's only thirty minutes away. If you're determined to go to your shift, I'd like to drive you. I'll be fine if I stay in the car," Adora requests, gently pushing just a bit further. She doesn't know how Catra would get to work without Adora driving her—it's too far to walk even on a day where she hasn't recently broken bones—but she knows how Catra feels about needing help. Catra pointedly leans into Adora's hand despite how she hasn't slowed her careful scratching thus far and has no intention of doing so. A benefit of being undead is not having to deal with her hand cramping up.

"Does your car even still drive?" she asks. Adora huffs, but she deserves that.

"Yes, it does. The front is smashed in and I need to take it to the mechanic tomorrow, but it drives without issue right now. I'll just tell people I hit a deer," Adora tells her. That seems to offend Catra. She wrinkles her nose up, clearly displeased until Adora shifts her hand and manages to find just the right spot to make Catra purr again, melting her hands. Fuck, that's a beautiful sight. She really hopes Catra lets her drive her to work and then straight back here to keep recovering.

"Fine, but only because you owe me for *hitting me with it*," Catra returns, her tone tinged with contempt, but she's kind of right, so Adora just beams at her.

"Deal," she agrees.

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Catra spends the day bored as shit. She was in too much pain and processing too much yesterday to really be bothered or bored out of her skull by being bedbound, but despite her entire body still aching today, the pain isnt intense enough to dominate her focus. Adora tries to get her to stay in bed, but that lasts just until she uses bathroom after breakfast. Honestly, her healing factor used to be good enough that she should be walking around by now, but the whole alive-but-still-immortal thing means that, even with Melog at her side, her body is spending some of its magic just keeping her going at all times, which gives her less to heal with.

She is still able to slowly shuffle to the bathroom today without needing to be carried, even if she leans on Adora while she does it. She doesnt want to go back to lying on the mattress in the tiny bedroom that Adora clearly just uses for getting ready in and occasionally "happing." Catra's sick of staring at the white walls. When she walks out of the bathroom, she veers off course into the living room proper. Adora is forced to either try to stop her and risk hurting her or to let her change paths. Catra knows which one she will do, even if she complains about how Catra should be resting as she guides her to the couch.

"I can rest here too. I'm *bored*. Fucking hell, how many books do you own?" Catra asks, slowly turning her head to inspect the living room without aggravating her whiplash. It's quaint, all the furniture antique. An entire wall of the space is taken up with built-in bookshelves and a few freestanding ones are scattered around the other walls. The curtains and color palette are very country, as is what Catra can see of the dine-in kitchen at the front of the cottage, but it isnt bad as far as things go. It's certainly better than the literal *hole* that Catra has been living in while she scoped out the area and tried to earn enough money for a security deposit on an apartment.

I like reading while the sun is up, at least if everyone else is busy . The cable channels here are shitty and I still just find the internet weird. Here, I bet we can find a book youll like to entertain you," Adora tells her, lighting up a little as she crosses over to one of the bookshelves. Catra snorts, watching Adora thoughtfully consult the mass of spines before her. Catra hasnt exactly had the time or access to get into easy entertainment over the last few years, spending most of her days either trying to survive or trying to research ways to break the bond, but of course Adora would find an antiquated form of entertainment to throw herself into now she has leisure time.

"Adora, you have more books than a library . Statistically it would be almost impossible for me to hate every single one," Catra comments dryly. Adora turns to flash a grin at her over her shoulder. Apparently she wont be deterred. Catra might not usually be a reader , but if nothing else, making fun of Adora's tastes in books will be fun.

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Finding a book for Catra is hard. Adora is almost certain she is being purposefully difficult. It would be in character, and some of the books that Adora pulls for her are *good* , but Catra still turns her nose up at them. Sometimes she gives Adora hope and actually reads them for a few pages, but she always ends up complaining that it's boring and setting the book aside. She is feeling good enough now to start chucking the books at Adora when she deems them boring.

"Come on, this one is great! She ends up running off with the cadet and saving the dragon if you just let it get there," Adora protests, gesturing with the hardcover book she narrowly caught before it hit her in the face. Her reflexes apparently arent as good as they used to be because she and Catra used to do shit like this all the time

when Shadow Weaver wasnt looking and she was never so bad at anticipating it.

She tells herself it's just that Catra's pain signals are throwing her off, but really she is generally distracted by Catra's existence. Despite her flippant disregard for the books or the direction she is throwing them in – namely, Adora's face – Catra hasn't tossed the two more delicate paperbacks that Adora gave her, instead handing them back to her with a sniff of disdain. Books might not really be her passion, but the thoughtfulness made emotion well up in Adora's chest.

"I'm not interested in romance or dragons, Adora," Catra comments dryly. Adora makes a face at her, looking back down at the stack beside her. Catra is getting decent entertainment from making fun of and rejecting the books, but Adora would like to find one that she actually is interested in reading, even if it's just for the purpose of making fun of it. She frowns at the stack, thinking about what she has on her shelves. She has read a decent amount of her books, but not quite all of them.

She was gifted the start of her collection by Bow because he thought it might be a good way for her to pass the daytime. She then quickly began adding to it with a veracity. Angella pays her for her help around the farm and she uses a decent chunk of that payment on expanding her collections, but occasionally she picks up a book and never gets around to it. Her friends, knowing how much of a reader she has become, sometimes gift her books as well, and not all of them are-

"Hang on, I've got it," Adora tells Catra confidently, gathering up her stack and walking back to the shelves to put them away. Catra snorts, her doubt obvious, but Melog follows Adora curiously as she finishes putting the books away and instead crosses to a small bookshelf near the entrance hallway that passes next to the kitchen. She usually puts her gifted books here so her friends can see that she appreciates them, but there is one book on the shelf that is almost mandated to stay there.

Gimmer's aunt gets offended if her gifts aren't proudly accepted, even if they aren't the kind of thing that you would usually display. The witch doesn't live on the farm – Adora can't actually tell if she and Angella get along, but she thinks the weird not-conflict between them is just because Castaspella is defensive of her brother and a bit overbearing – but her visits are often unannounced, so Adora leaves the book on display all the time.

"You're going to hate this," Adora says confidently, waggling the book a little in her hand as she walks back to her couch. Catra snorts, sending her a bemused look as Melog hops up on the couch and stands up on two legs so they can stretch up to sniff at the book. Adora lowers it down so they can stand comfortably and inspect it. After a moment of sniffing – or maybe just after seeing the cover – they pull back with a chuff that almost sounds offended.

"Why would you bring me something you know I'll hate?" Catra asks, eyeing her as Adora circles around her to sit on the opposite side of her from Melog. Adora grins as she places the book in Catra's lap, finally revealing the cover to her. Catra stares at it for a moment before bursting out laughing. Adora feels a bit breathless watching Catra toss her head back and laugh openly. Her body twinges with traces of pain, but it does nothing to dampen her spirits at the ridiculous dime-store romance novel cover featuring a mostly-naked woman throwing herself into the arms of a cartoonish Dracula.

"Gimmer's aunt gave it to me. I don't know if she thought I would find the portrayal of vampires funny or if she legitimately thought the porn was good enough for me to overlook that, but it's terrible through-and-through. I read parts of it out loud to Gimmer. She cried laughing at one point. You'll love it," Adora assures her. Catra instantly begins cackling at the mention of porn, but that's about *half of the scenes*. She wouldn't even call it erotica, it's too bad – and she has read some bad erotica.

"Well go ahead, give me the full show," Catra tells her, picking up the book and handing it back to Adora. Adora grins, taking the book back and flipping to the beginning. It feels so much like the kind of

shenanigans they used to pull to entertain themselves when Shadow Weaver wasn't looking. Adora's heart feels full in a way that she didn't know it could. She clears her throat as she finds the first page.

"I'm starting from the beginning because I need you to appreciate how little the plot makes sense. If I start at the porn, you might give it the benefit of the doubt," Adora tells her. The porn starts only a few pages in anyway, but she isn't warning Catra about that. She wants her to be as surprised by it as Adora was. Catra's eyes are sparkling as she tilts her head back to settle in against the back of the couch. Her tail twitches with amusement from beneath the edge of her robe and the movement doesn't even seem to hurt her.

As much as Adora doesn't want to read parts of this book aloud, as long as she leans into how comically bad it is, she thinks she can get through it without getting embarrassed. The good news is that she has no chance of getting turned on from this, at least. It's just too poorly written. Hopefully Catra will enjoy making fun of it as much as she did.

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The book is truly *awful*. Clearly it was written by a human who doesn't know vampires are more than just folklore. No one who knew vampires existed would risk writing shit like this and offending them. When Adora describes the male love interest having to drink his partner's blood during sex in order to *keep it up*, Catra falls over laughing and Adora has to help sit her back up. Most of it is hilarious, especially the massive plot holes and contradictions that start stacking up quickly.

Then they get to the first solo porn scene. Up until now, it has been terrible and inaccurate heterosexual sex, but now the love interest has fallen into a coma – vampires don't fall into a coma, they

hibernate, but nothing about this book is correct – and that leaves the mortal main character to swoon in front of his coffin and wonder if he will wake up again during her lifetime. Ridiculously, she masturbates right there, thinking back on the previous terrible porn scenes. It's so stupid that Catra should be laughing. She *is* laughing, except parts of it hit a little too close to home.

Not that Adora ever had a coffin, but getting off remembering the sensation of fangs in her neck and longing for the one who used to love her? Yeah, Catra knows that well. It's still terribly written, but it hits on her own memories, and that is the part that turns her on more than anything, remembering lying in hotel beds and desperately touching herself as she thought about Adora and wondered if she could somehow feel it through the sire bond.

Unfortunately for Catra, Adora is a fucking vampire, and that doesnt just endow her with the fangs that Catra stupidly misses in her neck. Her sense of smell is as finely tuned as Catra's. She picks up on the change in Catra instantly, stumbling over her words as she *tries* to keep reading the passage. Catra's tail lashes at her side, her cheeks blazing. You would think her embarrassment would be enough to kill her libido, but no, now she can smell *Adora's* interest picking up in response to her own. Catra's body is instantly on alert, craving something it absolutely cant have. No way they're having sex while she's injured.

Adora tries to push on, but her tone is a bit strangled, and then she gets to the part about *gushing blood bringing a headrush to her as intense as the one to her sex* and she draws to an abrupt halt. This porn is a fucking turn off if anything, but it reminded her of Adora, and that's what got her going. Catra turns her face away, looking to Melog instead, but Melog sends her an unimpressed look and hops off the couch, wandering away to the bedroom. Catra's tail lashes again.

She worries that is going to send the message to Adora that she wants her to take her to bed, but actually Melog is fleeing from the horny display happening in the living room – because Catra wants

Adora to lean over and bite her neck right here and right now. Fuck, she's a disaster. Adora awkwardly shifts on the couch behind her, clearly unsure what she should do. Yeah, Catra doesn't know either. Her brain helpfully supplies that Adora could fuck her, but that isn't happening. She might be feeling generally better, but she isn't healed enough to have sex.

"It's not the book. The book is still terrible. It's just because I remember what the venom feels like," she defends, grumbling a little as she sinks down into her own shoulders. Hunching hurts, but she really couldn't give a shit right now. Behind her, Adora nods almost too quickly.

"Of course. I can, uh, skip this scene? All that happens is she, uh, the blood flow to her—" Adora trails off and coughs pointedly, "—is enough to wake him up. And then he does what she was fantasizing about because he sees it through the stupid mind meld," Adora says, fumbling her way through the explanation. That is some of the dumbest shit that Catra has ever heard and it almost distracts her from the fact that Adora could very well be thinking about *Catra's* changing blood flow as she flushes.

She is almost about to open her mouth and say she is due for a nap —she is wide awake, but this is fucking *awkward* —when a knock at the door rescues her. At least she thinks that until she remembers that half of the residents on this farm are vampires and can likely smell exactly what state she is in. Fuck.

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Glimmer could not have picked a worse time to drop by. Catra is already defensive, but she is annoyed enough by the intrusion that she growls as Adora heads to her entryway, dropping the book off on her bookshelf before she approaches the door and sees Glimmer

through the window, Bow standing behind her and carrying a large covered dish. Adora breathes a sigh of relief. Vampires have a great sense of smell, but Glimmer's senses as a dhampir aren't quite as good as Adora's and she won't be able to detect much in either her or Catra's scents with Bow's cooking covering it up.

Adora might not be able to eat, but she does know that Bow's food always smells delicious. She opens the door and smiles at both of them, even if it is slightly strained. That's mostly because she is worried about Catra's reaction though. Adora squints in the face of the bright sun beyond her covered porch, glancing between Bow's greeting smile and Glimmer's almost suspicious expression. Adora reminds herself that she had that same look on when she came to visit before.

"I wasn't expecting you guys. I told you I got stuff at the store yesterday. Don't get me wrong, I'm sure Catra will like this a lot better, but you really didn't have to," Adora points out, slowly stepping aside to let them in. By now, the smell of whatever Bow cooked should have made its way to the living room and put Catra at ease that her current *state* isn't being advertised to the visitors she hasn't met. Bow and Glimmer both send Adora a pitying look as they step inside.

"I know you have no baseline when it comes to food, but TV dinners are *sad*," Glimmer tells her, drawing to an abrupt halt as she picks up on the heartbeat in the living room. Turning her head and craning her neck allows her to see Catra. Adora watches her eyes go wide. Right, Catra is...herself, but anyone who didn't grow up with a werecreature probably isn't used to seeing them just live in their halfway forms. Adora steps further into the house so she can see into the living room as Bow, glancing between them with a raised brow, heads straight for the kitchen.

Catra is all but glaring at Glimmer, her eyes narrowed and tail twitching tensely on the couch beside her. From across the house, her position looks a bit limp – *helpless*. Catra hates being vulnerable in any sense of the word. Having other people around while she's

injured is more likely to end in a fight than not. Adora watches Catra's eyes quickly dart towards the openings into the kitchen as she splits her focus between tracking Bow and watching Glimmer. She mostly focuses on Glimmer, though. Adora isn't surprised. She can't blame Catra for not trusting vampires.

"This is Catra. She's still healing up and not feeling very social," Adora tells Glimmer, gesturing into the living room where Catra's eyes have somehow narrowed even more. In the bedroom, Adora hears the mattress shift as Melog shakes out to their full size. That's not good. They might be preparing for a fight. Bow emerges from the kitchen and Adora sends him an imploring look. Both is a good negotiator. He can probably diffuse a fight before Catra decides to get hissy.

"Catra, this is Glimmer, and her husband Bow," Adora adds, reaching out to put a hand on Bow's shoulder and pull him forward. Bow grunts with surprise, a slight twinge of pain running through him that causes every person in the room to freeze. Beneath her hand, Adora feels two distinctive heat points. Oh. Glimmer fed recently. Hastily, Adora releases Bow's shoulder and sends him an apologetic look.

"Sorry. A bit, uh, absorbed," she says, awkwardly pocketing both her hands as if to prove she isn't going to hurt him with them again. Bow immediately sends her an understanding smile as Glimmer looks away, embarrassed. Adora knows for a fact she gets blood bags. She doesn't *need* to feed on Bow. The bite isn't deep either. That was definitely recreational. The coven's blood drive structure is set up so they—hopefully—have enough donations to fully cover the needs of anyone signed up to receive it, but it isn't unusual for a vampire to find someone they can personally feed on instead.

Adora wouldn't be able to get enough blood from one person, but the average vampire, especially a dhampir? Yeah, Glimmer could live off Bow if she had to, but feeding off Bow could cause issues when it comes to his testosterone shots and the routine HRT bloodwork, so Glimmer is on the coven's list of vampires needing a supply. This was purely for sport. Well, that certainly shifted the focus off Catra

potentially being turned on, although it seems to have put Catra even *more* on edge.

Of course it did – now she knows that Glimmer isn't above feeding someone close to her. Then again, neither is Adora. Catra isn't in danger of being *attacked* by Glimmer, though, and Adora fears she may be worrying about that. Adora clears her throat, drawing everyone's attention back to her, although Glimmer isn't quite looking her in the eye.

"Thank you for the food. I'll help out on the farm tonight after Catra sleeps, and I'll be free tomorrow morning to help you go over the coven supply lists after I drop Catra off," Adora tells the pair. She feels bad about wrecking the car Micah taught her to drive and then spending two days holed up in her house and not helping out like she should, but Catra is always going to be her top priority. Glimmer, apparently desperate for a change of subject, latches onto Adora's words.

"Adora, you can't be planning to drive that car anywhere but the mechanic right now. You aren't good at driving on a good day, forget about when your axle is probably bent," Glimmer says. Adora knows her expression is guilty, but she doesn't even know what a car having a bent axle means. She had never gotten behind a wheel until Micah took pity on her and started teaching her at twenty years old.

"Oh, has she hit you with her car too?" Catra questions, her tone snarky. Adora winces, darting her gaze over to find Catra's gaze still fixed on Glimmer. Her tail is tense and her ears are pinned back. Catra looks like she feels metaphorically backed into a corner. Her words are barbs she is throwing out in self-defense, but no one here is attacking. No one except her, anyway. Glimmer has *really* set her on edge. Adora clears her throat loudly as Glimmer narrows her eyes at Catra, apparently disapproving of the comment despite how Catra has more than earned wringing Adora out however she sees fit.

"Micah is going to drive with me to the mechanic tomorrow night. I already took it to the grocery store and it was fine," Adora defends. Glimmer looks incredibly unconvinced, but before she can say anything more, Bow takes pity on them and sidles up beside her, taking her hand in his own and giving her a pointed look – it's the one that even Adora has come to know means *calm down* – before he turns back to Adora.

"Give us a call if it does break down, but we just wanted to drop off some comfort food for Catra," Bow tells her. Adora smiles gratefully to him as he pulls on Glimmer's arm and she lets herself be reluctantly steered out to the front porch with one more glance thrown in Catra's direction. Adora is just glad they diverted a fight. Making Catra socialize while she is still injured is a terrible idea.

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Catra decides she should have been nicer to the people bringing her food when Adora actually gives her some of it and it's the best damn thing she has had in months, but forgive her for being naturally defensive when injured and wearing just a robe in front of strangers. Maybe she had preconceived notions about not liking Adora's new friends anyway, but they really chose the worst time to randomly drop by.

Catra doesn't want anyone – except Adora, and Melog she supposes, but Melog is her familiar and doesn't count – around while she is healing up. She barely held herself back from hissing at them, but luckily they picked up on her hostility and fucked off quickly. After the invaders leave, Adora turns on the TV and sets to cleaning her kitchen while Catra half watches it and half watches Adora through the cut out in the wall between the kitchen counter and the cabinets above it.

She quickly sets the TV on mute because the speakers are grating on her ears, so she misses half the subtitles, but watching Adora is more important anyway. Adora said something about the space needing to be dust-free if it's going to get actual use, but Catra is fairly certain it's just an excuse to avoid returning to the awkwardness of before. Or maybe she doesn't want to deal with Catra while she is fired up and defensive. Catra doesn't really blame her for that. She knows she has been a bit of a nightmare to deal with, but in her defense, Adora hit her with her fucking car.

By the time Adora is done bustling around the kitchen, Catra actually is feeling tired. Healing is hard work, and she spends a lot of time sleeping if she isn't working anyway. She also usually expends a lot more energy running around – she has to walk everywhere she goes between her unusual address and lack of funds – but repairing her body is her workout right now. Adora makes sure she eats, drinks, and uses the bathroom before she retreats to the bedroom, but Catra can walk without help now and she shuffles off to collapse in the bed with Melog.

It takes her awhile to fall asleep, but Adora is silent out in the main room, a guardian who will ensure that no random neighbors bother her in her sleep, and eventually Catra manages to drift off. The sleep doesn't feel very restful, though. She dreams of the small room where Shadow Weaver kept her for *weeks* after she caught them kissing in the dead night. It wasn't following a feeding, and while she was willing to turn a blind eye to intimacy induced by the endorphins of Adora's venom, Shadow Weaver finding them giving each other affection just for the sake of happiness was unacceptable.

In Catra's dream, she wastes away for weeks, shrinking slowly until she is down to the size of a housecat when Shadow Weaver finally returns and opens the door. Catra crawls forward pitifully, desperate to find a full meal rather than the scraps Shadow Weaver has barely been sustaining her on. Outside of her cell is a long hallway. It wasn't like that in real life, but Catra also didn't physically *shrink* as she waited for Shadow Weaver's temper to cool.

At the end of the hallway is Adora. Her eyes are blue, glowing like lightning. Fear quivers through Catra as she picks up on Adora's heavy breathing and animalistic hunch. Adora isn't herself, and she senses prey. Blood. After an eternity of staring at each other, Adora launches forward. The dream goes black. Catra doesn't think she wakes then, but it is the last thing she remembers when her eyes do fly open. Her breathing is heavy, not quite panicked, but fuck, that was awful to relive, even in distorted dream form.

She squeezes her eyes shut, promising herself that it's okay as Melog nuzzles against her side, sending her quiet assurances. A hand falls into her hair, gently petting through the short locks. It startles her. Catra opens her eyes to find her head is pillowed on Adora's chest. When she went to sleep, Adora was reading on the couch, but she must have snuck in at some point. Maybe she detected Catra having a nightmare and came to comfort her.

Melog says she has been there for a bit. Catra was the one to cuddle up to her. Catra steadfastly ignores that. They don't have any proof. She turns to tuck her face into Adora's chest, breathing deeply to draw in her subtle scent. Adora is soft and pliant beneath her, nothing like the beast who attacked her after being starved of blood for weeks. She keeps petting her with one hand, the other propping a book up on her hip. Adora doesn't say anything, letting Catra work on calming down the rapid heartbeat pulsing through her.

"There might be time yet, but Hordak fears that her delay will see enough reinforcements arrive to rebuff her attack. She started this war for her love. If she fails now, what will it say about her commitment, her strength? She surely won't be a fit queen to her people, but will she be a fit lover to the one person who truly matters to her?" Adora quotes, her voice low. Catra's ears twitch. She draws in a breath as Adora turns the page of her book.

"Letters and oaths don't reassure her. The only way to prove her love is to win. A slight against her lover cannot be met with anything less than the clash of swords. If reinforcements have arrived, then she simply must outmaneuver them," Adora continues, quietly

reading to Catra. Catra swallows, her ears twitching as Adora continues to read the most insane love declaration Catra has ever heard. Still, the dedication of the main character's inner monologue is sweet, if misguided.

The racing in her chest slows as she listens. The dream was panic-inducing, but Adora's voice is warm, soft and gentle as she reads about a war started for a nearly-forbidden love. It gives Catra something to focus on other than fear. Slowly, Catra even feels her eyes drift closed again, surrounded by Adora's scent and touch. There is no trace of the beast. Of course there isnt. It was a dream – and a memory, distorted and once real, but a dream nonetheless.

Adora isnt what Shadow W eaver forced her to become. Any vampire can enter bloodlust if starved enough. Catra could see Adora's fridge from the living room. She has room for plenty of blood bags to keep herself supplied. She isnt a danger , it just doesnt make Catra's memories go away. Adora's soft hand in her hair and warm voice help chase away the lingering adrenaline at least. Catra sinks down into her embrace, letting herself focus on the warm and safe body that is here with her now. She doesnt need to be afraid.

Shadow Weaver is gone, and she has Melog to help her too. Adora isnt going to hurt her again. Her hand is so soft in her hair , petting steadily as she keeps reading, trying to ground Catra after the nightmare. This is the Adora that she fell in love with, the one who she could never forget even after she gained the scars on her neck. This is the Adora who she knew so well - loved so much - that she could forgive the bloodlust that took her life, even if she is still annoyed about Adora raising her given the five-year saga it kicked off.

She will forgive her for that too, though. She may be a being made of bitterness and spite, but at her core, all she has ever wanted was love. That is what *made* her bitter, seeking out safety and happiness and finding herself only abused by their "guardian" in turn. Adora loved her though. She used her too, but she had no choice. The memories are going to be there, but they were there before she

found Adora again. If she is going to wake up from panicked nightmares anyway, she might as well wake up in Adora's arms, where a gentle voice can lull her back to sleep.

She knows Adora promised Glimmer she would do some farm work tonight and she is going to leave eventually, but for now Catra sinks in the warmth of her arms and hopes that she is asleep by then.

Chapter End Notes

> Not Adora unconsciously admitting that she's read other erotica not thrust upon her by overbearing aunts ≫
> I made up the book passage (It's vaguely referencing a story of mine). Maybe Adora sees herself in it a little (◡‿◡✿)
> Happy Catra day!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Adora's parasol (Can you tell Glimmer got it for her? She also added this ornament onto it because she loves torturing Adora with the gothic aesthetic).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stayed in bed until well past sundown, but she wanted to make sure Catra didn't have another nightmare. When it started, Adora was afraid that her presence would make it worse – it could very well be a nightmare about *her* – but Catra seemed soothed when she woke up. Adora kept reading aloud after she fell back asleep for awhile, and then she stayed in bed even longer after that to make sure nothing more would happen, but eventually she had to get up and see to her duties around the farm.

When she returns, she finds Catra awake, though laying in bed still. Adora fixes breakfast for Catra when she gets back home. Catra is now capable of walking around and standing in the kitchen doorway to watch Adora judgmentally as she takes altogether too long to work the microwave.

"You hit the timer button," Catra helpfully explains, her tone dry, when Adora hits *start* and the microwave starts counting down without actually turning on. Adora doesn't know why you would even want that to be a feature. She hits the cancel button a total of three times before the microwave lets her actually type in the time again and hit go. "Absolute disaster," Catra throws over her shoulder, sounding amused, as she turns to disappear back into the bedroom.

She gets dressed without help, shifting into her human form before stealing Adora's clothes, and eats by herself too. She even refills her water without asking Adora for help. Adora is glad that she is feeling better – she has been feeling guilty as shit for hitting her for the last

two days – but she's also anxious. She knows this isn't *goodbye*, not really, not when Catra lives nearby and Adora at least knows where she works, but she really doesn't want to take Catra back to her own place after her shift and be without her again.

Catra hasn't mentioned anything about what she wants after she gets off of work. She asked if Adora would still have the car to pick her up then, to which Adora quickly responded that she would, and she also asked her if Melog could stay here while she was working, but that could just mean that she wants Adora to drive her back to her own apartment at the end of her shift. Adora is afraid to get her hopes up of more as she waits by the front door for Catra to finish getting ready.

"You can't drop me off at the theatre. I have a uniform, but I shifted as soon as I got off my night shift, so I had to stash it in a bag in the woods," Catra calls from the bedroom. Her tone of voice is odd. Probably just strained from the discomfort of getting dressed. She said she was sore when Adora asked her how she was doing. Sore may be a far cry from the screaming pain that she was clearly in before, but it still isn't pleasant.

That explains why Catra was sprinting through the woods at night. When Adora asked before, she admitted her difficulties with shifting, but that still didn't explain how she got on the middle of a backroad in the forest. She was probably running from work to her place after the unexpected shift. Adora grunts an affirmative as she slips on her shoes and pulls her parasol out of the umbrella stand near the front door.

She shouldn't need it – the carport is covered, as is the walkway to it, and if she is just taking Catra to work then she shouldn't need to get out of the car – and it wouldn't be enough to ensure protection if she was using it out in the open and not under the cover of at least a bit of shade, but she would rather be safe than sorry. Unfortunately, she forgets a vital fact in her practicality: she has been using this parasol for so long that she forgot that Glimmer got it for her.

Catra walks out of the bedroom and stops in her tracks, staring at the black umbrella decorated with lace. It's solid beneath that, made from fabric that protects against the UV rays that would burn Adora, but of course Glimmer couldn't get her a plain UV umbrella as a gift and had to get a stupid frilly gothic thing instead. There's a little bat ornament on the top that Glimmer gleefully informed her didn't come with it but is now superglued on, so it might as well be a part of the design.

Adora could just buy her own – she has been using this one for years, after all, the gift has been appreciated by now – but she never really thought it was important enough to do so. People snicker at it sometimes and she knows she looks like a weird goth farmer when she goes out with it, but if she's completely honest, she kind of thought she deserved the mocking. She has done some bad things in her life. She can deal with some mortals thinking she has no taste.

"It was a gift. And it helps with the sun," Adora blurts out, because regardless of what she thinks she deserves, she doesn't want *Catra* to think that. Adora would have chosen something plain if she was picking it out for herself. She doesn't even know where Glimmer found something like this. Angella has a small collection of parasols herself, but they are mostly pastel and decorated with satins. They aren't as lacy or frilly as Adora's. Glimmer seems to have purposefully picked something atrocious.

"You look like a character from that awful erotica book. Open it, let me see the whole thing," Catra tells her, her face twitching as she clearly tries to repress laughter. Adora sighs and opens the front door, stepping out onto her porch and opening up the umbrella. She leans it up against her shoulder and turns back to face Catra through the open doorway. Catra looks at her for about two seconds before she bursts out laughing.

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The parasol made Catra laugh hard enough she got a headache. On the drive to the movie theater, she glances into the backseat and snickers occasionally upon seeing it all over again. Melog is curled up in a ball on top of it, shrunk down to fit in the backseat and avoid snapping the supports or whatever. Actually, they *should* do that and then Adora can get a new one that doesnt look like a total stereotype. Catra is glad she has something that helps, she guesses, but she is even happier that it looks so stupid.

It makes her laugh, but if Adora thinks she is going in public with Catra and that thing in tow then she's wrong. She is going to have to find something else. Adora isnt getting out of the car today , though. Catra directs her to the bus stop down the road from the movie theatre. She usually walks to the bus stop and then takes a hard turn into the woods, stripping out of her uniform and stowing it in a waterproof bag so she can shift and run as a cat back to her den.

The uniform she is fetching today is her spare and not the same one she ripped to shreds on Sunday night, but the specifics dont really matter. She switches off between them anyway. She –reluctantly – shifted into her human form before getting dressed this morning, and now she waves goodbye to Adora as she goes marching off into the woods. It's a good thing no one is taking the bus out to the movie theatre at ten AM. She would look like a crazy person. Maybe someone from the gas station across the street could have seen, but Catra really doesnt give a shit about them.

She finds her bag stashed up in the tree where she left it and, after glancing around, lets herself begin to shift. She doesnt fully settle in her halfway form, but she just needs claws to scale up and reach the bag. Normally she could climb it in any form, but she is still in pain and needs the help today. She groans as she hauls herself into the branches, but it still doesnt hurt as much as just *existing* did on Monday morning. When she manages to grab hold of the bag, she quickly drops back down to the forest floor , leaning heavily against the tree trunk and taking a few breaths as the aches pass.

Once her breathing is level, she lets the partial shift go, settling back to fully human. She tugs off the shirt that she borrowed from Adora, swapping it out for her shitty polo shirt that smells like butter. Catra doesn't even work concessions if she can help it, but the scent of fake butter won't leave. She stuffs Adora's shirt back into the bag. She'll have to go back to her den to get her shit at some point – probably soon, before it rains or some curious wildlife decides to break into her suitcase – but she isn't planning to go running back through the woods any time soon and doesn't need to keep the bag there anymore.

Catra treks back the short walk to the bus stop and freezes when she notices Adora still parked on the side of the road, idling there and pretending she *wasn't* just squinting into the woods for any sign of Catra. She isn't very good at it. Catra stares at her through the passenger window for a moment before she comes marching up to the window. Adora's terrible act crumbles in an instant and she quickly hits the button to roll down the back window on Catra's side. Catra shrugs off her backpack and shoves it through the window so it falls onto the bench next to Melog.

"I don't get off until four, you know. You should go home," Catra remarks. She has no idea why Adora is still here. Adora doesn't seem deterred, nodding with a bright smile on her face.

"I will, I just wasn't sure how long you would be in there. Good luck at work!" she tells her. Internally, Catra's chest warms. Externally, she rolls her eyes and turns away from the car, shoving her hands in her pockets at she walks up the street. After several long seconds, she hears the sound of Adora pulling away from the curb and then driving past her. Her car really does look like shit, the front bumper smashed in and the hood crumpled from the impact. She's just lucky that the windshield somehow survived and didn't crack, because then she wouldn't be able to drive it during the day at all.

It occurs to Catra that she maybe should have asked Adora to stay as she comes wandering up on the back door into the drive-in's office and ticket booth. She doesn't own a cellphone and she has no

clue what her boss thought of her sprinting off the other night. She was done with work, but if they saw her begin to shift, they could be unnerved by something they *thought* they saw and fire her. They probably aren't spreading werewolf rumors – the coven would have heard that by now and Catra assumes Adora would have heard and told her – but at-will employment means any little thing could be the end of her "career" here.

Catra pushes open the backdoor to find her boss *right there*, watching bootleg recordings of Broadway shows on the shitty tube TV on their desk like they always are. They barely glance up at her sudden appearance, raising a brow at her before they go back to watching. *Fucking cats*. Of course it is. Well, they don't seem bothered at least. Catra refrains from breathing a sigh of relief as she heads over to the binder with the timesheets to clock in. She is walking to the door into the attached ticket booth, just thinking she got away with it, when DT has to open their mouth.

"What had you in a tizzy Sunday night?" they ask, their tone of voice making it clear that they know they're *digging*. Catra is lucky that she doesn't have a tail to lash, because it means that she manages to perfectly maintain her bored façade as she turns to face DT, who still has their eyes glued to the screen. They have a container of popcorn in their lap that they are eating each individual piece at a time. It wouldn't be weird except for how they do it so purposefully, sticking their tongue out, placing the piece on it, and then finally biting it like a *normal* person.

"I had to shit so bad I was growing a tail. I'd rather go to the woods than that port-a-potty," Catra remarks, dryly. That actually makes DT snort. Their stupid method of eating popcorn saves them from choking at least, though they do give a light cough. They still haven't looked away from the fuzzy TV screen. It's so old that they always watch these videos on VHS. When they want to watch something newer, they do it on their phone. Once again, Catra thinks she has gotten away with it. She is turning back to the doorknob when DT speaks up.

"You could just say your period is too bad to come in or something when the full moon rolls around. I still wouldn't have bought it, but you wouldn't have shredded out of a uniform that way. I'm going to charge you the replacement fee if you want a new one," they say, freezing Catra where she stands. Catra stares down at the doorknob she is holding, her blood pounding in her ears as panic grips her. Slowly, she turns her head and looks up.

DT has finally looked away from the TV screen. They are sending her a *smug* look, satisfied with having gotten the drop on her. Then, they blink each eye in turn, yellow flashing across the whites of their eyes and pupils elongating to reveal that their green eyes are somehow hiding a true yellow beneath them, as unnatural as Catra's left eye. Catra gapes at them.

She can't believe she didn't pick up on a hint somewhere along the way that her boss was a fucking werelizard. In her experience, werecreatures mostly sense the same way humans do when in their full human form. Their eyes are usually the main giveaway due to their unnaturally bright – or just plain unnatural – colors, but they also have an inherent magic to them that usually lets Catra pick them out on the street. It helps them find each other.

DT always reeks like fake butter, but Catra doesn't think magic has a *scent* that she picks up on, it is just there, hovering in the back of her mind like a sixth sense. DT seems very smug to have surprised her. Even now, *knowing* what they are, Catra can hardly pick up their magic. Looking for it, she can see they are different, but it seems like hardly enough to push them into werecreature territory over just a plain-

Ah. Shapeshifter. Right. Catra grimaces as she finally turns the doorknob. All she knows about shapeshifters is that Shadow Weaver hated them for being able to disguise their magic and pass for human. It doesn't come without drawbacks – they have no healing factor to speak of, able to change their form but just as fragile as a human at the end of the day – but it makes finding them hard.

Shadow Weaver wanted one's heart at some point, but she was never able to track one down.

"Don't schedule me for the full moon, then," Catra grunts, finally opening the door but still watching DT out of the corner of her eye. It isn't like there's anyone waiting on the other side of the ticket booth glass at ten in the morning. DT snorts, shrugging as they turn back to their tv screen.

"I'm not tracking your *cycle* for you, kitten. Just tell me when you can't take a shift," they return. Catra wants to growl, but instead she presses her mouth into a thin line and walks into the booth. DT laughs as the door swings shut behind her, but in this form that barrier is enough to cut off the sound so Catra at least doesn't have to listen to it. The office is partially soundproofed so the noise of the movies doesn't bother management.

She absolutely wasn't expecting that when she came into work today. It's nerve-wracking to know she almost got caught – well, she did get caught, but it doesn't matter – even if it turned out fine. At least now she *knows*. Having a boss that she doesn't have to lie to about what she is will be nice. This might explain why they hired her with barely any experience aside from a few short, odd jobs here and there. She always assumed they just didn't care and the job wasn't that demanding.

Actually, it's still most likely that they didn't care and she was the first person to walk in for an interview. That tracks with everything she knows about DT. Whatever. She kept her job, she didn't make a human suspicious, and her boss isn't giving her too much shit. She just has to get through a six-hour shift and then she can collapse face first in Adora's bed and never move again.

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Adora drives straight over to Glimmer's house when she returns from dropping Catra off. She could park at her own house and walk over under the covered pathways, or even fly there safely as a bat, but she prefers not to take chances with the sun. She parks in the car port, using the parasol just in case as she steps out and holds the door open for Melog. Melog hops out of the car immediately, circling around Adora's ankles for a moment before they trot away in the direction of her house.

Adora doesn't really know where they are going considering the house is locked up and she isn't heading that way, but they never look back to her, so apparently they don't mind the idea of lounging on her porch for a bit. Adora climbs up the stairs of Glimmer's wrap-around porch and makes her way to the backdoor that acts as Glimmer's primary entryway. She knocks loudly and slides the backdoor open as Glimmer comes careening out of the home office.

Adora smiles to herself as she closes her parasol and steps inside. Glimmer's antics have always amused her. Today, Glimmer comes running up and wraps her in a hug like Adora's two days holed up in her own house have been some great chasm between them. Bow emerges from the office next, smiling when he spots Glimmer squeezing Adora tight.

"I hate to tell you this, Adora, but I think your girlfriend might be a bitch," Glimmer tells her as she pulls away from the hug. Adora twitches at the phrasing, but after a minute she smiles to herself and shrugs.

"I know," she responds, her tone far too fond. Glimmer sends her a disgusted look. If she didn't want to know how that made Adora feel, then she shouldn't have said it. "And she isn't my girlfriend," Adora corrects, walking into the living room proper and dropping down heavily on the couch. Glimmer and Bow exchange glances with each other over the top of Adora's head. Okay, she probably sounded too dejected about that. Adora clears her throat.

"I mean, Ill be happy with whatever she is comfortable with, you just might upset her if you call her that, so please don't. I've upset her enough, even before I hit her with a car," Adora elaborates. Glimmer snorts while Bow looks a touch pained, but he's mortal and can't quite get it. Catra was hit by a car Sunday night and now she's handing out movie tickets. Injuries and moving on from them has always been a part of their supernatural lives.

"You haven't talked about it, huh?" Glimmer asks, moving to sit down next to her. They need to deal with all the paperwork generated by the coven blood donation network, but Adora takes a moment of self-pity to sigh and shake her head. It prompts Bow to walk over too, sitting down on the other end of the sofa so Adora has a best friend on either side of her, providing moral support. Adora swears she is fine, just a bit anxious, but when is she *not* anxious? She is just doing her best to be realistic here given all that has happened between them.

"We were kind of together before, but we never got to talk about it. Now that she's back and healing up, it's starting to feel a lot like before, but. Well, we were each other's only option then and I *killed* her. She has a lot to process. I'm just waiting to see how she feels now," Adora admits, shrugging. She has told Glimmer and Bow pretty much her whole life's story, even if she skimmed over a lot of the bad parts.

Glimmer and Bow know enough to know that learning more would just make them want to go get a shovel and dig up Shadow Weaver's grave. They knew about Catra almost from day one. It's kind of difficult to get Adora to shut up about her, even back at the five-year mark. She only stopped talking about her when the bond broke and she feared that she could be dead. Glimmer and Bow know that them kissing is what led to the punishment that ultimately ended in Adora taking Catra's life.

Fuck, when she thinks about it like that, it seems like it would be impossible for Catra to want her again, especially after having been out in the world and having had the chance to get to know or even

grow close to regular people. It makes more sense for Catra to befriend another *vampire* than it does for her to fall into bed with the one who bled dry. Then again, Adora's bed is right where Catra was last night. Adora kind of doubts that Catra still loves her the same way, but maybe she will still want to be with her as a friend.

It seems like her last few years were lonely. Adora sighs heavily, reaching a hand up to brush the flyaway hairs from her ponytail out of her face. When she lowers her hand, she notices Melog standing at the backdoor, apparently done waiting for Adora to show up at her own house. The moment that they make eye contact, Melog loudly mews, startling both Glimmer and Bow. Despite her worries, Adora feels herself smile a little as she stands and walks towards the backdoor.

"I'm pet-sitting, I guess, while Catra's at work. Can they come inside?" she asks, pausing and glancing over her shoulder just before she opens the door. Melog immediately begins batting at the glass impatiently, causing Glimmer to raise an eyebrow at them. Okay, so they left a slightly dirty pawprint. Adora hopes that is just because they walked in something and not their mud coming loose or something. Adora really doesn't know how that works.

"Are you going to keep using them as an excuse not to talk?" Glimmer shoots back. Adora pulls a face at her and pointedly opens the backdoor. Melog immediately strolls inside, winding around Adora's ankles again. They can't even scent mark, smelling mostly of magic, earth, and Catra, but apparently they still enjoy emulating the marking behavior that a normal cat would have.

Adora hasn't seen Catra pick Melog up once yet, but Melog seems to like pets and scratches like a normal cat, so she bends down and cautiously lifts them up. They don't hiss at her, though they do go limp in a way that makes her wonder if they really want to be held. Once she flips them onto their back and cradles them up against her chest like a baby, though, they blink slowly and melt into her arms. Clearly they enjoy that. Adora crosses back over to the sofa, cuddling them up in her lap.

"I really just don't know how she feels right now," Glimmer said. "I'm giving her time. Catra doesn't like being backed in a corner. Don't we have work to do?" Adora shoots back, petting a hand through the ultra-soft fur on Melog's belly. Glimmer narrows her eyes at Adora, but she has seen for herself how Catra gets when cornered. After a moment of all but glaring at Adora, Glimmer sighs and heads back to the office to fetch their paperwork.

Adora grins down at Melog almost conspiratorially. It makes Bow chuckle to himself, but Adora ignores them as she ducks down and risks kissing Melog's tummy. They batt lazily at her ponytail, but they don't protest it. They're just as soft as Catra is when she is shifted into her preferred form, and they will have to do for now, because Adora is betting that she isn't going to get to kiss Catra's stomach for a while now.

"You're such a cat person it's disgusting," Glimmer informs her when she comes walking back with her stack of forms. Adora hums and kisses the top of Melog's little head instead. She can't argue with that.

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When Catra gets into Adora's car after work, Melog immediately climbs in her lap and begins purring. Catra sets to giving them ear scritches as Adora looks over with a fond but somewhat nervous expression on her face. Catra raises a brow at her.

"What, did you fuck up babysitting somehow? You know I can just ask Melog what you did wrong. We can communicate," Catra tells her. Adora's eyes get a bit wide but Melog, the liar, claims that nothing went wrong and shows her images of the stupid blood donation paperwork that Adora spent her afternoon on. Well, that explains where she is getting her blood from. It eases Catra some to

see the source of it. She poked around in Adora's fridge during breakfast this morning and seeing the blood was assuring, but so is seeing how she goes about getting it.

She likes knowing that Adora is at no risk of starving, with or without her. She has no desire to become Adora's blood bag again, at least outside of occasional fantasies. Okay, and maybe she would happily act those fantasies out, but it wouldn't be *feeding*. It wouldn't leave her weak and barely able to walk. Glancing over, she catches Adora watching her with an unreadable look in her eye. Catra flushes, hunching her shoulders and bundling Melog a little higher up her chest.

"What? Get driving. I smell like fucking popcorn and I want to shower while you're dropping off your car," Catra tells her. Adora startles a little. Probably because she snapped, but she doesn't know why Adora is giving her that look and she has been dealing with customers all day, no matter how limited they were in number. Adora quickly moves to put the car in drive though, heading off down the street and past the theatre as Catra sets to snuggling Melog.

She would like to cuddle Adora, truthfully, but she's driving right now and Catra doesn't want to make her smell like popcorn too. Cuddles will have to wait until after she has showered and Adora comes back. Maybe she will nap. It would be nice to be awake for some of the night and see what Adora gets up to when she isn't sitting around. In the driver's seat, Adora seems weirdly energized now that she has realized Melog isn't ratting her out for whatever she did. Melog overheard *something*, but they aren't telling Catra what. They say it's stupid.

"How do you two talk?" Adora asks, suddenly cheery as she glances at where Catra now has Melog tucked under her chin. For a moment, Catra swears she sees jealousy flash across Adora's face. Adora quickly refocuses on the road, however, so it's hard to say. Catra smiles a little to herself, tucking her face against Melog so Adora can't see it. Maybe Adora wants to cuddle too. Well, she'll have to

wait. Waiting doesn't sound so bad now it's torturing Adora too and not just her.

"Just thoughts, I guess. I can see through their eyes too, so don't go walking naked in front of them unless you want to show off," Catra tells her, grinning when it makes Adora sputter and grip the wheel tightly. Adora desperately keeps her eyes fixed forward, her embarrassment obvious as she shifts a little in her seat. Catra rolls her eyes at the same time that Melog wrinkles their nose and mews admonishingly.

"They don't get things like desire, though, so they would prefer if you didn't. I mean, they don't mind naked bodies, but you get my point. They're my familiar, but they are their own being too. They wouldn't generate the magic to keep me going otherwise," Catra explains, shrugging as she pets the top of Melog's head. She has never had to explain Melog before. The only other person who has ever met them really was the witch who made them for her. At that time, Madame Razz explained how Melog would work to her – poorly, but enough for Catra to get it – not the other way around.

"Keep you going?" Adora asks, her voice soft. A hint of anxious nerves is laced in it. Catra pauses, her mouth twisting as she thinks about her reply. She didn't mean to bring that up. She doesn't want to lie to Adora, but she definitely doesn't want to tell her all the details. She sighs, shifting to finally place Melog down in her lap and setting to petting them as they vibrate gently to soothe her.

"I purged the vampire venom, but I still need magic to sustain me. Having Melog means I have enough of a supply to live without having to feed on other's blood to get it," Catra explains. She doesn't need to explain how all that came to be. She is explaining her situation now that the ritual is done, so it's still the truth. Adora frowns, but she looks thoughtful as she bobs her head at her windshield. She seems satisfied to have gotten an explanation at all.

"Besides, I like them. It's like having a soulmate. I did everything I could to break the bond, but it was nice to have a connection I knew

wasn't a risk after it was gone," Catra adds, giving Melog a rolling scratch down their back that has their eyes slowly blinking closed. Adora winces a bit, but she nods. As much as Catra hated the idea of someone being in her head, it was because she was afraid of what someone could do with that power, so it was nice to replace that bond with Melog when she purged the vampirism from her body.

In a way, she thinks it has helped with her being able to trust again, even though Melog couldn't plot against her in secret if they wanted to anyway. They agree that it's like being soulmates. They like it. They like Catra. They're sweet. Oh, they like Adora too. Alright, time to shut up now. Melog slowly opens their eyes to send Catra a downright smug expression. Yes, of course they like Adora, *Catra* does a quite unreasonable amount and there has to be some transfer property to her familiar. She narrows her eyes down at them.

"You're doing that communication thing now, huh?" Adora asks, side-eyeing Catra when she pulls up to a stop sign. Catra feels her cheeks heat, suddenly caught.

"None of your business," she replies, turning to look out the window instead. She doesn't want to see the amused look on Adora's face as she drives them home.

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Catra never gives any indication that Adora should take her anywhere but back to the farm – when she talks about taking a shower while Adora's gone at the mechanic, Adora feels excitement spike in her throat – so Adora drives them home happily. Micah must spot her driving past the main house, because he shows up at her door before Catra is done stripping out of her uniform and muttering darkly about *butter*. She does smell like theatre popcorn, but Adora

always thought that stuff smelled good, so she doesnt get what the big deal is.

Catra must really hate it though, because she stays in human form as she walks out of the bedroom in just Adora's robe and dumps her polo in Adora's washing machine. Apparently she doesnt want to have her stronger senses anywhere close to it. Adora suddenly doesnt want to leave when Catra hops into the shower and starts giving happy sighs of relief from the hot water hitting her skin, but Micah is doing her a favor by following her out in his car and driving her back, so she bids Melog farewell in Catra's stead and heads out.

The mechanic is just about to close, but Adora is able to tell him her bullshit story about hitting a deer and ask him to work on the car tomorrow, leaving behind the keys. She intended to tell Micah about the Melog thing on the drive back, thinking it might give him or Angella some idea of what Catra's situation is now – Adora is glad that Catra told her, but she doesnt really understand how it is magically possible still – but instead she gets a fatherly disappointment talk from Micah when he asks her how the accident actually went and she admits that she was driving with her headlights off.

She stands by the fact that she doesnt need them, but he points out that this accident proves just how important they are for helping other people on the road to spot her. Adora feels thoroughly chagrinned, shrinking down further and further into her seat. Micah doesnt yell or get angry , he just has this gentle disappointment that devastates Adora after everything he and his family have done for her. She wants to make them proud, not wreck their cars.

"How' s your girl doing?" he eventually asks as they pull back onto the main road into the farm, finally changing the subject when they are close enough that Adora can see the cluster of houses up ahead. He really shouldnt use phrasing like that when she is only a minute or two from seeing Catra. It has to be bad for her heart and she doesnt even need hers to beat.

"God. She wasn't even that cranky after work today," Adora tells him. Micah chuckles at that, shaking his head slightly as he heads for her carport to let her out.

"Well, when she's a bit more settled in, we'd love to have her at dinner so we can all meet her," he says. The words make Adora's heart twist weirdly, but she nods. She has no idea if Catra would be okay with that, but maybe. It's just dinner, right? It doesn't have to be a "we're dating and you're meeting my surrogate family" thing. Or at least, Catra doesn't have to *know* that's what it really is. Adora would have to talk to everyone and get them to agree to be subtle beforehand though.

It would be complicated. Adora bids Micah goodbye with her head spinning a little. The walk from the carport to her front door is both covered and brief, but she still opens her parasol just to have the security of ducking beneath it while she tries to push such thoughts from her head. She shouldn't be thinking like this when she is around Catra. She is trying to be patient and give her all the room that she could need to decide what she wants for them going forward.

When Adora opens her front door, she takes a moment to cast her senses about. Catra is in the bedroom, though her heartbeat is going too fast for her to be asleep. Just resting then. She was feeling better yesterday and a *lot* better today, but spending six hours working had to be draining after spending two days mostly bedbound. Adora quietly puts away her parasol and takes off her shoes before heading to the bedroom. She is quiet, though not silent. She doesn't want to disturb Catra, but she knows that she is still awake and doesn't want to sneak up on her either.

When she opens the bedroom door, she finds Catra lying on her stomach on the bed, her cheek squashed against the pillow. She is settled into her preferred form, just barely cracking her eyes open to look at Adora through slit pupils. Melog is curled up at the foot of the bed, their nose tucked into their paws as they somehow make themselves into a perfect circle. Catra yawns, a long, drawn-out

sound like a rusty door. It makes fondness blossom in Adora's chest as Catra finishes and blinks slowly at her.

"Chere," Catra murmurs, moving her head back and forth a little to rub her cheek against Adora's pillows, marking them as her own. Adora instantly perks up, stepping forward and very carefully climbing onto the bed so she doesnt disturb Melog. She gets on top of the sheets so she doesnt track anything from outside into the bed, but apparently that enforces too much distance between them, because Catra rolls closer and tucks herself right into Adora's arms, instantly beginning to rumble softly as her body settles down for sleep.

It seems like she didnt feel safe enough to sleep on her own, because the second she has Adora watching over her, she drifts right off into blissful peace. Adora cradles her close, feeling an overwhelming emotion she knows the name of but refuses to think right now. It feels so close, but she knows it still has to be so far. She satisfies herself with waiting until she is certain that Catra is asleep and kissing the top of her head.

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Catra naps for most of the afternoon, so by the time sunset rolls around, she is actually rested. It means that she gets to see what Adora does at night. Her soreness is mostly gone and Adora seems eager when Catra asks her about where they are – all she really knows is what Adora told her when she first woke up and what little she saw out the window when Adora drove her to work – so Catra accompanies her on a walk around the farm. Adora shows her the fields, the small flock of chickens and goats, and the donkeys that apparently guard them.

It is really obvious vampires live here. The barn has fucking stained glass windows. Almost all the buildings, including the barn, are within eyeshot of each other, and there are covered walkways between them that feel strangely romantic to stroll through. Melog follows behind them as Adora shows her around, and Catra is startled when Adora waves up to a window in the big house at the front of the property. A glance up reveals a woman watching them through it. She smiles to Adora and waves back like a fucking pageant queen.

"That's Angella," Adora explains. Catra eyes her. They are too far away for Catra to really sense her, but she is oddly pale. She doesn't look halfdead like Shadow Weaver did, but neither does Adora. Catra is pretty sure most things were a Shadow Weaver problem and not that indicative of vampires as a whole, though. "Usually we work together at night, but I thought you might like it better if it was just us," Adora explains as she leads her out towards the fields. For some reason, that makes Catra flush.

She can't deny that Adora is right. Catra ends up trailing after her with Melog by her side as Adora goes about a series of farm chores underneath the moonlight. There's a faint breeze in the air that ruffles her fur and should be grounding, but it all feels like a lucid dream. Part of it is just the time of day, but it's weird to see Adora farming of all things. It's weird to be back with Adora at all. Catra never stopped thinking about her, but logically, part of her knew that they could never be back together.

She didn't think she would find Adora with a metaphorical white picket fence set up, free of their tormentor. She wanted everything with her, but she always thought that they would end up as nothing. Now they have an eternity of possibilities stretching out before them. Catra catches herself watching Adora's smiles closely, partially because she likes seeing how often she does it even as she engages in hard labor, but also just to look at her teeth.

There isn't a good reason to be tracking their glint in the moonlight when Adora looks up from inspecting crops and flashes her a bright grin before returning to work. There are no threats here, and Adora's

fangs aren't even visible right now. She has usually sharp canines, but they're the same length as her other teeth when she isn't preparing to feed. Catra is still looking for them. She can't help but remember her dream last night.

She shivers in the night breeze. Melog stands and pads closer, jumping up into her lap despite how she is posed somewhat precariously on the edge of a table with gardening tools strewn across it. Catra curls around them gratefully, beginning to pet them to soothe them both. Through the bond, a warm content begins to grow. Still, with her free hand, Catra reaches up and traces her fingers over the two points of scar tissue on her neck, the turning bite having left behind two of the only three scars on her entire body.

She cut her hair because it was too hard to take care of when she didn't have consistent access to a shower, but it leaves her neck very exposed. A small part of her is afraid to feel Adora's fangs again, whispering reminders of what happened last time. The rest of her? The rest of her craves it like a drug, to have Adora brace above her in the bed and bring her utter bliss, showing her that she really is safe now when she drinks but *stops*. In her lap, Melog mews softly. Instantly, Adora's head pops up from the other end of the field.

Catra waves vaguely to her before she drops a hand to the back of Melog's neck and gently squeezes, passing a message to them. She needs her things from her den, and she also needs some alone time with Adora. Melog obliges her, jumping down to the ground and shaking out to their full size. They butt against her hip for a moment, getting one last pet in, before they turn and walk out into the field. They know where they're going. After all, they ran to here from the den when Catra was injured.

Even across the vast distance, Adora looks confused as she watches Melog disappear. Catra just wraps an arm around herself. They'll be back. Tonight, she just needs Adora. She isn't having this talk out in an open field, though. It will have to wait until Adora's farm work is done.

Chapter End Notes

I changed the fucking chapter count and Iḿ not proud of it.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora watches Melog walk off into the night with a deep sense of confusion. She finishes the row she is on and then returns to Catra only to be waved off.

"They're going to get something. They'll be gone for a bit," is the only explanation that Catra gives her. Adora tries to ask what *something* means, but Catra just tells her to get back to work. Adora does so reluctantly only because she wants to finish her work early, before there is any sign of the sun or Catra gets too tired. Catra used to live nocturnally, but she didn't really have a choice when they were kids.

Now she has a job during the daytime and probably doesn't want to stay up all night. She doesn't have work tomorrow, but Adora has already arranged to borrow one of the farm trucks to drive her to her next shift, and she mentioned that she works again on Thursday while she was eating dinner and telling Adora about realizing her boss was a shapeshifter. Even with a manager in the community who should be understanding, she needs to be rested and alert when she has a shift.

They head back a few hours before dawn. Melog still isn't back, and Catra still isn't responsive about where they went. Adora hops in the shower when they get back to wash off the dirt. Her body doesn't produce a lot of oils or anything, but grime is grime. She listens to Catra roam around her house while she is washing up, poking at things and opening drawers. Adora is honestly surprised it took her this long to inspect the place, but she couldn't exactly do it while she was injured. She did poke around Adora's blood fridge at the first opportunity.

Catra is in bed when Adora walks out of the bathroom. She knew she was there, but she expected her to be lying down to go to bed. Instead, she finds Catra sitting up and watching her with bright eyes, her ears pricked forward. Adora freezes, feeling an odd shivering sensation run through her at being the center of Catra's focus so completely. Catra is lounging where she is waiting, her legs curled in front of her on top of the sheets. She looks *inviting*, her gaze burning in that way that Adora knows well. The last time Catra looked at her like this, she seemed to need to be held. This- this look is hungrier.

Adora can smell desire in the air. She swallows, stepping forward and approaching the bed. Catra's eyes only darken as she approaches. Adora's fangs ache from the look alone, though Catra's scent growing heady and intoxicating doesnt help either. Adora hesitates at the edge of the bed, only a few inches between her and Catra. Catra's pulse is quickening with every passing second as she tilts her head up to look Adora in the face. It also tilts her chin back, exposing more of her neck. Fuck, Catra cant seriously be asking her to feed, can she? She just wants *intimacy*, surely. Adora swallows, opening her mouth to ask what Catra wants-

She is cut off by the sound of her back door opening, startling them both. Adora whips around, her hearing straining as quiet feet pad away from the door. She cant smell a damn thing other than Catra, but before she can fly forward to challenge the intruder, Catra's hand snatches out and grabs her wrist, gripping her tightly as something heavy begins scraping on the porch, dragged up the steps by the quiet interloper.

"It's just Melog. They went to get my suitcase," Catra tells her, her voice low and a touch breathy. *Seductive*. Adora swallows, turning to look back down at Catra as the apparent suitcase reaches the top of the porch steps. Melog's paws are silent as they drag it to the backdoor that they somehow opened. Catra is looking up at her with an almost *hopeful* expression, still carefully poised with her legs on display and her tail curling around herself. She looks oddly vulnerable. Whatever she wants, she *really* wants it.

The sound of a giant cat dragging luggage into the living room is more than a bit distracting, but Adora wants to give Catra anything that she could ask. The problem is that Melog's return has reminded her there is no way they can do anything more than cuddling without talking first, and Catra hates talking. It would certainly kill the mood. Still holding her gaze, Catra lets go of her wrist and drops her hand back down to the mattress behind her so she can lean back again, giving Adora an excellent view of Catra in her borrowed running shorts and the sweater she took to guard against the night breeze. *Her clothes*. If Catra is even wearing underwear, it is Adora's too.

"They needed me to let them in before," Adora says, still trying to figure out how the hell to ask Catra to talk about how she feels, quite possibly the question that she wants to answer the least on the planet. The scraping stops somewhere near the sofa, and then the almost-silent footfalls head out the backdoor and, as if to prove Adora's point, are quickly followed by the sound of the backdoor closing. Catra rolls her eyes, looking a bit exasperated by Adora being slow on the uptake. Oh no, Adora definitely *got it*.

"They could have opened it if they really needed to. I just didn't want to talk to you," she clarifies. Adora blinks at her, surprised. It seems to take Catra a second to realize how that sounds. She bites her lip. "Oh, come on, you had just hit me with your car. I wasn't feeling *chatty*," Catra corrects. It isn't much of a correction, but despite how it makes Adora wince a little, it is fair. Actually, that might just be her opening.

"Yeah. Sorry about that, by the way. I don't think I ever actually apologized," Adora says, reaching down to place her hand on Catra's knee. Her voice is a bit breathless from hope, and it isn't even because she wants something horny. Well, okay, she is definitely hoping they get to do *something* tonight, but she also really wants to talk. She gently begins to rub, not breaking eye contact with Catra. She wants to keep the *intent* there so Catra doesn't think she is rejecting her or anything. Catra's breath catches at the touch, her tail dancing in her lap as the tip quickly twitches.

"You didn't mean to," Catra responds, her voice similar in tone to Adora's, though her desire shines through. She *wants*. Fuck, Adora does too. Catra's heartbeat is going so fast. Adora can hear it, smell it, and practically see it in the subtle pulse of the skin covering Catra's throat. Catra has given her the perfect opening for exactly what she needs to say before they go further, though. She has to take it. This won't feel right until she does.

"There's other things that I didn't mean to do, but I still need to apologize for them. I want to make them right so we can be *us* again," Adora tells her. She feels a bit lightheaded with the declaration out there. *Us* is a lot. *Us* tells Catra that she still loves her. Fuck, she wants eternity with her. Even if the word alone doesn't say that last part, Catra definitely gets the rest of it, because her eyes widen and her ears pin back.

She stares up at Adora for a long moment, the pounding of her heart filling the room. Adora can feel her fangs distinctly in her mouth, responding to Catra's racing heart. She keeps her mouth closed, not wanting to stress Catra with their appearance while she waits for her response. She knows Catra started off all but offering her neck, but she doesn't want to pressure her—or worse, *scare* her—if this talk has changed her mind.

"Adora, I just want..." she trails off. Adora knows at least some of what she wants, but this has to happen first. At least, she hopes Catra is just trying to discourage her from an emotional talk and not telling her that she doesn't want to be *them* anymore. Adora doesn't think Catra would have made an offer like this to her if she didn't want more between them. Adora shakes her head, gently squeezing Catra's knee.

"I know. But I need to say I'm sorry first," Adora tells her. Catra presses her lips together, her expression conflicted, but she still nods. Adora draws in a breath. "I killed you. I would never hurt you when I had control, but I chose to kiss you, and that's what got us both the starvation punishment. That's what made all of it happen. I should have thought about the danger to you. I should have thought

at *all*. I'm sorry ," Adora tells her , her voice strained, but these words have waited seven years to come out and they're tremulous.

Catra swallows, blinking at her, and then she nods shakily. Adora blows out a breath, resuming the slow rubbing of her thumb on Catra's knee. She feels like there are more words in her chest, but she doesn't know what they are. What can words do, really , to heal someone you *murdered*? She doesn't know that anything she says could be enough. She has imagined this conversation so many times, sometimes while Catra was hurling insults at her and sometimes between desperate kisses, but now it feels like all those imagined words are slipping through her hands.

" I swore I would never let myself get like that again. I have a constant blood supply, so I never *need* to feed on you, and I should never enter bloodlust again. You're safe with me, and if my blood supply suddenly fails, I'll do what it takes to stop myself as soon as I start getting desperate. I'm not going to hurt someone again, least of all you," Adora tells her . It isn't the grand declaration that she had planned, an oath to throw herself upon the sword before she lets herself be a danger to Catra again, but the sentiment is there at least.

Catra's breath shudders. Her expression is more conflicted than ever. Her tail tightly curls around her own legs, like she is trying to withdraw from the words, though she hasn't moved otherwise. She looks upset, but Adora knows that the entire subject is distressing. She keeps rubbing the gentle circles into her skin, hoping to soothe her as she processes her words.

" Adora, I- That isn't the part that I was mad at you for . I kissed you too," Catra tells her , her voice conflicted, caught between relief and tension. Adora stares at her, blinking slowly. What *other part* is there? She kissed Catra, they got caught, she mauled Catra when they are reunited, and Adora was force to raise-

Adora draws in a breath as she realizes what Catra means. Catra never wanted to be a vampire.

"Catra, even if you hated me, I'd rather you were alive than *dead*," Adora tells her, her tone a bit desperate, but she can't stand to even say it. She feared Catra could be dead for two years and sometimes she thought about falling into hibernation herself on the off-chance that she woke up one day and the bond was back. She has never fucking forgiven herself for killing Catra, but she wouldn't have been able to *live* with herself if she hadn't raised Catra. She can't apologize for that. She meant it. Catra's lip curls at the words, the ghost of snarl, though there isn't anger in her eyes, just pain.

"Newsflash, I *wasn't alive*. And you have no idea the things that I had to do to claw my way back to a heartbeat. Some of us don't want to kill to sustain ourselves," Catra returns, her voice shaking and raw. Adora can hear seven years of pain finally being aired in it, but she recoils herself at the words, tears springing to life in her eyes as all the old guilt that has threatened to bring her down innumerable times wells up in her throat. If it were any easier for a vampire to die, Adora would be gone by now. There have been too many times when she couldn't pretend that she didn't deserve it for the lives that she has taken.

"I know you've always been disgusted by what I am, Catra, but that was low," Adora manages, her voice trembling as she draws herself up to a standing position just to *get away*. It's true, it's *too* true, and that's why it hurts so fucking much. She thinks these things about herself, but hearing Catra call her a killer is too much despite how no one else in the world has earned it more. Catra should be spitting the words at her and brandishing garlic in her direction, trying to protect herself from the monster she is sharing a bed with, but that doesn't make it hurt any less to hear.

Catra's eyes are wide, her mouth open in a wordless gape. Adora can't take it. She turns and flees the room. She won't go far, but fuck, she needs to cry and she can't do that where Catra can see. She earned those words. Catra doesn't deserve the guilt trip of seeing her cry about them.

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One moment Catra can smell Adora's excitement as she approaches her, both of them *eager* , and then the next she is pushing too far . Talking before they do this would probably have been healthy if Catra hadn't fucked it up. She let her anger get the better of her . Her emotions always flare strongly. After a lifetime of extreme pain, her reaction to everything is equally intense. The apology went well – Catra didn't really realize she needed it until Adora of fered it – until Adora makes the mention of her being alive. Nothing has ever felt further from the truth.

Those five years were miserable. Catra spent them crawling from city to city, living in shitholes or completely homeless, chasing any rumor she could and always wondering if the next time she needed blood would be the one where she couldn't catch enough animals and had to hurt a person. She didn't like hurting the animals any better, but she didn't feel like a murderer at least. She still had to hear whimpers of pain as she drained the life out of something. When she finally heard of a witch who could help with the magically impossible, she was nearing the end of what she could handle.

She wasn't alive, but she didn't mean to make Adora feel like that. It feels like all the warmth leaves the room with Adora despite how she barely generates any body heat. Adora leaves the house, heading out the back door and closing it behind her. Catra can hear her pacing around on the porch, but the walls between them prevent her from sensing much more than that. She still knows that Adora is crying. Catra squeezes her own eyes shut, not sure if she wants to cry with her or run out there and throw herself into her arms.

Catra's throat is tight. She flops back on the bed, lying on her stomach so she can bury her face in the pillows. She desperately reaches out for Melog and they come running. They aren't too far , but Adora has stopped pacing by the time they arrive, just standing out on the back porch and contemplating what a vile person Catra is.

Catra listens to Melog lightly batt at the backdoor, but she doesnt twitch in the bed. She isnt getting up. She doesnt want to see Adora crying through the glass backdoor. Melog will have to open it for themselves.

Or not, because after a few seconds of batting, the backdoor opens and Melog quietly pads inside along with Adora's footsteps. Catra just *told* her that Melog can open it for themselves. She should just let them do it, but apparently she has to help. The door closes as Melog heads straight for the bedroom. Catra's breath catches, waiting, but Adora doesnt follow Melog, instead settling on the couch. When Melog slips through the open bedroom door, Catra catches the traces of salt in the air, though Adora is too quiet to be crying anymore.

Melog jumps up on the bed, their expression morose and mane a deep shade of blue when they pad around to sniff softly at Catra's face and lick her cheek. Their head is hung a little as they delicately jump over her to tuck themselves in against her waist as a protective barrier between her and Adora despite how she just wants Adora *back*. Having Melog here with her is nowhere near the same. She can hear Adora in the living room, shifting on the couch. The TV turns on, and then immediately off, but Adora doesnt move.

Me. This fucking considerate asshole is watching the TV with subtitles on so the sound doesnt bother Catra even after Catra made her cry. Catra has always known that Adora struggled with having to hurt others just to continue her own existence. She was especially conflicted by the pain that she caused Catra. What Catra said brought up all that guilt. She didnt even consider the pain it would cause Adora, too wrapped up in the reminder of her own pain over the last seven years, but Adora, a *good person* despite what she has been forced to do, is considerate enough to still think about her hearing in this moment.

It only makes Catra feel worse. Part of her almost cant believe that Adora thinks she is *disgusted* by her, but the rest of her knows it is how Adora feels about herself, so of course she thinks Catra feels

that way. And in some ways, Adora is even right to assume that, but despite Catra's wariness about vampire in general, that category never included Adora to her, not then and not now that she has been out for years and learned that Adora was not a singular exception. Being around strange vampires still makes Catra uncomfortable and she doesn't think that can easily change after how they were raised, but she is willing to give individuals a chance, at least in theory.

Shadow Weaver was awful and made it hard for Catra to trust, but she also had Adora to show her that everyone didn't have to be like that. Especially once she was on the run, often meeting other supernatural folk in her quest to find a cure, she learned that Shadow Weaver was awful and it had nothing to do with her being a vampire. She knows that every vampire is not always waiting to hurt her or to feed on her for being disobedient. She doesn't instantly trust *anyone*, but she isn't disgusted by vampires who obtain blood morally.

She has said a lot of things about vampires over the years, though. She thought Adora understood that her rants about *vampires* were shorthand for *ShadowWeaver* since it certainly wouldn't be safe to directly sneer at their captor, but now she is realizing that Adora just internalized it all. How would Adora know, anyway? Catra never *told* her that she was an exception in every way, a fucking shining beacon in the middle of misery.

Has Adora spent her entire life thinking, what, that Catra despises her on principle but still put up with her because she was all she had? The very thought makes the center of her chest ache, but she fears it is correct. She rolls over in Adora's bed, nuzzling into the sheets and just *wishing*. Wishing that Adora needed sleep, wishing that she would stop watching the TV in silence, wishing that she would come and confront her about it so Catra can tell her the truth. Fuck, she needs to tell Adora *something*, but she doesn't know where to start.

Quietly, Melog stands from the bed. They stretch their back out, long and slow, before hopping down to the ground beside the bed and

padding back out the bedroom door. Catra didnt tell them to go, but she doesnt try to stop them as they walk right up to Adora and begin nudging at her. Catra listens to the slight sounds of confusion Adora makes in her throat as she tries to scoot away from Melog on the couch and give them room, but they dont want room and they arent going to be deterred.

Melog bats at her and Adora lets out a quiet, scolding hiss. Yeah, that's not going to stop them. They are *Catra's* familiar after all. They're stubborn through and through. Quietly, they bully Adora until they get fed up and nip her. The bite isnt harsh, but Adora finally stands up to jerk away now since Melog has already gotten her to scoot all the way to the end of the couch. Once she has stood, Melog is not letting her sit back down again. Their determination almost makes Catra smile into the pillow as they all but shove Adora across the living room.

It isnt until Adora is halfway to the bedroom that she seems to realize what is happening, stopping dead in her tracks. Through Melog's eyes, Catra sees her staring at the bedroom door with trepidation. Catra's tail involuntarily thuds against the bed, causing her to wince a little. Adora can hear that. Catra waits. Hopefully she realizes this means that Catra wants her to come back and she doesnt think she is trying to *haras* her or something. Melog gets fed up with them both, softly nipping at Adora's ankle. She doesnt jerk this time, but she does start forward.

The bedroom door creaks a little as Adora pushes it all the way open. Catra swallows. Her face is turned towards the window, still dark as dawn slowly approaches, and she cant see Adora now. Melog is standing behind her, making sure she goes in before they leave. After several moments of standing, silent and still, Adora begins moving again. She approaches the bed carefully, her caution obvious when she gently sits on the edge of it. After a moment of hesitating, she moves to lie back so slowly it is like she thinks she is sneaking in behind Catra. She doesnt disturb the mattress or even touch her as she settles in.

Melog closes the door with a soft snap. It makes Adora whip her head around, no doubt staring as Melog heads out the backdoor once again and pads down the porch steps. They really aren't going far this time, worried that Catra will need them, but she hopes not. Talking is hard, but clearly she and Adora need to do it. Catra sighs, turning over and scooting to tuck herself beneath Adora's chin before she can look at her face. She really doesn't want to see the hurt on it or any lingering tear trails.

Adora draws in a sharp breath, stiffening beneath her. Despite all the times that Adora has held her apparently thinking this way the whole time, Catra is afraid she is going to pull away. After a moment, however, Adora's arms come up to wrap around her, holding her tight against her chest. Catra feels the tension leak out of her own shoulders as a weak purr starts, nudging into Adora's neck and seeking the pulse point where she can truly smell her.

"I'm sorry ," Adora whispers, her voice rough. Catra stif fens in her arms. "I'm sorry for saying that. Y ou have every right to feel that way with how we grew up and how many times I fed on you," Adora breathes out, the guilt obvious in her voice. Catra wasn't expecting that at all. It isn't *right* . She doesn't think Adora is a monster and she doesn't want Adora to feel like she is right to do so. Catra is shaking a little, she realizes.

"I'm not disgusted by you, Adora," she tells her , her voice tight along with her throat, but she needs to force the words out. Above her, Adora pauses. "And I don't hate vampires. Or you," Catra adds, while she has the strength too. She feels Adora shift, trying to pull back. She hates the weak whimper she gives in response, but at least it draws Adora to a halt. After a moment, she tucks Catra back beneath her chin and squeezes her tightly just like she needs.

"I don't understand," Adora replies, and fuck, she really sounds *confused* , like she can't conceptualize some part of Catra not detesting her. Catra squeezes her eyes shut and shakes her head a little.

"I know you never would have hurt anyone if it weren't for Shadow Weaver. Anything mean I ever said, it was directed at her. You were what got me *through* it. She was just evil. And I might not be comfortable around new vampires, but I don't hate them," Catra explains. It isn't enough, but it is all she has. She needs Adora to understand that she isn't some monster looming in the dark to her. She can sense a trace of hope coming off Adora, but Adora doesn't seem to have the words to reply.

"I- I was furious with you for making me your sire, but you are right that I would rather be *here*. I just didn't want anyone to have control over me like that, especially not Shadow Weaver. That's why it was so important I fix it. It wasn't about... not wanting to be like you," Catra tells her. She hated hunting, but if she hadn't been so focused on finding a cure, she probably could have settled down with a coven and gotten a blood supply that was freely donated. There was just a part of her that refused to feed on humans after what she had experienced as an unwilling blood bag.

Adora is the one shivering now, despite the fact that she shouldn't be able to. Catra clings to her, burying her face in her neck, not having any other words. She was about to ask Adora to fucking feed on her before all this happened. She would never do that if she was disgusted by the act of feeding itself, even if she always felt torn about it before. On one hand, it was draining, and demeaning, and *hurt*. On the other, it was a euphoric high like no other. A high she only ever got when it was Adora's lips on her neck. When it wasn't-

It was rare. She was Adora's special bitch, the only one who could meet her thirst. Adora didn't mind her anatomy, but Shadow Weaver fucking hated how Catra couldn't stop herself from shifting when she detected the danger of fangs approaching her neck. It was only ever as punishment that Shadow Weaver lowered herself to feed from Catra directly. Catra felt only fear when it was Shadow Weaver, the unnatural peace sweeping through her body and making her limp, compliant. She felt like she was screaming on the inside but couldn't move to fight it.

It was never like that with Adora. Sure, it hurt for a second, but then Adora's lips would seal against her skin and the venom – the euphoria – would hit. It felt like riding an orgasmic high as Adora began to actually suck and drain her, making her lightheaded but *content*. She would purr, totally lost in the throes of ecstasy as Adora moaned, relief at finally feeding giving her pleasure in turn. It was *intimate*, a feeling she has known nothing like since.

She *wanted* that tonight. She needed it, too, to prove to herself that Adora really is safe. After what happened last time, Catra needs to do this when Adora is in control and feel her treat her as gently as she used to when not in bloodlust. Now, not only will it be intimate, but it might just be the way to show Adora that she really isn't afraid of her on principle. Catra takes a shaking breath, shifting up a little until she and Adora are face to face. Adora stares at her, awe and surprise blatant on her face. Her eyes search Catra's face like she expects to find a sign that Catra is lying.

Catra swallows and shuffles a little higher up on the bed, lining herself up, and then tilts her head back to expose her throat. It takes a moment, but Adora sucks in a sharp breath when she realizes what Catra is offering. Catra feels herself swallow again, knowing how it must cause her throat to bob mere centimeters from Adora's lips. Her fur is prickling in anticipation. Adora doesn't even have to move for her breath to puff hot against Catra's neck, causing her to shiver in anticipation.

"Please, Adora. You know I always liked it. I need to feel you again," she manages, her voice strained. Conflicted or not, Catra has come more than once from having Adora's fangs in her neck, pumping euphoria in her veins. They never talked about it after the first time, where Adora tried to awkwardly assure her that it wasn't a big deal and that she knew her venom could cause a reaction while Catra just vehemently hissed at her to *shut the fuck up*.

Adora dropped it, but Catra silently assured herself that Adora *got it* whenever it happened after that. Adora certainly seemed to hold onto her neck longer afterwards, no longer drinking but certainly

pretending so she had a reason to keep holding her while she came down. She never let go until Catra's fur was no longer standing on end, keeping her wrapped in her arms even once she released her neck, gently guiding her to lie in their bed.

Catra wants that again. *Now*. Adora leans forward. Catra's fur stands on end, her synapses firing in overdrive in anticipation of the pain and then the wave of pleasure to come, but it *doesn't*. Gently, feather soft, Adora presses a whisper of a kiss against the side of her throat, right over the two bite scars. Catra feels herself whine, her thighs clenching as her body seeks the pleasure it was expecting.

"Adora, dont make me beg. Show me youre in control," Catra manages. She doesnt know what else to say. Adora has quickly taken her peace offering and ruined her with it, leaving her insides sparking with heat but nothing to cool it with and certainly nothing to *meet* it. Adora's breath stutters against her neck, her lips parting in the process, and Catra keens when she feels Adora's fangs brush against her, out and ready despite how she is holding back.

Catra angles her head further back, presses herself up against Adora's fangs. She feels Adora's answering moan vibrate through her throat. Her fangs are points of pressure against her skin, sharp and threatening, but still not piercing. Adora pulls back just a few centimeters and Catra whines pathetically. She cant say more. After a lifetime of being watched and listened to, hurt for any deviation, she only knows how to take action to prove her feelings. Words were never safe with Shadow Weaver's hearing.

"I dont want to hurt you, Catra. You dont need to do this. You dont have to prove anything," Adora murmurs, an edge of caution to her voice. Every word brushes her lips against Catra's neck. Despite the quiet rejection, liquid desire is pooling between her legs and she gasps at the sensation of Adora's lips on her, her legs shifting restlessly as she seeks *relief*.

"I need you in me. I miss it. I miss you. *Please*. Youre not a monster for it. It makes me feel good," Catra manages. She is begging

outright now, her previous words be damned, but the way it makes Adora release a shuddering groan is worth it as she finally, *finally*, parts her lips and bites down. Catra gasps out, vaguely aware of her tail lashing as her body stiffens.

It doesn't hurt as much as she remembers. There is a spike of pain, a dull warning that her body barely registers as Adora's fangs press into her, but the next second the venom releases. Adora's fangs sink in and all Catra feels is ecstasy flooding her veins. She moans, loud and desperate, an intense heat flaring between her legs and quickly reaching a fever pitch as Adora begins to drink now, gentle and slow.

Maybe it is because she has actually fed recently – maybe she is just trying to be delicate with Catra after so long without fangs in her neck. Adora is definitely more in control than usual. Catra is vaguely aware of one of her hands dropping to caress her thigh. She doesn't even pause to think about it as she lets her thighs fall open, invitation blatant despite how she can't imagine this euphoric high getting better. It *does*, though, when Adora's hand moves to touch her through her shorts. Catra is too far gone to register what she is doing beyond the wave of pleasure the touch sends through her.

She moans, muscles tensing and shaking for a long moment before she goes utterly limp beneath Adora's fangs. She is crying out, she realizes, the sustained orgasm drawing desperate noises from her as Adora keeps *going*, keeps touching her, keeps drinking in long but slow pulls. Adora always tried to do this fast, so guilty over hurting Catra, but it turns out *slow* is a high that has tears running down her cheeks as she loses all feeling but burning pleasure.

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Adora has felt Catra come before, completely surrounded by her and *inside* her, but it's different this time. This time she knows it isn't just

endorphins. This time, Catra is choosing it. She isn't just deciding what time Adora will feed on her, but choosing to undergo it at all. She doesn't have to do this. Adora has told her as much and has blood in just the other room. Catra is doing this because she wants to – she wants *Adora*.

She lets Adora truly touch her for the first time and Adora gets to know that *she* brought her over, not just some venom that is hardwired to turn her limp and blissful. Adora is careful, hardly drinking at all. That isn't the point. The point is the connection and ecstasy. She still drinks – Catra's taste on her tongue is enough to make her dizzy and moan with pleasure herself – but Catra has only recently healed and Adora doesn't want to drain her any more than she can handle.

Adora never wanted to hurt her. From what Catra said, she thinks part of the reason that she wants this is to prove that to herself as well. She stops drinking once Catra gets off, just holding onto her for a moment and panting through her nose despite how she shouldn't need to do it. It lets her draw in the scent of Catra's pleasure, luxuriating in the moment before she reluctantly retracts her fangs, leaving behind two puncture wounds right by the scar tissue of the turning bite.

Adora laps her tongue against her neck, squeezing her eyes shut and moaning as she cleans up the spots of blood that well up in the short delay before Catra's body closes over the wounds. Adora was too lost in the bliss to really notice it at first, but now she registers that Catra's taste has changed. Or at least, she thinks it has. Seven years could be playing tricks on her memory, or it could be from when she turned, but her taste seems sweeter than before. The difference doesn't really matter though – it still has Adora licking her lips as the wounds quickly scab over.

She carefully wraps her arms around Catra and pulls back to look her in the eye. Catra looks *wrecked*. She is utterly limp, her eyes closed and lips parted as she pants. Her purr rumbles loudly throughout the room. Her claws are flexing weakly, like she *wants* to

knead but just doesn't have the energy, and she has a satisfied smile on her face as she nuzzles into the pillow. Adora knows she is smiling fondly to herself too as she shifts to carefully rearrange Catra's body until she is lying on her back with her arms at her sides so her claws don't risk catching anything important.

"I'm going to get you water. Don't try to move. It's been awhile, you won't be able to bounce back as fast," Adora tells her, her voice soft and fond as she bends forward to press a kiss to Catra's forehead. Catra releases a small *mrphh* in the midst of her purr, nudging up into Adora's touch a little. It is the closest that she is going to get to an acknowledgement right now. Adora doesn't want to leave Catra at all, but she needs to take care of her as best she can. Aftercare is important following a feeding.

She tries to hurry when she slips from the bed, rushing to the kitchen and fixing a glass of water quickly. She doesn't have a good snack lying around to help Catra bounce back. She really should, but she hadn't anticipated feeding on anyone, much less *Catra*, so she hasn't thought about needing supplies to help replenish afterwards. She returns to the bedroom with just the glass, setting it on the nightstand and then climbing into the bed.

She sits up with her back against the wall, carefully sliding her hands beneath Catra and lifting her up so she can lean back against Adora's chest, her arms firmly wrapped around Catra's waist to keep her upright. Catra lets herself be repositioned with her eyes half-lidded, watching lazily and still purring. She accepts the water gladly when Adora brings it to her lips, not trusting Catra's arms to be strong enough to hold the glass right afterwards.

Adora could swear her body could tell that her prey wouldn't fight her and didn't release as much venom, but it still takes a while for the weakened muscles to come back to life. Catra drinks most of the glass before she wrinkles her nose the next time that Adora tries to offer it to her. Adora decides it has to be good enough, setting the drink on the nightstand and guiding them to lay down again. Catra trills happily, nudging further into her arms.

She seems blissed out and happy. All the earlier tension of the fight is gone as she curls around Adora and goes limp. Her purr is still rumbling loudly, making Adora grin as she bends down and carefully kisses each of her ears. Catra flicks her ears playfully, lightly smacking Adora in the face. It just makes her kiss them more. Catra certainly doesn't seem to mind the attention, though.

"Going to sleep now?" Adora prompts, her voice soft. They need to talk more, probably, but Adora feels a lot better between the talk and the sorta-sex. Catra gives a soft noise of acknowledgement as she rubs her cheeks against Adora.

"Be here when I wake up?" she asks, the request mumbled out against her shoulder. She already sounds half asleep. Adora draws in a sharp breath, tightening her arms around Catra.

"Of course," she promises. She doesn't know if Catra stays awake long enough to hear it.

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Catra wakes up in Adora's arms. She didn't think that she wouldn't, but she still purrs and rubs her face all over every part of Adora that she can reach. Adora barely manages to hold back a coo, the sound starting and then dying in her throat as she happily tilts her chin back to let Catra snuggle up how she likes. Catra is just feeling happy. Last night didn't go how she planned at all, but it was likely long overdue, and the final outcome ended up being what she wanted.

Adora took care of her. She was gentle with her. She didn't lose herself, or take too much, and she made her feel incredible. It was even better than she ever remembers it being, likely because Adora didn't actually need it and so didn't end up taking very much. A quick stretch of her limbs confirms for Catra that she feels fine this

morning. She is the kind of tired that only truly comes from sleep contentment that you don't want to break the spell of, but that's definitely not a negative in her book.

"How do you feel?" Adora asks her just like she has every other morning since they found each other again, tucking her chin down to drop a kiss into Catra's hair. Catra purrs her response, blinking slowly at Adora as she smiles. Adora clearly likes that answer, grinning to herself as she reaches up to pet through Catra's hair.

"I know you have stuff to do at night, but I really like waking up with you," Catra decides, wriggling her way down the bed a little so she can pillow her head on Adora's chest. She happily rubs her cheek there for a moment before she looks up again and finds Adora still watching her with soft eyes and a touched expression.

"I could come and get in bed around dawn so we can wake up together. I like cuddling," Adora proposes. Catra's eyes flutter closed as she purrs loudly. That sounds perfect, actually. She has Melog for during the night – vaguely, she is aware that they are now curled up at the foot of the bed, having returned while she was sleeping – but she likes waking up in Adora's arms. It just feels right. Adora seems pleased by Catra's happiness, but Catra watches an edge of worry creep into her gaze.

"Does that mean you're staying? Even after you heal up?" Adora asks, her voice quiet and soft, like she is afraid of saying it loud enough to be overhead. She sounds *hopeful*. Catra blinks at her, surprised. Of course it does. There's no reason to be hopeful, Catra assumed her *staying* was a given long before last night.

"Melog got my suitcase once I was strong enough for them to leave for a reason, Adora," Catra points out, not exactly saying it directly, but of course she is staying. Adora draws in a breath, hope flaring in her eyes and dancing along with happiness. She shifts the hand in Catra's hair, cupping the back of her head as if to hold her close instead of petting her.

"I mean, you have other stuff too, right? I wasn't sure if you would be going back to your own place after a few days. I want you here, though. And I'm sure the family won't mind you staying," Adora tells her, cradling her carefully. In Catra's mind, there was almost never a doubt that she would be staying, but Adora's words are a stark reminder of how much Adora doesn't know yet of her last seven years.

"I don't have other stuff. Or a place. I've never stayed anywhere long enough to get one. If it won't cause issues, I want to stay," Catra admits, nuzzling in a little to hide in Adora's tits so she doesn't have to see her reaction to that. Yes, Catra has been homeless for seven years, but she doesn't want pity. She *does* want snuggles, and Adora hugs her tightly in response, squeezing her close.

"There's nowhere else I'd rather you be," Adora tells her, her voice soft. Catra softens in her arms. The feeling is mutual.

Chapter End Notes

Back-to-back updates so I can get this fic off my plate and focus on NaNoWriMo.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> CW: next-to-last scene contains some more gruesome stuff, but nothing that much worse than what has already been in the fic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora watches Catra eat breakfast at the kitchen table, occasionally purring to herself, feeling even lighter than on the day that she first moved into the cottage. On that day, Adora couldn't imagine feeling any better as Glimmer showed her around a new home she could call her own, finishing with a tour of the fridge, where blood was already waiting for her. For the first time in her life, Adora felt assured that not only was she safe, but other people were safe from her. Today is more than that, because now she isn't just safe, but *happy*.

Catra is clearly aware that Adora is staring at her. She is being pretty blatant about it. Occasionally, Catra glances up and gives a quiet purr of amusement before returning to her meal. She doesn't seem to have any issue with how smitten Adora is watching her. Adora doesn't think she could ever forget last night, no matter how many times they do something similar in the future. It was incredible to wrap around Catra and touch her as she was greeted with her taste on her tongue again.

She glances down at Catra's breakfast. It's the last of the first dish that Glimmer and Bow brought over. They'll have to go to the grocery store and do some real shopping today, but Adora isn't really thinking about that. She is more focused on what Catra is eating right now. She doesn't know the names of some of the dishes that Catra had when they were kids, but none of them looked like this. Catra tasted different last night and diet can affect that.

Adora still likes her taste, of course, it's just odd how much she thinks that it changed. She can't tell if time is playing tricks on her or if it really is as different as she thinks. It could have something to do with her turning, but Catra said she purged the vampire venom from her system, so shouldn't she taste the same? It must just be her diet. She is eating what she likes now, no longer forced to just deal with whatever Shadow Weaver got her, and somehow that has sweetened her blood.

"Hey , frowny face, what's going on over there?" Catra cuts into her thoughts, her tone amused. Adora startles, her eyes snapping up to meet Catra's. She realizes she was almost glaring at Catra' s plate as she lost herself in deep thought. Despite Catra seeming amused, her eyes are bright and inquisitive. Her ears are trained forward too. She is concerned by Adora zoning out suddenly . Adora scrambles for something to say, because she *really* doesn't want Catra to think she is complaining about her taste.

"We're going to run out of food soon. We need to find a time to go grocery shopping," Adora replies, because it' s a reasonable excuse for staring at her plate, and it is something that they need to do. Catra relaxes, shrugging a little as she spears another bite on her fork.

"You in a grocery store? I'd like to see it. We could go tonight. Just don't be too obvious about the fact that you don't know what an apple is," Catra replies, smiling a little as Adora lets out an indignant snort. Okay, she knows she is clueless about food dishes, but she can identify basic produce.

"I know what an apple is! They're red and sometimes green. Micah likes them," Adora replies. Catra chuckles softly to herself at that, shaking her head. Apparently that didn't help.

"See, no human would ever say that. Don't worry your pretty little head about what I'm getting, you just need to push the shopping cart," Catra tells her . Adora inexplicably finds herself blushing, ducking her head a little with embarrassment and passing it off as a

nod. She cant help it. She was always flustered when Catra called her pretty before, even if it was rare and only ever in passing moments like this. Saying something so bold directly would have resulted in punishment if they were overheard.

"I'll try not to alert the humans," she responds, too flustered to come up with anything else. Catra grins back.

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Catra slept late, which isn't that surprising given the fact that she was up for most of the night. After breakfast, she finally drags her suitcase into the bedroom and unpacks while Adora watches, leaned against the doorway and grinning. There are parts of the bedroom that are dusty, showing how little Adora uses the room, but the dresser is well taken care of. Adora has racked up a decent wardrobe in the last few years – it is certainly more expansive than Catra's – but there is still room for her things.

Catra has been hauling the same ratty suitcase around for the last three years, ever since the handle broke off her last one. The bag before that got stolen at a bus station. It has been a rough-and-tumble few years. Finally unpacking her bag, knowing that she has no intent of packing it back up, feels strangely emotional. Catra turns her back to Adora as she bends down to her suitcase, pretending to root around in it for a moment just to orient herself while Adora can't see.

It doesn't work. Adora pushes off the wall and crowds behind her. When Catra swallows and straightens up, it is right into Adora's arms. Catra can't believe she's starting to cry over *unpacking*, but she quickly tucks herself beneath Adora's chin and draws in a deep breath, trying to calm herself with steady breathing and Adora's

scent. Adora gently shushes her, raising one hand to pet through her hair as she does so.

"You can let it out. Do you want to talk about it?" Adora asks, her voice soft. Right. This looks like a totally random breakdown to an outside observer. Vaguely, Catra is aware of Melog padding up to rub against her legs and encircle her too. They didn't come before because she didn't really *need* moral support, but now that Adora is offering it anyway, they don't want her to outshine them. Catra trails one hand down to absently run her fingers over their ears as she tries to think about what to tell Adora.

"I'm just... used to running, I guess. I haven't really unpacked in seven years," Catra admits, quietly. Even when she had a hotel room or somewhere else to stay for a few weeks, she kept her things packed up as much as possible in case she had to run. Now that she has found Adora and a little country cottage, somewhere *safe*, there is no more running. Should a threat come, she has to not outmaneuver it, but face it. She isn't really *worried*, she just... isn't used to not having to worry.

"It's safe here, I promise. We can stay here forever if you want," Adora whispers to her, holding her tight. Catra breathes out a soft sigh, nuzzling against her throat. She does want that. Sure, she never pictured herself as *farmer*, but she never really pictured herself as anything else, either. It was always about surviving from day-to-day. She likes the light-filled cottage, and she can't imagine a better setup for Adora. The farm works for her, so Catra is more than happy to stay. It's far better than the isolated, rural house where Shadow Weaver kept them growing up that felt more like a haunted jail than a home.

"I just want to be with you," Catra admits, her voice soft. Adora draws in a sharp breath and then squeezes Catra even tighter in a crushing hug. Catra happily goes limp in Adora's arms, beginning to purr. It's true. With Adora is where she has always been happiest. Unpacking her suitcase has served as an unpleasant reminder of why she always kept it packed, but Adora isn't asking questions. She seems

willing to believe that Catra was just constantly moving to outrun Shadow Weaver.

Catra doesn't want to correct her. She doesn't want to lie to her, but explaining how miserable hunting down leads on reversing the turning process was isn't going to help either of them, and especially not Adora's guilt. Even worse would be explaining what brought that chase to an end. Catra swallows, tucking her face in a little further to Adora's neck. The heart in her chest beats fast, a reminder of everything that Adora does and doesn't know.

Catra loves her. She wants to stay in this house with her forever. She is afraid Adora couldn't love her once she has learned what she has done.

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They pull up to the grocery store shortly before eight o'clock, because Catra takes one look at her parasol and tells her to get a new one if she wants to go anywhere with her while carrying one – which, if Adora's honest, is fair – and the sun is set by then so she doesn't need it anymore. They drive to the grocery store in the dark, Catra snuggled down in the passenger seat. Melog stayed back at the cottage since they would have to wait in the car anyway.

Apparently they are used to Catra having to leave them behind for forays into society, though, so they barely woke up from their nap to mew goodbye when they left. Catra seems tired too. She has her head rested against the car door frame, taking the car ride as an opportunity to rest. Adora steals glances at her whenever she stops at lights. She's adorable, just napping and relaxed without a trace of pain in her body anymore. Adora wants to lean over and kiss her senseless.

If she were walking, the thought would stop her dead in her tracks. As it is, her brain stutters for a moment and she almost misses the entrance to the grocery store parking lot. Despite what they did last night, Adora's mouth as kind of *occupied* and they havent kissed since Shadow Weaver caught them. Adora parks the car with her mind trained on just one thing. Once she has glanced down to check that she remembered the parking brake, she turns to Catra with a singular focus.

.And blinks in surprise at the face she is met with. Catra blinks back at her, raising a brow and seeming confused by her general demeanor. Her sudden focus did come from nowhere, but it has also left just as quickly .

"What' s up with you?" Catra asks with forced carelessness. Adora grimaces a little. Okay, the way she deflated upon meeting eyes with Catra definitely didnt go unnoticed. Adora quickly shakes her head, reaching out and taking Catra's hand so she can twine their fingers together.

"I just remembered we havent kissed yet. But were in public," Adora explains, squeezing her hand. She watches Catra quickly flush, shifting a little in her seat. The spark of excitement in her eyes is unmistakable and it makes Adora's breath catch.

"I dont mind PDA," Catra responds, her tone flustered almost to the point of grumbling, but she is peeking up at Adora hopefully. Adora's mind stutters, but after a moment she shakes her head. She has to think about how to phrase this. She doesnt want to make it seem like she is shallow, it just almost feels like cheating to kiss Catra like this.

"I dont either . That's not what I meant. You're just.. not *you* right now, and I want you to be yourself for our first kiss after so long," Adora explains. Catra stares at her . If she were in her preferred form, Adora is certain her ears would have twitched. Adora bites her lip. "Not that I dont want to kiss you like this! If you're comfortable with

it, we can do it right now, I just thought. I don't know , it seemed like it should be with you how you like to be," Adora hurries to say .

The last thing that she wants is for Catra to think that she doesn't want her when she is fully human. That would be weird if it were true, honestly, but Adora does feel weird about kissing her like that, at least right now. Maybe after they have settled in a bit together, but the girl that Adora fell in love with has ears. Catra is still the same person no matter the form she takes, of course, but she looks different enough that it really does feel like cheating. Catra blinks at her for a long moment before she ducks her head, her cheeks red.

"Now I *really* want to kiss you, but okay, well wait until we get home," Catra tells her. Adora perks up. She really wants to kiss Catra too.

"The moment we're through the door ," Adora promises her . Catra snorts and rolls her eyes as she finally reaches for the car door handle, but Adora isn't exaggerating.

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Adora waits until she has placed the shopping bags down before she carefully backs Catra against the counter with heat burning in her gaze. Catra grins, her tail lashing behind her as she tilts her chin up to meet her before Adora can take the initiative and kiss her first. Catra shifted back as they were pulling up to the house and Adora, despite keeping her eyes on the road, was instantly and obviously interested as Catra's tail thumped against the car seat.

Adora tastes just how she remembered. Of course she does, she doesn't eat so no foreign flavor is ever lingering on her tongue. Catra kisses her eagerly and messily, but Adora isn't much better , nor does she seem to care. Neither of them have much experience with this. They kissed less than a dozen times before the fateful day where

they got caught. It's kind of sad to think that Adora has gotten her off more times than they have kissed, but it's true.

They can correct it. They can correct it *right now*, as the kiss slows and they set on finding the perfect way to fit themselves together. Melog, just emerged from where they were lounging in the bedroom, meows a loud complaint and sets to sniffing at the shopping bag, but Catra has an arm wrapped tightly around Adora's waist now and she isn't letting go or pulling away. For a second it seems like Adora wants to, starting to turn towards the sound, but Catra gives a low growl that makes her groan and Adora promptly forgets about Melog snuffling beside them.

Catra has wanted to do this without having to keep an ear open for someone else approaching since Adora hit puberty and she realized that what she felt for her was more than just friendship. She didn't have a lot to go on – they didn't have much access to pop culture, and none to other people – but Adora made her feel so much. She still does. Catra sighs happily into the kiss as Adora gets a bit bold and begins to take the lead on sliding their lips together.

Maybe they have all the experience of virgin teenagers when it comes to kissing right now, but Catra is more than happy to spend the rest of the evening – and the rest of her *life* – correcting that.

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"What can change the taste of someone's blood?" Adora asks, a vague musing, as she watches Glimmer throw feed out into the chicken pen. Adora is ducked beneath the wide covering at the pen entryway, safe in the shade, even if it's a bit hot out today. Glimmer is trying to get the chickens to run around after the food so they stay healthy, but she abandons her quest to turn around and squint at Adora across the few meter gap between them.

"Uh, diet, their health, the time of day you feed, lots of things? You know this, Adora," Glimmer returns, her tone *suspicious*. Catra is at work right now, Adora having dropped her off that morning. After they spent all of last night and most of this morning making out and roaming their hands over each other, however, Adora has been forced to face reality: the taste of Catra's mouth is hardly different from her memories. There was a little variation from last night to this morning, enough to tell her that any changes she did detect between before and now were real and not imagined.

The taste of Catra's blood seemed to change far more than that of her mouth, and if her memory was consistent for that, then her blood must really taste different from before. Adora wants to ask Catra about it, but she knows that she wouldn't have an answer. She doesn't want her to think that she doesn't like it. Catra definitely still tastes distinct from any other blood she has had—and that's really all she cares about, having a taste that she can tie to her lover—but it is odd to her how different it is now.

"No, like, *really* change it. Werecat blood is savory, and now she almost tastes human. I mean, she still tastes good, don't get me wrong! It's just different, and I don't know if that's because of the ex-vampire thing or..." Adora starts, but she eventually trails off. Glimmer is looking at her with a mix of incredulity and disgust. Right. So, she's on her own with figuring this one.

"Your relationship disgusts me," Glimmer informs her. She doesn't sound genuine. Adora raises a brow at Glimmer. Apparently she doesn't even need to say it for Glimmer to pick up on her thoughts, because Glimmer quickly turns around and returns to distributing feed to the chickens. Yeah, that isn't going to save her. It was earlier *this week* that Glimmer fed on Bow.

"Do you think Bow tastes bad?" Adora asks, her tone snarky and smug. Glimmer growls a little under her breath—not a full growl, like Catra can do, but vampires are pretty good at making unusual vocalizations too—and pointedly doesn't turn around.

"Shut *up*, Adora," Glimmer tells her. The next handful she throws is a little too aggressive and half of it goes sailing over the fence. Glimmer swears under her breath and rushes forward. Adora snorts to herself as she watches her begin battling chickens back from their attempts to go over, under, and through the fence to get the feed on the other side.

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It turns out there are perks to being a higher vampire that they didn't know about when they were constantly kept inside. When Catra looks out the window on Friday morning and wistfully mentions that she and Melog like to go running together, Adora's expression is pinched for a moment before she exclaims that not only can they go, but she can join them. Adora didn't gain the ability to transform into a bat until she finished the inoculation process into higher vampirism, so she hadn't gotten to experiment much with it by the time that Catra was turned. Apparently she can withstand the sun in the form, even if she is still sensitive and prone to sunburns.

Catra has work tonight, so they have to do their run at a time when Adora normally couldn't brave the sun, but her bat form makes it possible for her to join them. Catra goes digging through the dresser and eventually turns up a flannel that has a pocket right over the breast. It definitely belongs to Adora, a little loose in the hips and bust on Catra, but Adora's eyes dilate when she sees Catra in it, so apparently she doesn't mind the rumpled look. For a minute Catra thinks that Adora is going to give up on the walk entirely, but she manages to tear her eyes from Catra and clear her throat, stepping away and heading for the back door. She transforms, immediately taking off from the floor and flying up to meet Catra.

Catra holds her hands out, cupping them and letting Adora settle in her palms. It's strange how very different she is as a bat. Carefully,

Catra gives her belly gentle scritches with one finger, watching Adora happily close her eyes and lean into the touch as she carefully arranges her tiny wings to support herself. To Catra's knowledge, very few werecreatures or otherwise shapeshifting supernatural folk seem to directly correspond to a known species, but Shadow Weaver did research after Adora's first transformation revealed just how unique she is.

Her small nose is curved up at the tip and golden, just like her wings. Her fur is white, giving her a cotton ball-like appearance. The closest bat species Shadow Weaver could find was the Honduran white bat, though their noses were rather different, they're a bit smaller , and their wingspan is shorter in proportion to their body. Before Catra died, Shadow Weaver wasn't able to turn up a record of another vampire transforming into white bat. The ability to transform into bats is limited to higher vampires, and given the only way to become one is to be born a dhampir, bit by another vampire, and survive their likely-stronger magic battling it out with your own, documented cases are rare.

Catra didn't get many opportunities to just enjoy how cute Adora is as a bat. If she was in this form, she was likely trying to master it under Shadow Weaver's direction. Adora seems happy to cuddle up in Catra's hands despite how Melog is waiting impatiently at the backdoor with one paw on the glass. If they really wanted out that badly, they could just open it themselves, but instead they have their head turned back to look at her forlornly as she carefully pets Adora's downy fuzz with her fingers. Adora squeaks quietly , opening her eyes to reveal they have maintained their usual blue, a shocking color on a small bat.

"You've fucking adorable," Catra says, despite herself, as she tucks her hands in to cradle the small bat against her chest. Adora squeaks, once in shock and then a few times in seeming protest as she reaches out and carefully clings onto Catra's shirt. Catra keeps her hands hovered nearby as Adora climbs into her breast pocket and settles down. Catra pulls the top of the pocket open so she can

look down at Adora's little white face peeking up at her. Adora squeaks again, although this time she sounds delighted. Catra grins to herself.

"Alright, Melog, we can go," Catra tells them, finally reaching for the door handle with her other hand. Melog's answering mew sounds exasperated. Catra rolls her eyes as she opens the door and lets Melog step through it first. Against her chest, she can feel the small ball weighing down her shirt that represents Adora. As she walks down the length of the porch, Melog already running ahead and waiting at the bottom of the steps, Catra reaches up and softly strokes Adora through her pocket.

The heartbeat in her chest is going unusually fast. Catra tells herself that it's just from how cute Adora is and not nerves. She doesnt know why having Adora resting right beside where her heart should be feels risky, but it does. It feels like somehow Adora will finally listen to its heartbeat and realize it is wrong. Catra's limbs suddenly feel oddly cold. *It's guilt*, Melog helpfully supplies, along with a plea for them to get running.

Catra is only going to jog today, not wanting to disturb her little passenger too much, but for the moment she just walks and waves Melog on to run ahead and then double back. Melog mews loudly. They want Catra to just tell Adora so they can start running side-by-side as cats together with no worries. Catra rather likes having Adora in her pocket, which necessitates having two legs, but which form she is in is far from Melog's point.

They think she is worrying about nothing. Catra is afraid that if she tells Adora now, she will destroy this small piece of paradise that she has stumbled upon.

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Before taking Catra to work on Friday, Adora asks Glimmer just to be sure that it's okay for Catra to stay on the farm, and she even offers to increase her chores to cover what should be Catra's share since Catra is already working a real job. Glimmer stretches up on her toes to pat the top of Adora's head and assures her that she doesn't need to do extra chores.

"We all knew that Catra was staying anyway from the way you talk about her. She's anti-social enough I doubt her presence will be that noticeable," Glimmer says, rolling her eyes. Adora huffs, pulling a face at her. It is the middle of the day and she is sitting on Glimmer's covered porch swing, which itself is underneath the covered porch. Adora is wearing her sunscreen and well-protected from the sun in preparation for driving Catra out to work in the next hour.

Her usual car has good UV protection treatments, and though the farm's pickup that she is borrowing while she waits for her car to be repaired has the usual run-of-the-mill protection on its windshield, Adora doesn't trust it and she doesn't want to get a sunburn. Catra is back at the house right now and preparing for her shift by napping in the mid-afternoon sunbeam that has been cast onto the rug.

"She isn't anti-social, she just takes awhile to warm up to people," Adora shoots back. Glimmer doesn't seem to buy it and Adora can't argue her point very well when it was always just the two of them growing up. She has no proof that Catra will open up to anyone else, but she thinks that she will. Catra is so sweet and affectionate with her, despite her well-earned defensiveness, that Adora can't imagine her not opening up with time.

Of course there are still things that they need to talk about with each other, so they're definitely a long way from telling anyone else, but Catra is, in passing, starting to paint an undetailed picture of her last few years constantly moving around and chasing any bit of information on vampires she could get in hopes of undoing the process. It was clearly hard on her. She needs to take time to settle down and recover. A quiet vampire farmstead where not much

changes might be the ideal place for her to recuperate. The fact that it's built in a way that is functional for Adora is just a bonus.

When Adora returns home, she feels like her point is proven. Catra is shifted into her full werecat form, a rarity for her before, but she has done it now for a very good reason: to cuddle Melog. The two cats are wrapped around each other almost like a yin and yang symbol, or two interlocked rings. Purring is filling the room despite how the sunbeam has moved on at this point. Their affection and comfort with one another is obvious, and when Adora reaches down to pet Catra's ears, Catra lifts her head and licks her wrist in greeting with a long swipe of her tongue.

The odd, rough sensation sends a little shiver through Adora's body as her mind takes a second to process that it is okay, but she does like it. It's sweet. She looks down at Catra with shining eyes as Catra drops her head back down onto Melog's flank and blinks slowly at her. Adora *is* confident that Catra will warm up to the others, but until then, she is happy to keep her all to herself.

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Adora writes a letter on Saturday. Catra watches her do it with curiosity.

"I know vampires love being antiquated, but you aren't even old enough to be stuck in your ways for letters. You should be clinging to one of those internet services instead," Catra comments as Adora writes. Adora's mouth twists with amusement and she looks up to shoot Catra an exasperated look.

"I'm writing Mara. She lives far away and I've never met her, but she's... my mentor, I guess? She's another higher vampire. She's two hundred and prefers letters," Adora explains, waving her hand in

the air as she turns back to her page. Catra blinks at her in surprise, stepping closer to look over her shoulder at the page. It is filled with Adora's scratchy script, though Catra notices her own name several times. Catra narrows her eyes at it, picking out mentions of her fast recovery from the car accident and that she has moved in with her now.

"Does she care about this stuff? Doesn't she just...teach you how to bat and stuff?" Catra asks, mostly because she is more than a little flustered by how much gushing about her there is on the page. It's weird to think about Adora sending off a letter to some woman she has never met that includes a line about how lucky she feels to see Catra's cute ear twitches in her sleep now. Adora smiles a little as she shakes her head.

"We might be the only two higher vampires alive right now. We're the only two known ones, anyway. We've bonded. She tells me stuff about her wife too. And she'll be glad for the update! I called her on the night that I hit you because I was panicking about how you seemed to be alive," Adora explains. Her pen is already paused a few short centimeters over the page, but her entire body stills when she finishes speaking. After a moment, she turns and looks over her shoulder with wide, curious eyes.

"No. I don't want to talk about it," Catra quickly shuts her down. *Not now*. She isn't fucking ready. It's a weekend afternoon and her day off. She wasn't supposed to do anything today, much less have a breakdown, which will be an inevitable part of them having this discussion. Melog mews a chastisement from the couch and Catra ignores them, her ears pinning back as her gaze fixes on the page with a glare. Adora hesitates. She clearly wants to ask.

"I just want to know if it's had any long-term affects aside from the full moon thing. And...maybe if it could be an option for me-" Adora starts to ask. Catra feels her fur bristle.

"No," she cuts her off, a little too vehement, too *obvious*. Adora's eyes go wide and Catra quickly looks away, her tail lashing behind

her. She doesnt know if it would work for a higher vampire or not, but she does know that it isnt an option for Adora. She’ s too good. Catra growls, frustrated with herself for her obvious reaction. Melog rises from the couch, jumping down and walking over to wind around her legs and assure her. Adora clears her throat.

"Catra, if you dont want to talk about it because it was hard on you, I get that. But... After you left, I had to get food. The humans Shadow Weaver found couldnt *keep up* . Im not- Im not innocent. Ive done even worse than what Ive done to you,"Adora admits, her voice low . Catra’s breath stutters, her ears twitching against the sides of her head. She probably should have guessed that, but fuck, it hurts to hear the guilt in Adora’s voice.

Catra feels like shit for being assured by it, too. Adora has hurt more people than she has, but it’s also a matter of intent: Adora didnt choose *any* of it. The only thing she chose was ending Shadow Weaver, and in Catra’s opinion she did the world a favor there. Catra swallows, her tail lashing behind her. She isnt ready . Assurances aside, she needs to mentally prepare herself for this conversation before she can talk about it.

"Not right now ,"she growls out. Adora nods in her periphery , reaching out for her. Reluctantly, Catra lets Adora’s left hand intertwine with her right, squeezing gently .

"Okay . Whenever youre ready ,"Adora replies, her voice soft. Catra feels a shiver run through her, an odd sensation like a ghost just walked through her causing her tail to puff out. She nods vaguely, looking away. Her gaze lands on the backdoor . It’s the middle of the afternoon. The sun is high in the sky and Adora is stuck inside.

"Im going to take Melog for a walk,"Catra says, wrapping an arm around herself. It’s an excuse to take time to think, but Adora doesnt call her on it. She just squeezes her hand and then lets her go. Catra forces herself to walk at a normal speed to the backdoor, Melog close at her heels and sniffing her with concern. She is grateful when

she gets outside and quickly splits off from the path so she can step out into the sun. It warms the chill in her bones.

A part of her is relieved, reminding her that Adora has done worse. The rest of her whispers back that Adora, at least, didnt have a choice in what she did. Catra growls, dropping to all fours and shaking out her coat as she shifts into her full cat form. She takes off running, Melog following close behind. This is how their runs usually go, but right now, Catra just needs the wind to replace the rushing in her ears. Her head hurts.

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Adora is doing her best not to be anxious. She is pretty sure that Catra fled just because she doesnt want to talk about it for her own reasons. Adora was born to be anxious though, and she cant help but worry if Catra had to leave because she learned what Adora has done. Catra didnt really say anything about what Adora admitted. Her only response was an ear twitch. She didnt look disgusted, Adora reminds herself as she seals the letter in its envelope. Catra really seemed to just be in her head about the whole thing.

Adora knows that she wouldnt judge Catra for anything that she did to free herself of Shadow Weaver, even if the goal was pointless by the time that she accomplished it, but it seems like it's going to be hard for her to talk about it regardless. Mara did call it a *dark proces* . Adora walks up to the main house to drop off her letter with her head spinning. Angella asks her questions about how she and Catra are doing and if she's settling in well, but Adora's mind is distant. She knows Angella can tell, frowning and gently prodding her if everything is alright.

"It has been several years. It might just take a bit for things to settle for you two. You have been through a lot,"Angella gently reminds

Adora when she tries to brush her off. Adora sighs, looking down at her shoes and absently spinning her parasol handle in her hands. She knows that. Honestly, they have gotten further than she was expecting in the last week, both emotionally and physically . She just worries, still, about losing Catra again.

"I just love her a lot. And I worry about not being good enough for her," Adora mumbles. Angella stands from her chair at that, stepping forward and enveloping Adora in a hug that startles her. She wasn't expecting it. In her experience, the only people Angella is touchy with are her family. Otherwise, she tends to be rather formal and withdrawn, even if she has been warming up to Adora over the years. This isn't the first time she has hugged Adora, but it is the hug that has felt the most unnecessary.

Or maybe not, because Adora raises her arms and squeezes Angella back, her chest feeling tight. The hug helps with the tears that want to prick in her eyes all of the sudden. Part of her knows that Catra isn't going to pull away – the rest of her says that everything they have done over the last week was a lie since Catra didn't know even the broad strokes of what pushed Adora to the point where she could make herself attack Shadow Weaver and leave her for dead.

"Adora, you know I consider you family . You're good enough. You're a good *person* . You're more than what that woman made you do. If anyone in the world can understand that, it should be someone else who was raised by her," Angella tells her , her voice gentle. Adora breath catches. Angella is right, at least on the last point. Catra should understand. The reminder of her place on the farm always makes emotion well in her chest as she hugs Angella back just a little tighter.

The words make her feel better, but they still prompt tears in her eyes.

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"One week anniversary of you hitting me with your car ," Catra points out on Sunday morning. They havent gotten out of bed yet. Catra is stretched out on her back with her head in Adora's lap. Adora, leaned against the wall, has a book in her hand that she was reading before Catra woke up and demanded her attention. It's one in the afternoon and they really should get up, but they didnt go to bed until nearly dawn. Adora seemed down when Catra returned from her run and it took a little while for her to perk up, so she didnt start her farm chores until late.

It doesnt matter when they went to bed, though. Catra hasnt gotten up because she isnt feeling well. *Guilt, fear* , Melog unhelpfully supplies. Yeah, she knows, she doesnt need the reminder . The talk yesterday unsettled her. She is trying to bury herself in Adora's lap and forget it all, but she cant stop thinking: would Adora kick her out of the bed if she knew? She shouldnt be able to judge her for a damn thing, but Adora never chose to hurt anyone when she was in her right mind.

"I'm sorry , but I am kind of glad it happened now. It would have been months before I went to Peekablue's and you might not have even been working then. I'm just happy that you're here and okay ," Adora tells her, dropping her free hand to pet through Catra's hair. Catra snorts, turning to nuzzle into the touch. It feels good. She would respond if she were feeling better, but for today, she just lets it slide. She is glad to be back in Adora's bed. Ecstatic, even. She was in a lot of pain for awhile there, but there is nowhere she would rather be now that she is healed. She doesnt want to lose this.

Melog is fed up. They stand from the end of the bed and shake themselves out, turning to pad up to the head of the bed. Adora lifts her hand from Catra's hair to pet them – which is *unacceptable*, but Catra is a bit distracted by Melog themselves right now, so she lets it go. Melog ducks Adora's hand, shaking their ears out as Adora's

fingers brush against them. They refuse the touch, instead lifting their head up and gently taking Adora's wrist in their mouth. They tug it back down towards Catra, but not to pet her hair again.

They guide Adora's hand to her chest, dropping her hand and then pointedly shoving it down into Catra's tits as Adora watches on with obvious confusion. Catra feels her cheeks heat. Melog was aiming for right over where the heart in her chest is beating just a little too fast, but it's not like they have opposable thumbs and they shoved Adora even further off course when they tried to correct her position with the nosing. They are just trying to give them both an obvious hint.

"Uh," Adora says, a question more than anything else, as she glances between her hand, Melog, and Catra's face. Oh fuck. Catra can tell from the look on Adora's face that her thoughts have turned dirty. She thinks Melog was trying to give her a hint about what Catra wants. Absolutely not. Melog finds their passion for each other excessive. They understand why and how Catra loves Adora and in many ways they feel the same about her, but the physical reaction Adora elicits in Catra just cant translate to magic mud, apparently. Melog is likely never going to encourage them to get handsy.

"They were trying to show you my heartbeat," Catra explains, because she can pass that off as a *hey, Im alive now* thing and it's frankly easier to explain than her familiar encouraging her girlfriend to grope her. Adora blinks at her, but after a moment she shifts her hand to lay it over the beating center of Catra's chest. It's hard to tell through her fur, but Adora's hand is lying right over a line of scar tissue, the only scar on her body aside from the two marks on her neck from the turning bite. Catra swears the irregular heartbeat now filling her ears picks up speed in response to the touch. Adora lowers her book with her other hand, setting it down so she can give Catra her full attention.

"Nightmare?" Adora asks softly, her expression anxious as she looks up to meet eyes with Catra. Catra scoffs, shaking her head and looking away. In her periphery, Adora bites her lip, clearly still

concerned. Melog mews loudly, chiding Catra. They want her to stop making herself sick. Catra wants them to shut up. They won't. They nip at Catra's hand, just trying to harass her until she breaks. She scowls at the wall. There's no point in talking about it. It isn't going to fix anything, and worse yet, it may break *them*.

"What do you need, Catra?" Adora asks, softly, fanning her fingers out in the fur on Catra's chest so she can press her palm tightly against her and feel her blood pumping. Melog isn't able to tell Adora what they think she should ask about, but they can make it clear something is wrong. Catra can't even come up with a placating lie because Melog can just keep complaining and make it obvious that she's lying. Catra sighs, glaring at the window.

"I'm not going to judge you, Catra. You know the things that I've done," Adora responds, quietly, apparently having picked up on the topic of conversation. It's just a logical conclusion after their talk yesterday. Catra swallows. Yeah, she does, but she still doesn't want to say it. Melog isn't convinced that she will work up the courage to, but they drop down to lay beside her and rest their head on top of her legs as a comforting weight, reminding her that she will always have them even if she loses Adora.

"It took me five years, but I found a witch. She made me a filter of garlic to pass my blood through like dialysis. It would make the vampire venom clot while the rest passed through it so I could filter it out. She made me Melog so their magic could sustain me once the venom was gone, but... my heart was still dead," Catra asks, her voice barely above a whisper. Adora draws in a sharp breath, probably as she realizes just how bad this could be. A moment later, her hand shifts from Catra's shoulder to her hair and her other hand comes up to replace the one at her shoulder. Catra doesn't really think she deserves comfort right now.

"She sent me on my way. I knew what to do, but not how to fix the heart problem. Or the fact that I would die from lack of blood with so much filtered out once I got rid of the vampire venom," Catra continues. She thinks, truly, that Madame Razz believed she would

find some kind of peaceful solution. The old woman was weird and eccentric, but kind. Catra's research, however, turned up just one solution. It was a solution she had found before, but it always ended in failure or death without the venom purged and a magic source to replace it. With Raż s help, it could finally work.

"I needed a beating heart, and blood. I didn't want to hurt anyone, Adora, I really didn't," Catra whispers, her voice distraught. Adora's hands leave her and she moves in the bed. Catra feels fear quivering in her lungs. For a moment she is afraid that Adora is going to *leave*, but then Adora slides down in the bed, pressing against her back and throwing an arm around her, squeezing her tight.

"When I attacked Shadow Weaver, I told myself it was one sacrifice and then I wouldn't have to hurt anyone else. Just one, and then everyone else is safe," Adora breathes to her. Catra squeezes her eyes shut, nodding jerkily. It's how she justified it to herself too. She hadn't hurt any humans yet, but the wildlife she had killed had souls too. Sometimes she was afraid of damaging the fucking ecosystem with overhunting when she stayed somewhere too long, and she never knew when she would finally need blood bad enough that she snapped and attacked an innocent.

"I wasn't sure what I was going to do, but eventually I saw the signs of werelizard attacks in a news report. I figured someone attacking random people and risking exposure of the whole community needed to be handled. I talked to him first. He wasn't going to stop," Catra continues. She was desperate by that point. She was pretty sure she was getting close to snapping and attacking a human anyway. If she was going to hurt someone, she wanted to do it just once and know that it never had to happen again.

It helped her guilt that Tung Lashor was an asshole when she eventually found him. And an idiot. When she spoke to him, he saw no reason why the rest of the community should be his concern. He just had a grudge against the people he attacked shortly after being bitten and gaining the ability to shift. When he was fed up with the

conversation, he tried to fight her. He probably thought that Catra would back off since she already knew that he had hospitalized two people, but he didn't know her true intentions.

"If it hadn't been you, it would have been a hunter. I've- I've been working for years to come to terms with the fact that sometimes you just have to pick the lesser evil. My job in the coven is stopping people like that now," Adora tells her, softly. Those are the words that make Catra finally cry. Adora shushes her, not trying to silence her, but instead calm her. Melog crawls up so Catra can cling to them tightly, Melog in her arms and Adora at her back. For several long minutes, Catra just buries her face in Melog's fur and silently cries.

She isn't up to continuing. Adora can fill in the gaps. She did the ritual, filtering her blood and replacing what was needed with his. Her advanced vampire senses told her that he was a blood type match even before she got close enough to speak with him. Ripping out her own heart and replacing it with another wasn't easy, but it took less than a minute. Any longer and the wounds in both their chests would have closed over thanks to their healing factors. Melog watched over her, sharing their magic with her. They helped her through the ritual and were her rock afterwards.

Adora doesn't ask for more details. She hugs Catra tightly and whispers *it's okay, I'm here* to her as she cries, finally letting out the trauma of having taken a fucking life. Catra wants to say it isn't okay, because it certainly doesn't feel like it, but Adora killed someone for the first time seven years ago, and she is managing to make it through the day now. Catra still loves her despite what she has done. She has to believe Adora can feel the same way about her.

"I love you. You did what you had to," Adora assures her, quietly. Catra draws in a sharp breath, causing Adora to pause and seem to realize what she said. After a moment, she blows out a breath. "I do. I always did. I knew whatever you did had to be dark, Catra. You ended your need for blood and stopped someone who would have kept hurting people. I'm not going to judge you for this," Adora assures, softly stroking one hand down her side. Catra swallows.

The entire operation was brutal, and it left a scar. Hearing Adora say that it doesn't make her a monster helps though. Adora struggles with similar things. They really are a traumatized pair, but at least they understand each other. Catra takes a deep, slow breath, trying to calm the rapid beating of the foreign heart in her chest. Sometimes she feels like it is more reactive than her old one. Other times she knows that is impossible, and it's more likely that nearly six years of being dead made her forget what having a heartbeat was like.

"I love you too. I don't care what you had to do," Catra whispers, screwing her eyes shut. Does that make her a bad person? Probably, but Adora killed *her* and she forgave her still, so it would be pretty spectacular if she held a grudge on her for being forced to do the same thing to others too. Adora draws in a sharp breath, and then she's crying too.

Yeah, they're both messes, but at least they have each other.

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When Catra finally tells her what she did, Adora knows two things: the process isn't an option for her if it would even work for a higher vampire, and she doesn't give a shit about what Catra did. It's always traumatic to hurt someone like that – hell, it has to be traumatic to hurt *yourself* enough to swap out your fucking heart – but Catra did what she could to minimize the damage. Adora would rather Catra be around than a werelizard on a rampage, and if that makes her a bad person, then she can live with it.

She can live with a lot as long as she has Catra, it turns out. Now that they have cleared the air, Adora's guilt has eased. It will take a long time for it to go away completely, if it ever happens, but after a few days she finds her thoughts are lighter than they were before.

She feels less consumed with the past now that she knows what is in it isn't going to drive Catra from her. Catra seems to feel the same. It takes a few days – reliving a trauma like that understandably brought her mood down – but she starts brightening, and soon it feels like the old Catra that she knew is back, laughing and joking with her.

Neither of them are carefree, but they weren't as children either. They have a lot of trauma, but it is in their pasts, at least. They aren't living in it every day like they once were. Now they spend their days on the farm, Adora slowly beginning to show Catra how things work when she accompanies her at night and occasionally lends an extra hand. Adora holds Catra while she sleeps, and manages to cajole her into actually reading – and even reluctantly enjoying – a book or two. She drives Catra to work, and she kisses her goodbye before she jumps out of the car.

Finding a balance – and a good time for Catra to sleep – is surprisingly difficult. Adora never sleeps, but she is a largely nocturnal creature to avoid the sun. If Catra sleeps at night, then she sleeps through the hours when Adora can go out with her. Conversely, most places are closed that late, Catra has work during the daytime and evening, and Adora still *can* get around the farm during the day. They just kind of wing it for a few days until Catra decides that splitting things and going to sleep in the early morning hours, when there's still a bit moonlight left but she and Adora have had a few hours together to go out, is best.

As long as she doesn't have a morning shift, it works with her job. She wakes up in the late morning or early afternoon and has plenty of time to enjoy the sunlight still. Adora is happy to climb into bed with her in the morning, sometimes with a book or her phone and sometimes with nothing but Catra's breathing to entertain her, and they cuddle together while Catra sleeps so she can wake up with Adora right there. She seems to just like it, but Adora hopes it eases nightmares too. Catra definitely gets them, even if the most she tend to say about them is a reluctant, "I didn't sleep well."

Adora doesnt need her to elaborate. She understands her . Talking about the trial that Catra went through feels like knocking down the last barrier standing between them. Maybe it's just that Adora's reaction reinforced the trust between them. From Adora's end, now she understands Catra better, and she feels more understood too given their almost-shared experiences. None of it is the kind of thing that is fixed overnight, but they have decades – hell, centuries – together to work it out and heal.

Micah told her, early after escaping Shadow Weaver, that healing always takes times. He was referring to her slowly healing over hurting Catra and losing her then, but now they can heal *together* . They dont have to fit their broken parts together , two traumatized children clinging to each other. Instead they can grow as one, their branches intertwining as they both reach towards the light.

Okay, maybe Adora has been reading too much lovestruck poetry lately, but it was for research. She wants to start writing it about Catra. She has all the time in world to master the craft. She stands by the sentiment.

Chapter End Notes

The fic notes are now up on my tumblr. Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!